



NUMENÉRA™

VERTICES

By Sean K. Reynolds



NUMENÉRATM

VERTICES

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INTRODUCTION



Datasphere, page 355

Abhuman, page 13

Welcome to *Vertices*, a sourcebook full of new Ninth World locations your player characters (PCs) can discover and explore. Each of these locations has a connection to the [datasphere](#), the mysterious information network that surrounds and permeates the world. Specifically, each site is a vertice—a place where creatures from the physical world (the real) can transcribe (upload or download) themselves to or from the datasphere. The PCs may not know that a particular location is a vertice, or even what a vertice is. Their reasons for visiting the place might be entirely unrelated, and the datasphere connection may be a complete surprise and an opportunity to take the campaign in a new direction.

The material in this book is enhanced if you have *Voices of the Datasphere*, the sourcebook on the datasphere and its inhabitants. However, that book is not required to use this one, and you can enjoy all the locations in these pages without knowing anything about the datasphere other than the [basic information](#) in *Numenera Discovery* and what is explained here. On its own, *Vertices* details eight unique locations, plus additional supplementary material you can add to any Numenera campaign.

HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

This book is for you, the game master (GM). To help you get started, here's a quick summary of the material covered in this book.

Part 1: Locations begins with an exploration of the unusual nature of these ruins (each is a vertice, a place with a connection to the datasphere), the three powerful entities vying for control of the sites, and how to read the

location entries. Following this first chapter are eight unique locations for PCs to explore, each with its own numenera quirks and treasures.

Part 2: The Numenera describes new cyphers and artifacts the PCs can find or salvage from these locations (or potentially anywhere else in the Ninth World).

Part 3: Creatures and Characters gives game stats for new creatures (including a melting reptilian [abhuman](#) called a nalkor and three godlike voices) and a couple of dozen non-player characters (NPCs) that can be used as allies, foes, or minions of the PCs.

Part 4: Additional Resources includes a random settlement generator to help you quickly rough out a camp, fort, or village where the PCs might rest and hear interesting rumors, as well as a glossary of the datasphere terminology used in this book.

This book introduces a lot of new game terms and in-world terms relating to the datasphere; be sure to check out the glossary on page 96.



Numenera Discovery



Numenera Destiny

Throughout this book, you'll see page references to various items accompanied by these two symbols. These are page references to *Numenera Discovery* and *Numenera Destiny*, respectively, where you can find additional details about that rule, ability, creature, or concept. Often, it will be necessary to look up the reference to find information you need. Other times, it's not necessary, but looking it up can deepen your experience and understanding of the game and the setting.

PART 1:



LOCATIONS



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EXPLORING THE VERTICES



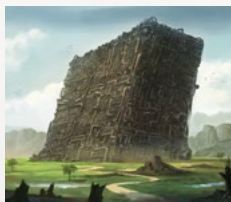
Bodrov, page 138

Westwood, page 137

Datasphere, page 355

Glimmer, page 43

*Canted Pipes of Vnaar,
page 16*



One idea for a one-shot datasphere adventure is to use a 21st-century videogame level as an area to explore. To keep the players from recognizing the original source, just reskin the environment (such as swapping water for fire and vice versa), replace its programmed enemies with appropriate bestiary creatures, and perhaps confuse things by rotating the PCs' orientation in the rooms so they are walking on what would normally be the walls or ceiling.



Cyphers, page 272

*Experience points,
page 122*

Part 1 is the main focus of the book, with eight locations ready to drop into any Numenera game, complete with room descriptions, inhabitants, and things to discover. For example, if the PCs stop at a village between *Bodrov* and the *Westwood*, the villagers can tell them about the strange, angled prior-world ruin—the *Canted Pipes of Vnaar*—said to be beyond a nearby ridge.

In addition to being a physical area the player characters (PCs) can explore, each of these sites is a connection to the *datasphere*, which the characters might be able to use to enter or exit that digital realm, or perhaps just to download useful information or experience a *glimmer* that inspires their next course of action.

Overall, how these sites fit into the campaign is up to you. Here are a few suggestions:

- A non-player character (NPC) sends the characters to the site in search of salvage or a specific item.
- Rumors about the ruin from people in a nearby settlement get the PCs interested in exploring it.
- The PCs need *cyphers* and *experience points* (XP) before they're ready to deal with a major stage of the campaign, and they seek out (or happen to find) the site along the way.
- A *glimmer* (perhaps sent by a voice) suggests that something the PCs want is at the site.

- Rival explorers accidentally reveal that something very valuable is at the site, and the PCs need to get there before their rivals do.
- The PCs want to enter the *datasphere* and know the site might have a vertice.
- The PCs are followers of a voice and are told to wrest control of the site from another voice.

Most of these locations have only part of the structure mapped and described—typically, the main part that's relevant to the site's name and rumored features. You can leave these rooms empty (perhaps already salvaged or filled with useless ancient debris), or add more features and completely new areas, either with your own planned designs or by using a randomizer like the *Ruin Mapping Engine* in *Jade Colossus: Ruins of the Prior Worlds* or the *Ruin Deck*. These new areas might be lateral to the main structure, underground, in the air (such as on a levitating platform or orbital station), or in a parallel or partial dimension.

Because each of these sites is also a vertice, new areas can expand into the *datasphere* as well. Even a Ninth World campaign that focuses on the physical world can enjoy a brief, weird jaunt into the *datasphere*, such as entering a lifelike simulation with slightly different physical rules, visiting a strange and abstract alien simulation, or something in between.

INFLUENTIAL VOICES

One common thread for the locations described in this book is that they have attracted the attention of three powerful **voices** (godlike entities of the datasphere) named **Aorut**, **Etranv**, and **Isijaan**, who vie for control and influence over these sites. Each voice's nature, interests, and goals are very different, and which one is strongest at a particular vertice affects what goes on there.

By applying their power and influence to a **vertice** site, a voice can subtly enhance or diminish aspects of the numenera there. For example, a voice might increase the level of the automatons in a particular ruin, reduce the damage inflicted by certain hazards there, seal off areas they want to remain undisturbed, or send minions to explore specific rooms. Suggestions for how these three voices specifically change aspects of the vertices described in this book are given for each site.

Voices usually can manifest themselves in the real in a limited fashion through a telepathic message similar to a glimmer, by speaking through an interface panel or an automaton, or (if the datasphere connection is strong) by creating a hologram of themselves that can communicate with images and sounds. However, as entities of the datasphere, these manifestations are just minor projections of the voice's will and attention; their real essence and power lives in the datasphere. If a voice is active at a site, PC explorers are likely to notice their presence—a near-mindless automaton might pause in its path to observe them, a panel or ocular device might activate and turn to face them, or a holographic representation of the voice might flicker into existence and attempt direct communication. In the datasphere side of a vertice, a voice is more likely to send a representative creature or a holographic projection to speak with the PCs directly.

The voices have many minions in the datasphere and the real; these minions include **rival explorers**, groups of suggestible abhumans, people who worship the voice as a god, members of various cults and other **organizations**, self-willed or directly controlled automatons, or datasphere entities transcribed into physical bodies. Any of these minions might already be exploring or fortifying a site, arrive at the same time as the PCs, or show up when the characters are inside—perhaps complicating the PCs' escape or coming to their rescue in exchange for providing a service for the voice.

The voices can potentially be mentors or adversaries for the PCs, just like any influential physical being of the Ninth World, such as a town mayor, wealthy noble, or wise **Aeon Priest**. However, the motivations and plans of the voices are mysterious and complicated, and PC allies might find themselves discarded to serve some greater purpose. Due to the nature of the voices' remote interactions with the real, PCs who want to threaten or destroy one need to enter the datasphere and find the node where the voice lives—and is actually vulnerable.

VOICE VARIANTS

If you aren't using *Voices of the Datasphere* in your campaign, or if you don't want Aorut, Etranv, and Isijaan to be voices, they easily could be powerful aliens (extraterrestrials), creatures from another dimension (ultraterrestrials), or machine intelligences. All of these options allow the three entities to remotely view and interact with the sites. You can also completely ignore these powerful creatures and use the locations in their normal "default" mode.

Rival explorers, page 84

Voices (Aorut, Etranv, Isijaan), page 82



Organizations, page 215

Vertice: A place where transcribing to and from the datasphere is possible. A vertice is a physical location, a dataspace, and a specific kind of numenera installation.



Aeon Priest, page 264

These voices might have interest in other vertices in your campaign, and other voices could likewise attempt to manipulate the real through any vertice.

UNDERSTANDING THE LISTINGS

Every location is presented by name, followed by a standard template that includes the following categories.

Level: Each location has a level attached to it. Unless something else in the text specifies a different level (like a creature or lock), you should use this level for any tasks relating to understanding, activating, or defending against things in the site. In each location's entry, the level is listed in parentheses after its name.

Description: The first paragraph after the site's name and level is spoiler-free text you can read or summarize for the players when they first see the location.

Overview: A short summary of the nature of the site and what's happening there.

Rumors: Several suggestions for ways that the PCs can hear about the location in question.

Common Cyphers: Cyphers that PCs are likely to find in that location. If there is a settlement nearby, these resources might be available there, too. (These are suggestions to help bring PCs here and not a restrictive list of what cyphers can be salvaged from the site.)

Voices: Each site presents ways to change things at the location depending on which voice is active there. For example, if Aorut is strongest, it's likely that NPCs and creatures will tend to be more aggressive or have their attacks eased; or incidental hazards will be more lethal. In most cases, this entry has additional information about the interests and goal of one voice in particular at that site. You should decide which voice is dominant at the site when the PCs arrive.

It is possible for two voices to co-dominate at a site or battle for control for a short while (meaning two voices' changes are in effect), or for all three voices to abandon a site to focus on other areas (which means the site functions as described in the main entry).

You can use this section to make repeat visits to a site more interesting, changing the mood and creating a new experience for the PCs each time they return, especially if their goal is to help a specific voice claim these locations.

Rumors generally come from a settlement near the ruin in question. To quickly create a settlement, use the Random Settlement Generator, page 94.

Having a settlement (page 94) near the site—even one with hostile bandits or abhumans—gives opportunities for the PCs to learn lore about it, get specific goals for exploring it, or encounter rival explorers (page 84).



CHAPTER 2

TANDO'S RIBS

LEVEL 6

 READ ALOUD

A low blue-white synth building has twelve gently curving spires projecting out of the top, to an overall height of six or seven times that of a human. Altogether they look like half of an enormous buried rib cage sticking out of the ground. Each “rib” has dark spots in various places. A nearby rock formation resembles a giant inhuman skull.

Overview: A ruin resembling the weathered bones of an enormous (possibly humanoid) creature. Portions of the interior create an organic-seeming substance that is nutritious and augments size and physical prowess, with long-term side effects. All creatures in the ecosystem near the structure are affected by it, creating larger, stronger animals of all types, including a large number of **yovoki** that live in and near the ruin.

Rumors: Tando was a god who was slain defending the nearby village of Dacrim-So against the iron wind. Tando was a mighty hero who used the numenera to grow to great size and wrestle a monstrous creature. Tando was a ravenous beast who ate numenera to make itself immortal, but was slain by a curse. Tando's remains are a warning to the people of the Ninth World. Tando's marrow turns people into giants and heroes in times of need.

Common Cyphers: **Health resonator**, **rejuvenator**, **strength boost**

Voices: **Aorut** wants whatever numenera (buried within the walls) creates the

marrow so he can understand how to create it elsewhere; he uses machines or living creatures to tear apart the walls in specific ways to reach the marrow source.

Etranv tries to feed marrow to many kinds of creatures to see if it has any unusual effects on them, particularly if the creature is injured. Her minions are likely to bring companion beasts or small caged things for this purpose.

Isijaan changes the color and physical structure of the marrow, forming thin, meaty growths, runny slime, noodle-like grains, or other odd shapes and textures. It might augment the marrow's benefits, make some of it extremely poisonous, or increase how long it remains viable after it leaves the area. (Isijaan apparently knows much more about the marrow than Aorut or Etranv.) It occasionally sends groups of **rival explorers** (particularly individuals like **Sammoz** and **Uduvu**) to sample and harvest non-poisonous marrow for use elsewhere.

Tando's Ribs is a numenera ruin that looks like the half-buried rib cage of a gigantic creature, with the “sternum” visible as the ruin's base (when viewed from the “back” of the structure, underneath the curved spines, it loses its resemblance to a rib cage). The structure is made of pale blue synth; when this material is viewed from an immediate distance, metallic threads can be seen winding across its surface.

Voices (Aorut, Etranv, Isijaan), page 82

Consider placing this site southeast of Thriest in Malevich.



Thriest, page 151



Yovoki, page 261

*Rival explorers, page 84
Sammoz, page 91
Uduvu, page 91*



*Health resonator,
page 182*



Rejuvenator, page 286

*Strength boost,
page 287*



The boulder may have been deliberately shaped long ago to look like a skull in order to match the ribs, then eroded over time, and then carved more recently (perhaps only a few thousand years ago) by an entirely different civilization to restore its skull-like appearance. There may be some device or secret concealed within or under it, undiscovered for ages.

Dark irregular spots are scattered all over the structure but they have the same texture as the blue synth—the discoloration is beneath the surface. They sometimes gently contract or expand (like chromatophores on an octopus’s skin) by about ten percent in response to pressure, impact, or energy. These spots seem opaque from the outside of the structure. Some are transparent from the inside and can be used as windows to look out, and some have no obvious purpose (and don’t correspond to any interior spaces that creatures can access).

The nearby stone formation that resembles an inhuman skull is not part of the structure. Upon closer inspection, visitors can see that it is simply a large boulder, weathered and worn, although portions have been carved with crude tools to enhance its skull-like appearance, and the far side (opposite the ribs) is marred by smaller carvings and paintings of shapes and stick figures. A cave-like depression (an eye socket of the “skull”) is often the lair of climbing or flying animals, all of which are larger than normal because of the marrow (see below).

DATASPHERE CONNECTION

The Holographic Interaction room (area 2) has a constant live connection to the datasphere, although it is not currently enabled for transcribing. A character skilled at crafting numenera could potentially upgrade that area into an installation that can realscribe and datascribe creatures (doing so might require disassembling a vertice at another location and reassembling or incorporating it here). The corresponding datasphere frame looks very similar to the Holographic Interaction room, but is just a part of some other node (in other words, that frame can be part of any node that's useful for your campaign).

The pebbled material in the crack is marrow, and the creature (a **nepp**) is slowly eating it. As long as nobody harms it or comes within striking distance of it, the nepp is content to ignore other visitors and keep scouring the marrow out of the wall crack, which will take it another hour or so. If the exterior door to this chamber is open when it finishes eating, it wanders out.

The miscellaneous debris in the room is from creatures coming in and out or living here when the door opens on its own, and contains nothing of value.

There are two dark panels here, corresponding to the ones on the outside of the structure. Interacting with them (no roll needed) causes them

Nepp: level 4; Might defense as level 6; running, climbing, and jumping as level 6; health 20; Armor 1; damage inflicted 7 points; moves a long distance each round; immune to visual effects

The yovoki have figured out how to open and close the doors in this ruin, although it sometimes takes them a few rounds because they can barely reach the door controls.

SITE LOCATIONS

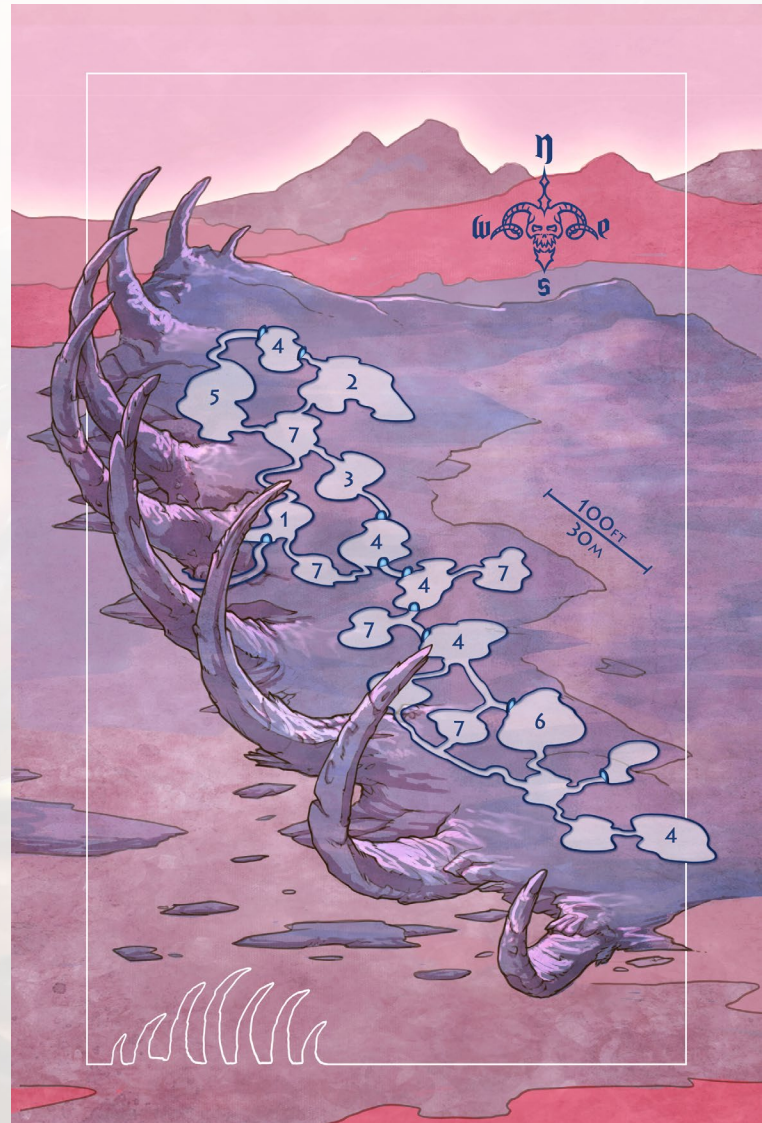
The following are specific locations at this site.

1. ENTRANCE CHAMBER

The door into this chamber isn't visible when closed. Characters can open or close it by activating one of the two nearby dark spots (panels) on the outside of the ruin, causing the door to appear and iris open. The door sometimes opens on its own, remaining so for one to three days at a time, which allows wild creatures, yovoki, and curious visitors to roam about the structure; many of the rooms on the map are used as temporary lairs by these creatures.

READ ALOUD

The inside of the ruin is made of the same pale blue synth as the outside. The walls curve sharply to meet the floor and ceiling. On the north wall is a crack as wide as a hand, with dark blue pebbled material within it. The crack is partially covered by the gently undulating form of a brown, hairy rug-like creature. The entire room smells vaguely of fresh meat. Leaf debris, small animal bones, and other natural items from outside litter the floor.

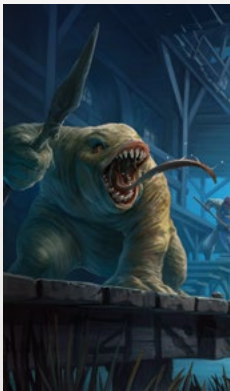


Roe: clusters of eggs from fish or other sea creatures, such as caviar

The “ribs” connect along the central part of the ruin; rooms in those areas may extend up into the rib for 10 to 30 feet (3 to 9 m) before tapering to a pointed ceiling.

Yovoki and nepps don't like how each other taste, so they don't prey on each other. Although nepps aren't tame, the yovoki allow them in the ruin because they sometimes kill other intruders.

Nepps, page 11



Abhuman, page 13

Yovoki, page 261

THE MARROW

At various places within the ruin, the synth coating of the walls cracks open, revealing a dark blue, pebbled substance that resembles *roe* and smells slightly meaty. This rubbery material—the marrow—is edible and can be scraped or chiseled out with little effort. Most veins of marrow are only about 1 to 2 feet (30 to 60 cm) long and 2 inches (5 cm) deep. The marrow replenishes itself over several weeks, although a vein that is fully emptied usually closes for several months. (The marrow is not behind all the walls; it appears only in the locations noted in this chapter.)

The marrow is moderately tasty, and is very nutritious and sustaining for any creatures that eat flesh or plant matter (equivalent to an equal volume of optimal food for whatever species is eating it). Three partial or full meals of marrow, over the course of a week or so, have two effects on a creature:

- A gentle, permanent growth spurt (even for creatures that are adults and no longer grow), typically increasing its height (and other proportions) by 10 to 25 percent over the course of a week. Smaller creatures may grow up to twice their normal size.
- An overall increase in vitality that lasts for a few weeks. For an NPC, this increases the creature's level by +1 (usually adding +3 to its health as well) and its physical damage inflicted and physical modifiers by +1. For a PC, this increases their Might Edge and Speed Edge by +1.

Once a creature experiences these effects, only one meal of marrow per week is needed to sustain the vitality increase (or restore it once it fades away).

Marrow is never fully digested by a creature; some portion gets absorbed into its bodily tissues and remains there. This means that marrow makes its way through the local ecology, altering many creatures as they are eaten in turn by others. A rat can eat marrow, then pass the marrow to a wolf that eats the rat, then, when the wolf dies its marrow gets taken up by the maggots and worms that eat its corpse, which later might pass the marrow to birds or fish that eat them.

Marrow loses its potency outside of the structure (or a living creature's body) after a few days, so storing and transporting it in its original form is ineffective (without some sort of stasis ability).

The net effect of the marrow in the local ecosystem is that all local creatures tend to be larger than normal, and many of them are higher level than normal. This includes insects, spiders, and harmless creatures such as squirrels and game birds, all the way up to large predators and flesh-eating *abhumans*—including a local tribe of *yovoki* that have taken up residence in the ruin. The *yovoki* have realized that eating the marrow makes them stronger, so they keep other intelligent creatures out of the ruin in order to control this resource and remain dominant over other beings. Any human or near-human settlement near the ruin will have many unusually tall residents even if they aren't able to eat marrow or marrow-fed animals often enough to sustain the vitality increase.

to become one-way transparent from the inside, which doesn't interfere with their ability to control the main door.

2. HOLOGRAPHIC INTERACTION

READ ALOUD

The walls of this large room have hundreds of tiny dark spots, like the ones on the outside of the ruin but much smaller and more numerous, giving this place a mottled appearance. The spots on the walls near you are fluctuating rapidly, as if responding to your presence.

This room is the site's primary connection to the datasphere and directly corresponds to a similar frame in the local node. The datasphere frame creates a transparent replica of any creature or object visible in this room. The room creates a holographic

version of any dataform in the frame, reinforced by underlying **weak force fields** that give the holograms a tangible physical presence. Together, these two features allow creatures in the real and the datasphere to interact as if they were in the same room, including with audio and simple physical interactions (for example, two creatures could shake hands or play catch), but not actually harm each other.

At any particular time, there may be a datasphere traveler in the frame, in which case they're visible in this room. Said visitor might be a datasphere native curious about the real or someone trapped in the datasphere who needs assistance in getting transcribed back to the real.

The yovoki think this room is haunted and usually avoid it.

The room itself cannot transcribe anything in either direction, but the similar numenera here means using any device to to contact the datasphere, transcribe to or from the datasphere, or build something that uses the datasphere is eased by two steps. Salvaging in this room disables its abilities, but salvage actions to find specific **iotum** related to the datasphere (such as a **data orb**) are eased by two steps.

3. FEASTING SWARM

READ ALOUD

A swarm of red and yellow insects of abnormal proportions buzzes about in this room, with most of them crawling on the exposed pebbled marrow of a large crack in the wall. Another wall crack is bare of creatures, and instead of the blue marrow, it leaks a trickle of black sludge that forms a puddle on the ground. A layer of orange dust coats much of the floor.

Weak force field: level 1

The Holographic Interaction chamber would be a good place for you to hit the PCs with a glimmer, or for the voices to attempt direct communication with the PCs.



lotum, page 107

Data orb, page 115





Synth eater, page 277

GM intrusion: *The wall crack ejects another synth eater, which joins the fight against the PCs.*

Insect swarm: *level 4; flies a long distance each round*

GM intrusion: *Bites from the swarm cause swelling or irritation on a character's face, blinding them in one eye (hindering all tasks requiring sight) for a day*

The insects are the local equivalents of houseflies, and have shiny red and yellow carapaces and hairy limbs. Normally the size of a thumbnail, exposure to marrow over the generations has caused them to grow to triple their normal size. This colony primarily lives in this room; when the local marrow is depleted, large numbers of them starve, and the survivors cannibalize the dead (with the inedible bits forming the orange dust) and then roam the nearby corridors and rooms until they find something else to eat. Depending on the actions of the PCs, the **insect swarm** might ignore them to focus on the marrow or attack in the hopes of getting a big meal.

The black sludge is a side effect of malfunctioning numenera here; instead

of creating marrow, it has generated four **synth eaters** that remain inert unless a creature bearing synth comes within an immediate distance. If roused, the synth eaters separate from their communal hibernation and attack the PCs. These synth eaters cannot digest marrow or the blue synth material that the ruin is made of, so their attention is focused on the PCs and their unfamiliar enticing synth.

The yovoki know the synth eaters are a threat, and if they come through this area, they give the inert creatures a wide berth.

Battling either the swarm or the synth eaters is likely to agitate the other inhabitants of this room enough that they all join the fight against the PCs. The synth eaters and the swarm do not attack each other.



4. YOVOK LAIR

Each of these rooms on the map is a sleeping place for two to five **yovoki**, plus their simple beds of synth, leaves, and other soft materials. Any such room with four or five yovoki almost certainly has one vein of marrow.

The yovoki attack or flee depending on how threatening or hurt the characters look. Fleeing yovoki try to reach another group of their kind so they can team up against the invading PCs—especially if doing so means they regain control of a marrow vein.

5. OGRIN'S CHAMBER

READ ALOUD

Most of the available space in this smelly room is taken up by a large yellow mass resembling thick layers of congealed wax. Only after a few moments is it apparent that the mass is actually a creature, swollen and distorted beyond its original proportions. The only recognizable features are a pair of red eyes and a wide mouth filled with tiny teeth. A crusty layer of dried slime coats the floor and the lower walls.

This bloated creature was originally a yovok named **Ogrin**. It got lost in the ruin about a century ago, found a plentiful source of marrow, and survived here. The marrow triggered something in its genes, causing it to continue growing and mutating, and now it is a semi-amorphous creature with a yovok-like head (most of its bones have turned to cartilage or have been completely absorbed). Now it is barely sapient and likely to attack any creature it sees, for (like common yovoki) it is constantly hungry. It prefers to remain in this room and eat marrow, but can creep about when its supply temporarily dries up. The local yovoki alternatively believe Ogrin to be a demon or a god, and they leave gifts of ruined numenera

near its room. When it is on the move, they throw food at it to give them time to escape.

The dried slime is a mix of Ogrin's bodily secretions and gruel-like waste. When it leaves this room, it leaves behind a wet trail of this material, like a snail. The slime dries in about an hour.

If Ogrin is killed, buried deep in its innards (requiring an hour of searching) is a mutated internal organ that is a level 6 **chemical factory** cypher. This cypher has a **quirk** in that using it causes a creature to give off a horrible smell for a few hours, hindering the actions of all creatures within immediate range.

6. SNOGGOG'S LAIR

READ ALOUD

This room is another abhuman lair, with several small beds of soft synth, leaves, and other debris. Two cracks high up on the wall reveal the dark blue marrow. A simple ramp made of synth planks stacked on large pieces of junk is tall enough to allow a short creature to reach it.

There are usually five or six yovoki living here at any time, plus the closest thing they have to a leader: a taller, green-painted individual named **Snoggog**.

Snoggog wears a bulky metal ring (a level 8 heat **ray emitter**), which it uses to threaten other yovoki into obeying it. It likes to sleep on top of the ramp so nobody can get to the marrow without its knowledge. When the room runs out of marrow, the abhumans move their nests and ramp to a new room.

7. SALVAGED ROOM

Each of these rooms is an area that has already been salvaged by explorers or suffered some kind of damage that has destroyed anything salvageable. Salvage attempts here are hindered by three steps.



Yovoki, page 261



Chemical factory, page 276



Artifact quirk, page 290

Ogrin: level 5, defenses as level 6; Armor 3; attacks twice per round with barbed, fleshy pseudopods that inflict 5 points of damage each plus yovok poison

Snoggog: level 4, defends as level 5, jumps as level 6; Armor 2; damage inflicted 3 points plus yovok poison



Ray emitter, page 285

CANTED PIPES OF VNAAR

LEVEL 5

It is very unlikely that any rival explorer (page 84) with psychic abilities, such as Chymer, is willing to spend much time at this site.

Consider placing this site between Bodrov (page 138) and the Westwood (page 137) in Navarene.



Bodrov, page 138

Westwood, page 137



Datasphere siphon, page 277

Gravity nullifier, page 280

Mental scrambler, page 283

Voices (Aorut, Etranv, Isijaan), page 82

READ ALOUD

A rectangular structure over a hundred feet tall is covered in matte-black pipes, most of which are large enough for a human to stand in. The entire structure is tilted, as if it were halted just after it started falling over. A subtle telepathic voice whispers in an unknown language, too quiet to determine the syllables.

Overview: A very tall numenera structure covered in large black pipes, tilted at a 20-degree angle off of true vertical. The odd angle means all of its interior spaces are hard to navigate. A constant psychic transmission of gibberish makes it difficult to concentrate or use mental abilities.

Rumors: The people of the nearby village of Buvachi believe that the ruin used to float high in the sky and crashed to earth hundreds of years ago. The structure is tilting and sinking, and soon it will fall over and crush everything in its path. The mental voice is the last thoughts of a dying god and tells secrets of the future.

Common Cyphers: Datasphere siphon, gravity nullifier, mental scrambler

Voices: Aorut directs the resident abhumans to carefully examine all of the exposed devices, focusing on the levitation technology and the site's damaged power source. Arriving PCs are likely to find them in the process of salvaging something of interest to Aorut. The abhumans are more

likely to be willing to bargain or trade with visiting PCs, but they are still aggressive if an agreement cannot be reached. A group of rival explorers (particularly someone like Fellen-Froug) is probably present to guide the abhumans' activities and keep them focused on their tasks. The explorers use one room within the structure as their camp, but they also have an offsite camp. They stay there every few days just to get away from the constant telepathic messaging.

Etranv dampens the intensity of the message so it doesn't affect recovery rolls. The voice directly controls the automatons in area 4 and deploys similar machines in other parts of the ruin in the hopes of communicating with visitors. She probably uses her machines to drive out any abhuman squatters, forcing them into the nearby territory in search of food and living spaces.

Isijaan often changes parts of the telepathic message, adding its own name, references to other parts of the datasphere, jibes at other voices, or the names of nearby creatures in the real that it has identified.

The Canted Pipes of Vnaar is a large structure jutting out of the ground, tilting to the east at about a 20-degree angle (and also skewed slightly north). The entire ruin is covered in black synth pipes, most of which are large enough that a human can stand inside it with arms outstretched and not be able to touch the top or sides. Several openings



in the pipes allow creatures to enter the structure. The two immediately observable features of the ruin are its unusual angle and the constant telepathic message in the area.

It is likely that abhumans or humanoids who can climb or fly (such as *culovas*, *caprimags*, *keltonim*, or *sathosh*) use parts of the structure as a lair, its elevated entrances acting as a defensive feature.

THE ANGLE

The entire ruin leans far enough that the tilt is obvious from the outside at any visible distance. The interior floors and walls are tilted like the exterior—moving east is “downhill” and west is “uphill.” The incline is steep enough that characters moving east must be careful not to fall, and those moving west can only do so at a slower pace and with greater difficulty (see the Angled Maneuvering box on page 19). The slight tilt to the north is not significant enough

to affect movement, but observant characters will notice it, particularly if they spill liquids or drop something that rolls easily.

Although the assumption is that the entire structure is tilted off-center, only the walls, floors, and things that directly interface with them (such as doors and elevators) accommodate this tilt, and most other features within it are aligned to the true vertical axis. For example, a rectangular panel isn’t tilted to match the floor, objects that are probably tables and chairs have level surfaces despite being bolted to an angled floor, and so on. An angled door connecting two chambers might be next to a “normal” window, making the view of both slightly disorienting. However, there are a few places within the structure where the doors and such follow the “normal” orientation and other features are aligned to the tower’s tilt; some of these are part of the original structure, and some were clearly added by someone else with different materials.



Culova, page 231

Sathosh, page 251

Caprimag: A smelly, vulture-like abhuman; level 3. For more information, see Ninth World Bestiary 2, page 31.

Keltonim: A bat-like abhuman that enters a dangerous rage when threatened; level 3. For more information, see Ninth World Bestiary 2, page 82

By comparison, the Leaning Tower of Pisa’s worst tilt in its history was 5.5 degrees. It was stabilized in the late 20th century to be less than 4 degrees.

Although the reduction of Intellect Pool points generally won't affect NPCs because they have health instead of Pools, the hindering of mental powers does affect NPCs. Player characters might try to lure a telepathic foe into this area to gain a slight advantage.

Visitors might speculate that the ruin fell from a great height and landed here, embedding itself in the ground at an angle. The truth is that the land around it used to be much lower, and originally the Canted Pipes hovered at an angle above it, but at some point in a past age the land was moved upward, which buried the bottom portion of the ruin. If this ground were dug away (which would require hundreds of hours of work), the ruin would remain in place, levitating at an angle.

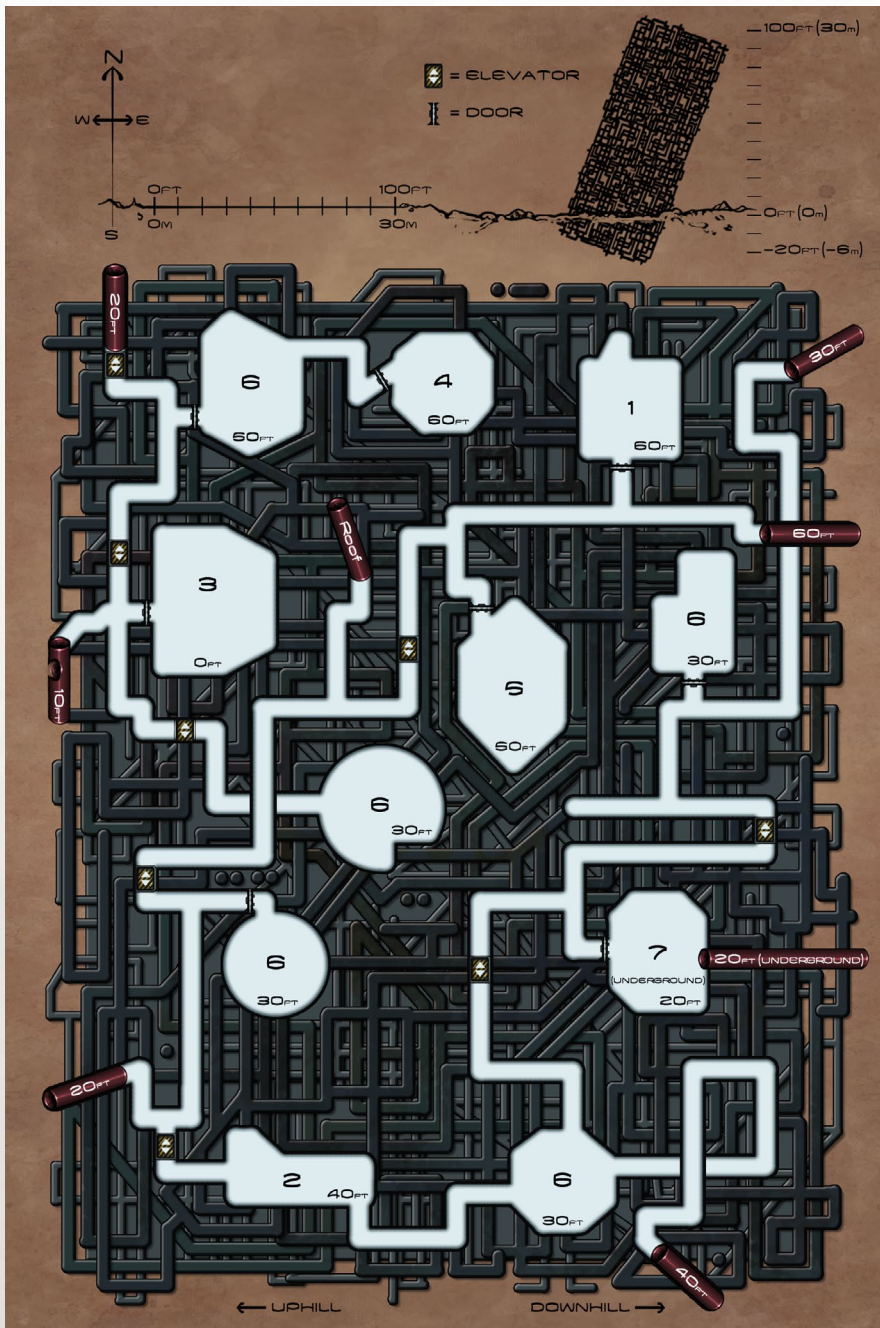
THE MESSAGE

All creatures coming within about a mile (1.5 km) of the Canted Pipes hear a faint telepathic message that repeats every few minutes. The message is a mental projection that sounds like a near-human voice intoning strange syllables in an unknown language. The volume of the message increases gradually as a creature gets closer to the structure, and inside the ruin it sounds like standing next to a person speaking (but not

yelling) in a loud voice.

The first portion of the message is the sounds “Vnaar vnaar vnaarm, uuus eerad halem utaag, vadar koor koor desh hoy gareesh bohn dawsh, ko koraa.” The next portion is slurred or distorted, and other parts of it grow fainter or louder. Altogether the message runs for about a minute and a half, then pauses for ten to twenty seconds before repeating again. The tower gets its name from the initial word-sounds in the message.

The constant projection of the message is distracting and annoying. After hearing the message for an hour, all mental actions (including Intellect defense rolls, and using type or focus abilities that cost Intellect points or require an Intellect-based roll) are hindered, and any ability or recovery roll used to restore Intellect Pool points is only half as effective (rounded down). For example, a recovery roll of 6 points could restore 6 points to a character's Might Pool; or 3 points (instead of 6) to their Intellect Pool, or 4 points to



ANGLED MANEUVERING

Normally (on flat ground) a character can **move** up to a short distance as their action (**routine**, difficulty 0), or move a long distance if they succeed at a difficulty 4 Speed task.

When moving down a steep incline, these tasks are hindered by two steps; failure means that at some point during the move, the character stumbles and falls down (you determine where this happens). Moving an immediate distance downhill is a routine task.

When moving up a steep incline, these tasks are hindered by one step; failure means that at some point during

the move (determined by you), the character stumbles, falls down, or is otherwise unable to make any more progress that round.

Requiring these rolls for every single move within the Canted Pipes can become tedious and frustrating for players. Instead, introduce a few of these rolls when the PCs begin exploring the ruin, then save them for dramatic situations such as combat or dealing with a hazard (or present a chance of falling as a GM intrusion). You can also require characters to pay an **initial cost** of 5 Speed points for each day they spend within the ruin to reflect the ongoing difficulty of navigating it.

their Speed Pool and 1 point (instead of 2) to their Intellect Pool. These negative effects happen regardless of the distance or volume of the message—hearing it is a mental earworm, whether faint or loud. After spending at least ten hours without hearing the repeating message, an affected creature can use mental abilities and recover Intellect points normally.

The source of the message transmission isn't limited to one place within the Canted Pipes; its point of origin intermittently shifts between five or six interior locations, remaining at each point for anywhere from ten minutes to an hour. This shift doesn't change the relative mental volume of the message. If characters track down a broadcast point and destroy it, that point is no longer a source for the transmission. If all of them are destroyed, the message is silenced until at least one broadcast point is repaired and reactivated.

Nobody knows what the message means, but there are several common theories: information from the gods, a beacon for an extraterrestrial or ultraterrestrial civilization, a warning (perhaps about something inside the

structure), coordinates to another location, or a code or password that unlocks something. (Memorizing the clear parts of the message can help a character activate the device in area 3.)

The message also exists on the datasphere side of this vertice, although there it is accompanied by a series of glyphs representing each sound, which travel across the walls or through the open air. Some of the glyphs flicker as if glitching, which might be a clue as to why nobody has been able to translate the message.

ENTRANCES AND CONNECTIONS

Seven openings in the pipes allow creatures to enter the structure at various distances above the ground (indicated on the map for each entrance). Six of these openings look like they're naturally part of the structure—places where a pipe juts outwards 10 feet (3 m) and ends. The seventh (on the western side) is a place where a section of an exterior pipe has been smashed in from the outside.



Action: Move, page 116

Routine tasks, page 102

Initial cost, page 106

GM intrusion: The character stumbles and begins to slide or roll downhill. The character can attempt a Speed defense roll to stop this uncontrolled movement after an immediate or short distance.

Characters who can climb, fly, or use abilities like Define Down to change the local orientation of gravity will have a much easier time navigating the Canted Pipes.



Define Down, page 64

Creatures who have telepathy or are sensitive to psychic phenomena usually can hear the message at about twice the distance that a typical person can hear it.

The Canted Pipes are a level 5 ruin, so numenera of level 6 or higher that protect against mental attacks block the message entirely.



Psychic helmet, page 299

Despite all the twists and turns of the interior passageways, there aren't many left-right choices to make, and the severe tilt helps them track which way is east, so explorers are easily able to retrace their steps to a previous location without getting lost. There is no need to map the hallways—focus on the rooms and their elevations.



Strongglass, page 94

GM intrusion: After spending several minutes in the room, a character is disoriented by the eerie silence, and all hearing-based tasks are hindered for an hour. The character also must succeed at an Intellect defense roll or experience occasional auditory hallucinations for an hour.

The Message, page 18



Oddity, page 304

Some of the natural entrances (as indicated in the individual room descriptions) have interior doors that require an understanding numenera task to open or close. The smashed entrance and the other natural entrances are open to the elements, and local creatures sometimes lair within.

Most of the interior areas eventually connect to each other through twisting passageways and cramped elevators. A portion of the interior structure can be accessed only by the smashed entrance and one of the natural entrances.

There is a hidden eighth natural entrance buried underground, which leads to area 7. Unless characters have the ability to move or phase through large amounts of soil, they're unlikely to discover this entrance from the outside, but may find it through connections from other parts of the ruin.

DATASPHERE CONNECTION

The hexagonal pillar in area 3 is a functional transcription device, which sends creatures to a node containing a set of vertically stacked frames, each of which has a frame environment resembling a transparent-walled room surrounded by glowing pipes of energy. As noted under [The Message](#), the telepathic transmission at this site is visible in the local frames as a string of glyphs, often glitching.



SITE LOCATIONS

The following are specific locations at this site.

1. QUIET ROOM



READ ALOUD

The walls, floor, and ceiling here are made of nearly opaque brown glass. Faint light and silhouettes can be seen beyond the glass. Four black synth tubes, each about the length of a human forearm, are scattered around the room. It is unusually quiet here.

The brown glass is actually [strongglass](#). Although the slowly moving lights and silhouettes projected on the glass suggest that there are other rooms directly connected to this one, there are no open adjacent spaces in the structure—breaking the glass, phasing through it, or using devices to observe through it only reveals machinery and structural materials. (The moving dark and light shapes might be a projection or transmission from elsewhere, or just an optical illusion.)

This room dampens all sound within it, whether it originates here or is projected into it. Voices at a normal conversational level are completely silenced, and even screams and shouts are as quiet as a whisper. All sound-based effects are hindered by four steps, and all sound-based damage is reduced by 5 points.

Each of the black synth tubes is an [oddity](#). Their abilities are:

- Warms if shaken, up to about the temperature of a hot drink
- Vibrates if spun, taking several minutes to become quiescent again
- Levitates a fist-sized sphere of water-based liquid that one end is touched to
- Turns anything put inside it bright blue for several minutes

2. HOT ROOM

READ ALOUD

This room is much longer than it is wide or tall. A few sections of the wall buckle inward, and two of those emit a bright blue glow. An automaton resembling several metal and synth snakes fused together slumps in the middle of the room, inert.

The damage to this room causes the structure to leak radiation, particularly in the glowing areas. Creatures in this room take 1 point of ambient damage from radiation every minute. Any creature within immediate distance of a buckled wall takes 1 point of ambient radiation damage every round, or 5 points per round if near a glowing area.

The PCs may have abilities or devices that can seal off a damaged area, either temporarily or permanently. Sealing the glowing breaches negates their localized radiation damage. Sealing all of the breaches stops the ambient radiation damage for the entire room. Actually repairing the damage would take dozens of hours, an unlikely proposition considering the radiation.

The automaton is nonfunctional due to extreme age and radiation damage to its sensitive components. It can be salvaged for a **needler** artifact (with the “strange telepathic sendings” **quirk**) and about 20 shins. Unlike salvaging an automaton defeated in combat, its outer housing is intact, so salvaging it takes about ten or fifteen minutes, during which time the PCs are exposed to the ongoing radiation damage. The automaton can be moved out of the room and salvaged in a safer area. It is slightly larger than a human and weighs about twice as much as one.

3. BEETLECRAB NEST

READ ALOUD

This large room has three wall panels that appear to have been salvaged by previous explorers—sections are smashed open or pried loose, with wires and the remnants of

other devices dangling like the dead limbs of a corpse. Four black synth conduits project downward from the ceiling, and a short hexagonal pillar stands unharmed in the middle of the room. The floor is covered in a layer of fragments from some kind of crab-like shelled creature, with an accompanying unpleasant smell.

The exposed panels have already been salvaged by other visitors; **attempting to salvage more** from them is hindered by one step.

The hexagonal pillar is intact, other than some scratch marks on its surface from a previous attempt to open it. This is a functional vertice device, capable of transcribing one or more creatures to or from the datasphere, although if the character operating it fails an understanding numerera task, the subjects get a minor glitch. If the characters try to salvage the pillar, it lights up and makes warning beeps and whistles; this doesn't escalate into harm to the characters, and they can salvage it normally. However, the noise immediately alerts the creatures living in the ceiling conduits.

Each of the four conduits is a nest for flying creatures resembling a cross between a winged beetle and a fiddler crab, about the width of one or two hands with fingers outspread. These beetlecrabs have vermin-level intelligence and sleep for long periods of time, but they are very territorial, attacking as a **swarm** by flying out of their nest area and surrounding intruders. Two **big beetlecrabs** are twice as large as the others and have dog-level intelligence, directing the main swarms (using claw clicks and hisses) with simple pack tactics. The creatures typically fight to the death, but if driven out of this area, they'll return later and ignore intruders while they cannibalize their own dead.



Additional Salvage Attempts, page 110

The words of the telepathic message are a clue to activating the transcription device. A character who memorizes the non-distorted part of the message has an asset on their understanding numerera task to activate the device.

GM intrusion: A character falls ill from the radiation exposure, as if from a roll of 96–100 on the Cypher Danger table.



Cypher Danger table, page 273

Needler, page 299

Artifact Quirk, page 290

GM intrusion: The radiation activates one of a character's cyphers or artifacts, targeting a random creature in the area, or a random nearby location if the cypher doesn't affect creatures.

Beetlecrab swarm: level 3; Armor 1; flies a short distance each round

Big beetlecrab: level 2; Armor 1; flies a short distance each round

The beetlecrabs are simple creatures and are unaffected by the constant telepathic message.

The voices may try to interact with the PCs in this area by speaking through the automatons or by telekinetically manipulating the water into faces, shapes, or symbols.

A character without adequate access to water moves one step down the damage track for each full day—or every few minutes within this room.

The buoyancy of the water counteracts the extreme angle of the entire ruin, although moving and fighting in water has its own difficulties.



Water, page 114

Mist, page 114

Cypher bag, page 294

Tiny Automaton: level 0, stealth as level 7 due to size and phasing.

Swimming automaton: level 5; Armor 1; climbs or swims a short distance each round; one or two attacks per round with spikes or edged wheels inflict 5 points of damage

Noticing the vanishing slime: level 4

4. INVERTED WATER

READ ALOUD

The upper portion of this tall chamber is filled with liquid that ripples like water in a pond. Beige-yellow silt churns in the liquid, obscuring what lies within, but there are momentary glimpses of large wheeled shapes moving within it. Several devices around the bottom edge of the room point long tubes up towards the surface of the liquid. There is a feeling of heavy pressure in the air, and the wheeled shapes sometimes make knocking sounds.

The ceiling liquid is mostly water (enough that humans can safely drink it, although it tastes earthy). Its surface parallels the tilted angle of the floor, and it remains held against the ceiling as if gravity affects it differently than other matter. An object dunked into it drips water upward even though the object itself has normal weight and falls to the ground if released. If a character enters the water, they still feel gravity pulling them down toward the floor. The silt obscures vision in it like **mist** (ranged attacks are hindered). Altogether the water extends about 60 feet (18 m) beyond its surface. This inverted orientation applies only within this room.

The tube devices occasionally spray a burst of fluid that joins with the water on the ceiling or a thin stream of yellow powder that adds to the silt. Neither substance has any properties the characters might find useful. These devices can be salvaged, but harming them immediately attracts the attention of the automatons moving about in the water.

The three **swimming automatons** look like large metal wheels (about as tall as a human) with smaller wheels all around the perimeter and a central spiked hub resembling a sea urchin. At any time, one or more might come to the surface as if watching the PCs (or, rarely, come completely out of the water to manipulate the tube devices), but they don't take

hostile actions unless attacked or the tube devices are tampered with. Otherwise, they take turns manipulating a couple of panels in the deepest part of their pool, which don't appear to affect anything in this room (the PCs can salvage these panels, assuming they can deal with the lack of air).

5. SWEAT FACTORY

READ ALOUD

This room is empty except for two large brown glass cylinders, a spider-like device attached to the wall, and a long-dead human corpse collapsed in the near corner. The device, about the size of a backpack, emits a high-pitched hum, almost too high to hear.

The device causes living creatures to sweat beads of yellow slime. The slime is harmless, but the sweating causes dehydration. Every few minutes, this depletes the creature as if they went a **full day without water**. Creatures can stave off dehydration by drinking to replenish this water. The device can be salvaged for a level 6 **cypher bag** artifact, but every time the user makes a depletion roll for it, they take 5 points of damage (ignores Armor) due to a sudden bout of yellow-slime sweat.

The glass cylinders are full of **pea-sized automatons**. In their passive state, they are coiled into metallic spheroids, but when there is yellow slime in the room, they uncoil into a wormlike shape, phase-teleport onto sweating creatures in the room, quickly lap up the slime, then return to their storage cylinders. This subtle consumption by the automatons usually prevents creatures from realizing that they are continuing to produce slime. If it were normal sweat, they'd quickly be dripping with it, but the actions of the thirsty automatons mean the creatures become only a little damp. Only **careful observation** of their sweating flesh lets characters realize that

something is consuming the slime from their bodies; those more focused on the devices in the room might not realize the threat until the first stage of dehydration sets in.

The tiny automatons have no attacks or abilities other than their teleportation and slime-eating. They can be destroyed in large numbers with area attacks once the cylinders are opened or destroyed, and they put up no resistance (although they squirm as if they can feel pain).

The corpse is of a person who probably had a slight build, and now is nothing more than a dried husk over bones. It is dressed in explorer's clothes. It has a small sword, a crossbow, 5 bolts, a pouch with 10 shins, a backpack, a set of light tools, and two cyphers (a level 6 **magnetic shield** and a level 3 **psychic communique**). There is no obvious cause of death (the body has no fresh wounds, just scars from old ones that healed naturally), but once the dehydration hazard of this room becomes apparent, the PCs might realize that this explorer succumbed to it.

6. ABHUMAN LAIR

If **abhumans** are making use of the Canted Pipes, this is one of several rooms they use as a lair or sleeping area, and has several small beds of soft synth, leaves, and other debris. There may be three to ten abhumans here, depending on their social nature.

7. LIGHT GRAVITY

READ ALOUD

This room is another abhuman lair. In addition to the simple beds, the area is decorated with several tall stacks of junk, carefully balanced to nearly the height of a human.

The engines that levitate the entire structure are nearby but inaccessible through passages creatures can reach.



Their proximity makes the gravity in this room about half normal, easing all tasks relating to movement (balancing, climbing, jumping, running, and so on). The telepathic message is also much quieter here, but still loud enough to have its normal effects.

Stacking junk is something the local abhumans do when they are bored. Nothing useful is in what they've used for their "art."

The door on the east wall leads to a large synth pipe exit like those elsewhere in the ruin. However, this pipe ends underground, closed off by a wall of stone rubble and drit (spilled inward from the outside, not stacked up from inside the structure). Clearing enough of this material to allow a creature to reach the outside surface takes several days of labor—but character abilities such as phasing or telekinesis can overcome this obstacle more quickly.



Magnetic shield,
page 282

Psychic communique,
page 285

Abhuman, page 13

GM intrusion: A stack of junk gets knocked over (accidentally or deliberately), tripping a nearby character if they fail a level 3 Speed task, and creating an immediate area of difficult terrain.



Difficult terrain,
page 117

SEVEN COUSINS

LEVEL 6

Because this ruin is a mile above the ground, if the ground itself is high above sea level (on a hill or mountain), characters visiting the Cousins may get winded easily due to the lower air pressure and oxygen level. These characters are hindered in all tasks, either due to a failed Might defense task or a GM intrusion.

Titanothaur: a level 10 destructive creature of gigantic size; most are easily 300 feet (90 m) tall. For more information, see *The Ninth World Bestiary* page 126.

Consider placing this site south of Dynafel in Iscobal.



Dynafel, page 154

Attractor, page 276

Detonation (gravity), page 277

Gravity nullifier, page 280

Reality spike, page 285

X-ray viewer, page 288

Strongglass, page 94

Voices (Aorut, Etranv, Isijaan), page 82

READ ALOUD

A cluster of huge boulders comes into view, floating at least a mile above the ground and held in place by a haze that matches the surrounding sky. Bright glass panels on the undersides occasionally catch a glint of light. The boulders are flat on top, with buildings upon each of them. A few smaller rocks drift around them like they swing on invisible ropes.

Overview: Seven flying stone islands high in the air are visible from the ground only when the sun hits them at certain angles. The structures are used as landing pads and a communications hub for anhedons making their way to the Ninth World, but they have their own guardians and agenda.

Rumors: Miners in the outpost of Nomrom tell the tale of the gods who placed seven great heroes—all cousins blessed by the numenera—in the sky to keep watch against enemies from the stars. A nameless demigod split himself into seven shining diamonds to light the way to paradise. A six-fingered demon claws at the walls of its invisible cage.

Common Cyphers: *Attractor*, *detonation* (gravity), *gravity nullifier*, *reality spike*, *x-ray viewer*

Voices: *Aorut* studies how the mineral-teleporter affects flesh creatures in the hopes of learning how unsupported creatures (such as many bizarre datasphere entities) might be able to survive in the real. This requires

controlling a nearby vertice and bringing many creatures here to use as test subjects (resulting in corpses piling up or spilling off the side of the platform).

Etranv is fascinated by the stone-based anhedons and brings other stone-, crystal-, or silicon-based life forms to this location. This usually results in heated battles for control of the site between various factions of creatures (which the characters can take advantage of if they're careful not to draw attention to themselves).

Isijaan overrides the numenera holding the Cousins in place and sends them drifting, shakes them up and down, or flies them around in search of something big and dangerous to shoot at (such as a *titanothaur*). They may instead strafe a few villages or cities until repelled with equal or greater firepower.

The Seven Cousins are a numenera fortification that goes unnoticed most of the time because of their location and a subtle cloaking field that blocks casual observation. They float a mile in the air and are hidden from view from the ground by an illusory distortion field that mimics the nearby atmospheric color and texture. When viewed up close, they look like flat stone boulders with structures built upon them.

The underside of each boulder appears to be rough stone with occasional patches of lichen or similar growths. Several large *strongglass* panels stick out among these rough shapes, absorbing power from sunlight and projecting an antigravity



field that keeps the boulder from falling to the ground. Dozens of fist-sized metal nodules create a visual haze underneath each boulder. From the ground, they look exactly like the ambient sky—cloudy, clear, blue, twilight grey, and so on. However, several times per year, the rising or setting sun hits the strongglass panels at just the right angle to create a twinkling effect that is visible from the ground as seven distinct **flashing objects** high in the sky.

The platforms are very stable, and most activity by human-sized characters can barely make them vibrate. Only a level 7 or higher effect that creates great force (such as a detonation) is strong enough to shake or tilt them momentarily.

FOES FROM THE SKY

This site is frequented by **anhedons**—stony creatures known to fall from the sky. The Seven Cousins contain several devices

that are useful to the anhedons in their search for the Meeting of All Things. At any particular time, there are three to four anhedons using various devices in this ruin.

When PCs arrive at this location, they probably see anhedons working at one or more of the platforms. These creatures are intent on what they're doing and probably ignore the PCs unless they call attention to themselves by making noise, attempting to salvage numenera from the structure, attacking the anhedons, or otherwise interfering with whatever they are doing.

Every few hours, an anhedon lands on one of the boulders with a loud crash. The new arrival usually spends a few rounds conferring with others of its kind who are present, then chooses its own tasks to work on. Some anhedons leave the ruin by jumping off (and presumably landing on the ground somewhere), but others vanish (or appear) using the device in area 2.

To reach the Seven Cousins, the characters might use a flying vehicle or similar numenera, be teleported here accidentally or intentionally, get pulled here due to a malfunction in the elevator in area 3, be dropped here by a flying beast using one of the platforms as a nest, and so on.

If the Cousins are used (by someone other than a voice) to attack any settlements, it is likely that a group of rival explorers (particularly Ee'al and Laren) will come here to stop the attacks, putting them at odds with the anhedons (and potentially being allies for the PCs). See page 84 for more on rival explorers.

Most people see only six bright spots, but those with keen eyesight can make out that one point is actually two discrete objects. Some local villages use the challenge of looking for the seventh spot as a vision test for young scouts and warriors.



Anhedon, page 253

GM intrusion:

An anhedon uses a gravity-assisted jump on one side of a platform to bounce an opponent on the opposite side. The bounced character must succeed at a Speed task to grab onto something solid so they don't fall over the edge.

Wanderer: level 5

Because an anhedon's gravity manipulation allows them to jump a very long distance, there is no place on top of the structures that they can't reach (no two platforms are more than a very long distance apart). This can be troublesome for characters with limited-range attacks or limited mobility. Furthermore, their natural mass and gravity control means their jumps can muster enough force to briefly wobble a platform—perhaps enough to send a person near the edge tumbling over the

side. The anhedons are aware of this and may try pushing or knocking foes off of the platforms under the assumption that their opponents won't survive a mile-long fall to the ground.

THE WANDERERS

The **Wanderers** are five irregular human-sized stones that constantly circle the cluster of platforms, roughly evenly spaced from each other. If a creature falls or jumps from a platform, a nearby Wanderer usually moves to position

itself so the creature lands on it (probably taking 1 or 2 points of ambient damage for the short fall), then flies to the nearest platform, dumps the creature back on level ground, and resumes its orbit.

The Wanderers are not perfect at their task. Although they succeed the first time a character needs them (in other words, the first fall for one individual in the group of PCs, not the first fall for *each* PC), for later falls a Wanderer has only a 50 percent chance of being close enough to intervene, and even so the character has to succeed at a Speed defense task to catch hold of the Wanderer.

If a Wanderer doesn't catch a falling character (or vice versa), the character falls all the way to the ground and dies—although a successful level 9 or 10 task might only knock them unconscious and move them down two steps on the damage track, depending on what they land on. Of course, the falling character or their companions have three or four rounds to try something else (such as activating a flying cypher) before the character hits the ground.



The Wanderers completely ignore anhedons and never try to catch them.

DATASPHERE CONNECTION

There is no vertice at this ruin, but the Data Scanner Array (area 4) does have the ability to search for nearby vertices and similar datasphere-active sites.

SITE LOCATIONS

The following are specific locations at this site. Most of the objects and structures here are **shapestone**, but a few pieces (such as some electrical conduits and flat panel interfaces) are made of materials such as metal, synth, and glass.

1. WEAPON PLATFORM



READ ALOUD

This narrow platform has a curved ledge on each end and a rectangular grid inscribed on the floor. Portions of the grid rise and sweep from one side to the other like ripples in a pond.

The rectangular grid is a malfunctioning device; if working properly, it would form a scale topographical map of a chosen area underneath the Seven Cousins and allow a user (at one of the ledge interfaces) to change the view to any location within a few miles that has a direct line of sight to the sensors underneath the platform. In its current state, it randomly sweeps over its surveyable area and intermittently zooms in and out (if the characters are familiar with any local landmarks, including villages or other settlements, these might briefly cross into view on the map). Repairing the device is a complex understanding numenera task (hindered by two steps) that takes several hours, some of which requires tinkering with devices on the underside of this platform.

Either of the ledge interfaces can be used to fire a weapon that shoots bursts of ceramic needles at an immediate or short area within the location shown on the map. Choosing the size of the area and firing the burst-needler is a single understanding numenera task. However, while the grid-mapping device is malfunctioning, the best the user can hope for is aiming at something interesting when it briefly and randomly comes into view on the map, hindering all attacks with the weapon by three steps.

When fired at an immediate area, the burst-needler weapon inflicts 12 points of damage, or 3 points on a successful Speed defense roll; at a small area, it inflicts 4 points of damage, or 1 point on a successful Speed defense roll. The burst-needler's range is about 2 miles (3 km). It has a depletion of 1 in 1d20.

There is usually one **anhedon** on this platform at any time, trying to repair or adjust the map mechanism.

2. MINERAL TELEPORTER



READ ALOUD

The two significant features of this platform are a chest-height carved stone ledge and a large circle inscribed on the floor. The air around the ledge ripples like a mirage.

The circle is the focus point for a teleporter, and the ledge is its control panel. The ledge gives off heat like a campfire out to an immediate distance. (If people are trapped up here during wintertime, the ledge is warm enough to keep them alive indefinitely.) A successful understanding numenera task allows a character to figure out that the teleporter is connected to several other locations in the Ninth World, most of which are at ground level (but at least one is a hovering platform like this one). The character also learns how to activate it.

From a gameplay perspective, the Wanderers are here to save an unlucky PC from falling to their death, but they are intentionally unreliable so the characters shouldn't be reckless.

Attacks at the limits of a weapons range are hindered.



Shapestone, page 93

Range, 114



Anhedon, page 253



The frequent arrivals and exits of the anhedons means you should have as many combat encounters in this structure as the characters can handle. You can always add more anhedons to an encounter as a GM intrusion.

GM intrusion: An anhedon arrives from the sky or via the teleporter while the characters are studying its controls—or while trying to restore a teleport-damaged ally—and immediately attacks.

The device doesn't clearly convey that it is meant for teleporting stone-based life forms (including silicon- or ceramic-based life), which means the anhedons can use it without any risk. However, if a flesh creature such as a human uses it, the teleporter transports only the heavily mineralized portions of their body—namely, bones and teeth—leaving behind an unsupported skin-bag of fluids, nerves, and meat that collapses under its own weight and suffocates over the next few minutes. If the roll to understand or manipulate the controls would have succeeded at a level 7 task, the user realizes this limitation before using the teleporter on a flesh target.

If a flesh character's bones are teleported away, they can be brought back in the right place with a successful understanding numenera task hindered by two steps. Otherwise, the mutilated creature will die unless exceptional measures are used, such as using numenera to regrow a skeleton, suspending its need for air, or the like.

3. ELEVATOR

READ ALOUD

Five concentric circles are carved in the floor of this platform. Near the low ridge at the platform's edge are three adjacent square pillars with multiple markings.

The three pillars are the control mechanism for a gravitational elevator defined by the concentric circles. Controls on the pillars cause one or more of the circles to iris open, allowing larger and heavier items to be carried to or from the ground.

The controls are spaced too far apart for a human to easily manipulate; attempts by a single human operator are hindered by two steps because they have to move back and forth to activate distant switches (a long-armed creature such as a lattimor can just barely reach all of them and can operate it without penalty). Having a second person help activate the

controls counts as an asset whether or not that person has any skill or inability in understanding numenera.

Anything placed on the circles remains there as the circles are opened. A separate command (its own action, but not a separate task) sends the materials down to the ground at a speed of about 100 miles per hour (160 kph), safely slowing it in the last few seconds so it lands unharmed. Another command can pull one or more objects at that place on the ground upward to this platform; the circles automatically open when items are brought up. The gravitational elevator can hold about 3,000 pounds (1,300 kg).

Unless the anhedons must move something very large, they have no need for the elevator and almost never use it. Of the seven platforms of this ruin, this is the one they visit least.

4. DATA SCANNER ARRAY

READ ALOUD

This two-level platform has a large number of square pillars, most of which are on the upper portion. Many of the pillars on the lower half are broken off, leaving only small pieces fused to the ground.

Each of the intact pillars is an interface that can search for one specific thing, which a character can identify with a successful understanding numenera task. Each search includes some kind of error indicating another pillar, as if the active interface required input from one of the destroyed pillars.

Any newly arrived anhedon usually spends several minutes on this platform adjusting settings and using the scanners to update itself about some kind of data relevant to the Meeting of All Things.

The human-comprehensible searches include:

- Teleporter locations accessible from this site (this information is the same

GM intrusion: The elevator grabs some random material from the ground, pulls it up to the platform, and tears it apart, flinging shrapnel and debris over the entire platform. This inflicts 6 points of damage, or 2 points on a successful Speed defense roll.

as what can be discovered using the interface in area 2)

- Currently active datasphere sites within a few hundred miles (this sometimes includes damaged or intermittently active vertices, or locations that aren't vertices but experience frequent glimmers)
- Underground power conduit paths (out of date; lists many paths that are destroyed, cold, or have shifted from an active location)
- Locations with at least 10 units of **midnight stones**
- Confirmed travel paths of {undecipherable} for the past 35 hours
- Ongoing time anomalies and anomalies from the past few days

Any other search produces results with maps, graphs, and extrapolations, but it isn't clear what is being shown or tracked, or whether it is something dangerous or of value. It is easy (eased by two steps) to repeat a pillar's most recent search, perhaps gaining an updated result. This allows the characters to see what an anhedon was using it for, but that doesn't mean they can tell what was being searched for.

The salvageable portion of this platform is the web of numenera connecting all of the individual pillars, which counts as two intact salvage sources.

5. POWER CONTROL

READ ALOUD

This platform has six low stone ledges arranged on its surface. Three shallow depressions indicate there may have been other ledges here in the past. A rocky creature with glowing red eyes is repeatedly touching its fingers to the top of one of the ledges.

This platform stores and distributes power to the other platforms (each of them powers itself, but this one is a

backup should a specific platform's own mechanisms fail). As an action, a creature can use a successful understanding numenera task to increase or reduce power to any other platform. Reducing a platform's power three times forces it to land on the ground (moving a long distance each round) and disables its other functions; for example, cutting power to the teleporter platform prevents it from teleporting anything. Restoring a platform to full power takes five to ten rounds and causes it to rise up to its previous position and resume its normal functions. Shutting down this platform moves it to the ground and renders it inoperable until recharged by a level 6 or higher energy source.

There are often one or two **anhedons** on this platform, adjusting power usage in minor ways to enhance something another one of their fellows is doing.

The buried network of numenera connections between the ledges counts as two salvageable locations.

6. CAMOUFLAGE DEVICE

READ ALOUD

A long, zig-zagging stone ledge winds its way across this platform, coming close to several square pillars embedded in the surface. The ledge is cold enough that a slight mist forms around its base, and the pillars emit heat that pushes the mist away in gentle waves.

The stone pillars are a linked set of devices that create the hazy camouflage underneath the Seven Cousins. The stone ledge is the control mechanism for the pillars; like the elevator controls in area 3, they are spaced too far apart to be easily manipulated by one human creature (understanding numenera actions are hindered). A successful understanding numenera task can activate or deactivate the camouflage hiding the platforms from viewers below. It is possible to alter the shape and orientation of the camouflage

The voices may try to interact with the PCs in this area by sending messages to the panel, or forcing the specific search results to the panel despite whatever the PCs are trying to find.



Midnight stone, page 113

Anhedon, page 253



Plan seeds, page 136



lotum, page 107

field over the seven platforms, such as hiding them from above, from all directions, or hiding some and revealing others, but tasks to do so are hindered by two steps. It is also possible to orient the camouflage so it obscures the flat parts of the platforms, reducing vision to an immediate distance.

Anhedons on any of the platforms are likely to ignore explorers unless they deactivate or shift the camouflage field—especially if it hides the site from above, which would make it harder for the anhedons to land on it.

7. THE SMALLEST COUSIN

READ ALOUD

This smallest boulder has a pair of semicircular ledges framing a squat pillar in the middle of the platform. Twelve small grooves in the outer part of the floor are partially covered by tiny stone arches.

This platform is actually a vehicle that has been restrained to this location for at least a thousand years. The pillar is a pilot's seat, the ledges are its control mechanisms, and the loops are places to secure passengers or cargo with ropes or chains. Recognizing that this is meant to be a separate mobile structure requires an understanding numenera roll.

Freeing the vehicle requires unlinking its controls from each of the other platforms at this site. Doing so requires six hindered understanding numenera tasks (one for each of the other platforms, with each task taking three or four rounds), but these can be accomplished from the vehicle's control unit.

Attempting to unlink the vehicle from a platform triggers a flashing silent alarm at that platform's control unit, and the unlinking attempt can be shut down there as an action. Any anhedon within an immediate distance of the alarm notices it, shuts it down, and moves to stop the characters from continuing; other anhedons at the site see its actions and follow suit.

Stats for this vehicle are in the Seventh Cousin box. Materials needed to craft a vehicle like it are included for GMs who want to allow the characters to find a **plan seed** for this vehicle. The vehicle doesn't have a cloaking device; its camouflage is provided by the complex device in area 6.

SEVENTH COUSIN

Minimum Crafting Level: 6

Kind: Vehicle

lotum needed to build: Stone (100 units); io (2d6 units); responsive synth (30 units); apt clay (4 units); synthsteel (5 units); monopole (2 units)

Parts needed to build: 60 units

Specifications: This vehicle is a stone structure about 30 feet (9 m) across, flat on the top, with strongglass panels projecting from its rough convex underside. Embedded devices negate and push against gravity, allowing it to hover in midair. Gravitic thrusters allow it to move horizontally or vertically up to a short distance each round. On extended trips in a straight line, it can move up to 80 miles per hour (130 km), but maneuvers at any speed above 10 miles per hour (16 km/h) are hindered by two steps. The vehicle features a stone seat for a pilot and a low stone lip around the perimeter to keep things from rolling off. It can carry about 3,000 pounds (1,300 kg) in addition to its own weight. After each ten hours of movement, the Seventh Cousin must rest in the sun for at least one hour before it becomes operational again. Hovering in place does not deplete its power source, and it can recharge while hovering.

Depletion: 1 in 1d20 (check per week of use, other than hovering)

CHAPTER 5

FRAGRANT TRAP

LEVEL 6

 READ ALOUD

A thin vapor in the air carries a mixture of conflicting scents—blood, salt water, wet stone, perfume, and more. Visible through the haze is an orange and black numenera ruin, with one corner smashed open as if by an enormous detonation. Something glitters inside, and the mist appears to be thicker around the damaged area.

Overview: Metallic golden cubes inside the ruin emit weird gases with different effects. Cube-headed creatures of various shapes live here and defend the ruin against salvagers and vandals.

Rumors: According to the elders of the village of Gel Durgan, this ruin is the lair of a ravenous beast that uses scents to lure in prey. Creatures of a previous world are slowly decaying into poisonous gases that drive people mad. The numenera turns intruders into golden warriors who are cursed to defend the site for all time.

Common Cyphers: **Chemical factory**, **gas bomb**, **personal environment field**, **teleporter (traveler)**

Voices: **Aorut** wants to reconfigure the local numenera so the golden warriors are protective of him rather than the site. For this purpose, he brings large numbers of intelligent smaller-than-human creatures and transforms them using altered numenera, with limited success—some seem loyal to him, some are compelled to protect the site, and others experience severe mental

problems and aggression toward non-transformed creatures. The facility becomes populated by erratic guardians, although Aorut exiles or kills the most troublesome ones.

Etranv is fascinated by the golden warrior “curse” and sends other creatures to this site so she can study the transformation (this means there are more creatures here and of many additional varieties). She may attempt to transplant this numenera to another site, assuming that those already transformed would be compelled to remain there rather than fight to come to this place.

Isijaan doesn’t know or care what is going on here, but they enjoy the strange effects the cube gas has on creatures; when rolling to see what effect a cube gas has, multiply the d100 roll by 2 (so a roll of 52 becomes 104). It is curious about the inactive moon-teleporter in area 7, and if the PCs get it working, the voice transmits some of its mind to the moon and explores there (perhaps to the aid or detriment of the characters). If Isijaan is able to reach the moon, they see it as a stepping-stone to digital networks in other star systems, and pushes his followers (particularly **Delufti** and **Movamac**) to bring him devices and vehicles that would allow him to transport a portion of himself to these distant realms.

The Fragrant Trap is a long, squat ruin covered in alternating bands of orange and black. One corner is torn open,

Parts of this location may use a form of psychological manipulation called gaslighting, which makes a person question whether their own memories, perception, or judgment are valid. Gaslighting is one way that abusive people control and harm others (particularly in romantic relationships). Before using this location in your campaign, check with your gaming group to make sure they're comfortable with gaslighting happening to their characters. For more information about consent topics in RPGs, see the free Consent in Gaming PDF at myMCG.info/consent

Voices (Aorut, Etranv, Isijaan), page 82

Delufti, page 86

Movamac, page 89

Consider placing this site east of Rarrow in Ancuan.



Chemical factory; page 276

Gas bomb, page 280

Personal environment field, page 283

Teleporter (traveler), page 288

Rarrow, Page 163



A golden cube can be salvaged for a cypher, perhaps an oddity, and a few shins.

If you want to add more golden warriors or customize this location to fit your campaign, choose any biological creature of level 2–6 that lives in the Ninth World, add 1 to its Armor, and it's ready to serve.

revealing several interior levels. It is through this damaged area that most visitors are able to enter the structure, but several other concealed entrances lead to areas that are essentially untouched.

Most of the rooms within the structure have one or more golden metallic cubes, each about the size of a human's outspread arms, usually attached to a wall or floor. These cubes emit aromatic gases, either constantly (until the whole room is saturated with it) or in brief bursts when a creature comes within immediate range or tries to tamper with a cube. The gases have various scents and effects; see Cube Gas, below, for more information. The ruin can retract any of these cubes (taking a couple of rounds to do so) at any time, leaving a seamless wall or floor that closes up in its place, then move the cube through the spaces between the rooms and extrude it elsewhere within the structure.

More cubes are found in areas near the ruin's external damage, as if it has created or relocated them to help protect against intruders.

This ruin is protected by many "golden warriors"—entities that look like biological creatures of the Ninth World (humans, abhumans, broken hounds, and so on), except each has metallic golden skin and, where its head should be, is a golden cube inscribed with patterns of lines and rectangles. Underneath a golden warrior's armored skin is normal flesh and bone; even their cubical heads are purely biological under the metal shell. These warriors never go more than a mile from the Fragrant Trap, and they act to prevent other creatures from harming the ruin (including salvaging its numenera). They seem to have an innate sense of whether a visitor has harmed the ruin (perhaps by sensing trace chemicals

released by damaged wall panels or cube components) and usually attack “known” looters on sight.

Deeper within the structure (farther away from the outermost damaged areas), there are fewer cubes and golden warriors, and more numenera relating to the site’s apparent purpose instead of its defense. Of course, as the numenera cannot fully be understood by human minds, any conclusions the PCs and players reach after viewing these areas might be confusing and contradictory.

CUBE GAS

A gas affects a creature for about an hour, during which time the creature is generally immune to additional effects of the same instance of the gas. A character exposed to the gas, whether from a direct puff or a lingering dose in a room, can resist with a successful Might defense task. A character who deliberately exposes themselves to the gas (such as intentionally inhaling it from a cube) is automatically affected as if they had failed the task. A character exposed to a direct puff of gas has to make only one Might defense roll against it; a character in a room infused with the gas must make a Might defense roll upon entering the room and again for every hour they spend in it.

The gases are level 6 poisons, so type or focus abilities that help against poison, or devices such as an **antivenom** cypher, can resist or reverse these effects. Each gas has a different scent and effect; roll on the table to randomly determine what gas a particular cube makes. (Some rooms add to the roll, allowing for results above 100.)

If a character is under the effect of two or more cube gases, they might have another problem on their hands—see Golden Warrior Curse, below.

d100 Scent and Effect

01–10	Blood; mild hallucinations cause disorientation, hindering all actions
11–20	Campfire; eases all attack and defense tasks; when the effect ends, character moves one step down the damage track
21–30	Cooking oil; sense of touch heightened, easing all touch-based sense rolls by two steps
31–40	Salt water; flesh toughens and turns gold, adding 1 to Armor
41–50	Wet stone; grows color-shifting fur on flesh and equipment that eases stealth tasks
51–60	Wood; grows hollow horns (on head or shoulders) that ease hearing tasks by two steps
61–70	Animal breath; all Speed Pool costs increased by 1 (minimum 1 point)
71–80	Burning synth; slow-acting nerve poison, every ten minutes the character must succeed at a Might defense roll or take 3 points of Speed damage
81–90	Old man sweat; +3 to Armor against fire (01–50) or electricity (51–100)
91–100	Ozone; automatically detect the presence of golden warriors within a short distance
101–110	Perfume; all Intellect Pool costs increased by 2 (minimum 2 points)
111–120	Savory food; seeing a creature damaging the ruin (salvaging counts) fills them with rage and makes them attack for one or two rounds
121–130	Backward; temporarily gain Vanish as a new type ability
131–140	Blue; character exhales clouds of sparkling gnats that persist for a few rounds before vanishing

To make things less predictable for the characters, roll twice on the table—once for the scent, and again for the effect—or choose a scent that’s similar to the one that you rolled (leaves instead of wood, fur instead of animal breath, and so on).

GM intrusions:

A helpful gas’ effects last half as long as normal, or ends at just the wrong moment.

A harmful gas’ effects last twice as long as normal.



Antivenom, page 276



Vanish, page 48

Numenera or character abilities may be able to reverse an ongoing or completed transformation, but the golden warrior is likely to physically resist any attempts to do so—even if it is their allies making the attempt.

For a character under the effect of multiple harmful cube gases, transformation into a golden warrior might be the fastest way to save their life.

Because NPCs and creatures don't make Might defense rolls, use this guideline to determine when one of level 6 or lower becomes a golden warrior: being affected by two cube gases at once means a 50 percent chance of transforming, three means 75 percent, and four means 100 percent.



Sathosh, page 251

Golden warrior curse: level 6 (which is the default difficulty for anything regarding this site)

141–150	Childhood; when the player rolls an odd number on a task roll, character is compelled to announce a different unremarkable truth about themselves (such as “I like soup,” “My eyes are brown,” or “I am attacking”)
151–160	Fear; character can look up and see the exact location of the moon and various artificial objects in orbit, even if indoors or underground
161–170	Questions; character gains an extra shadow, cast by an unseen light that is positioned high to the northwest; any creature touching the shadow for a full round takes 2 points of radiation damage
171+	Unidentifiable; spending an action studying a creature within immediate range allows the character to see into the creature's flesh, revealing worm-like parasitic infestations

GOLDEN WARRIOR CURSE

The strange truth of the ruin's warriors is that they aren't artificial beings created by the ruin—they are regular creatures that have been transformed into golden warriors, and other intruders (such as the PCs) can get transformed against their will. Any nearby settlement probably calls this a “curse,” but it is merely a local numenera effect.

At any time that a character is under the effect of two or more cube gases, they are at risk of experiencing a painful metamorphosis into a golden warrior. As a GM intrusion (either from you offering XP or a player rolling a natural 1 on a d20), the character must succeed at a Might defense roll or undergo the **curse**. Each gas affecting them beyond two hinders this defense roll by one step (one step for three gases, two steps for four, and so on).

A character who fails this defense roll physically transforms over the course of about a minute (during which time the transformation could be halted or reversed using numenera or character abilities). The new golden warrior retains their personality, goals, and temperament. However, they gain two permanent compulsions: they don't want to be more than a mile away from the ruin, and they don't want anyone to harm the ruin (including salvaging its numenera). They will take violent action to resist breaking these compulsions, but a successful Intellect defense roll allows the golden warrior to resist their compulsions for about ten minutes.

Having a cube head doesn't affect a golden warrior's abilities, senses, or attacks in any way. Despite its head being physically smooth, the creature can hear, smell, see, and (somehow) even bite and swallow. While within the ruin they do not need to eat, breathe, or sleep, and they become immune to cube gas (which immediately ends any cube gas effect they were experiencing at the time of their transformation). They have the normal lifespan of a creature of their original kind.

Golden warrior NPCs and creatures tend to work together even if their original species were enemies. For example, **sathosh** hate most other kinds of creatures, but a sathosh golden warrior would ally with other kinds of golden warriors to protect this site. It might not socialize or trade with them, but it would avoid conflicts with them.

DATASPHERE CONNECTION

The device in area 7 can be used for several forms of transportation, including a teleportation network and a vertice. The entry frame for the vertice looks like a narrow path between two white cliffs with a dark sky overhead, the ground covered in pale dust; in

this simulated space, characters can't climb the cliffs, and horizontal movement seems no faster than walking in the real. However, although the path looks about a mile long, a character can travel its length after walking for about a minute. On the far end is a metal structure that connects to "underground" frames—perhaps links to a smaller datasphere exclusive to the moon, without any other direct connections to the datasphere of the Ninth World.

SITE LOCATIONS

The following are specific locations at this site. A yellow square on the map indicates the location of a golden cube. Each room's description explains whether its cube's gas fills the entire room or makes individual attacks on creatures.

All interior walls are white, grey, orange, or black synth, or a combination of synth colors.



1. SATHOSH BREACH

READ ALOUD

A large section of the outer wall has been torn or blasted away, probably by a detonation or impact by something large and hot. A light mist clings to the area. Pale lights flicker inside the structure, illuminating a lot of orange and black synth debris, with a path through the junk leading inward.

This location describes two of the four points where the demolished part of the structure allows access to the interior. The local guardians have cleared a path on the floor and watch over this entrance from farther in.

The guardians are several gaunt, gold-skinned humanoids with a metal cube where their head should be, armed with

Sathosh golden warrior: level 3, climb as level 5, resists mental attacks as level 6; health 9; Armor 1; two adjacent warriors can make a short-range mental attack that inflicts 6 points of Intellect damage (ignores Armor); four can attack in melee as a single level 5 foe that inflicts 6 points of damage

Areas 1 and 3 are named for the creatures living there, but those creatures are not responsible for whatever damage created these entrances in the first place, which occurred long before the current residents arrived.

Cube gas, page 33

The voices may try to interact with the PCs in this area by controlling a sathosh warrior, but the abhumans' inability to speak greatly limits communication this way, frustrating the voice.

Broken hound golden warrior: level 2, perception as level 5 due to scent; health 6; Armor 1; bite inflicts 4 points of damage; four to six can attack in melee as a single level 4 foe that inflicts 8 points of damage

spears and swords (these are **sathosh golden warriors**). Three of the sathosh fight to the death to defend their home, but the fourth retreats to warn other guardians about the invading explorers.

The golden cube in this room isn't visible from outside the ruin—it's half buried under some scrap synth. It shoots a puff of gas at any creature that comes within an immediate distance.

2. SATHOSH LAIR

READ ALOUD

This room is mostly intact, with a high ceiling. Short walls of grey and black synth partially divide it into smaller, semi-private areas. One section of wall has been pried open, with the scrap piled on the floor, revealing some support structures and a large golden cube extending out of the gap. A vaguely familiar scent hangs in the air.

This is one of two areas used as living space by the community of eight sathosh golden warriors that inhabit the ruin. They use the small subdivided spaces as homes for individual families.

The golden cube constantly emits a gentle stream of **cube gas**, filling the entire room.

With their skill at climbing, the sathosh can easily get over any of the partial walls without reducing their movement, and they use this (and the height advantage of fighting from the top of the walls) to their advantage against intruders.

If the combat goes against them, the last one or two sathosh flee to warn the others, and perhaps round up some **broken hound golden warriors** as well.

Divided among the smaller home spaces are d100 shins, a few miscellaneous pieces of equipment of varying quality, and an oddity (either a large synth ring that randomly turns warm or cold when squeezed, or a torn piece of flexible synth that has a moving picture of a running feline creature on it).

3. BROKEN HOUND BREACH

READ ALOUD

A big section of the outer wall has been blasted apart or torn open, probably by an explosion or crushing damage. A faint mist clings to the area. Pale lights flicker deeper within, illuminating haphazard piles of black and orange synth debris and a glint of something large and metallic.

This location describes two of the four points where the demolished part of the structure allows access to the interior. Every few weeks, a sathosh golden warrior from area 1 or 2 comes through here and makes a clearer path to the outside, but the animals that live here make the place more sloppy within a few days.

The guardians are eight gaunt, golden-skinned canine beasts, each with a metal cube where their head should be (these are broken hound golden warriors). They viciously attack any intruder to their lair, but flee (either deeper into the structure or outside) if there are three or fewer of them left. Any fleeing beasts will regroup after an hour and attempt to hunt their new prey.

The golden cube in this room is half buried but still visible from outside the ruin. It shoots a puff of gas at any creature that comes within an immediate distance.

4. COMPULSIVE TRUTH ROOM

READ ALOUD

Mist is barely visible in the air here. A large cube juts out of the ceiling, pressing diagonally through the frame of what might have been a glass panel. The cube is partially torn open along one edge. On the floor underneath it is a neatly swept pile of synth and glass debris, probably from the broken panel. In one corner, a trickle of water runs from a pipe in the ceiling to a small drain on the floor, splashing noisily.

The golden cube in this room is damaged and malfunctioning, releasing

two different gases. It has filled the room with gas that makes creatures speak unremarkable truths (same as a result of 141–150 on the Cube Gas table), but it fires a different gas if anyone approaches it. The gas changes each day; roll d100 and add 30 to determine each day's gas.

Note that because the cube emits two different gases, it's much more likely that any individual creature might be under the effect of at least two gases at the same time, with the potential for an **involuntary transformation**.

Because this room is a convenient source of fresh water, and because it is near several inhabited areas, it is frequently visited by other creatures, making it very likely that the PCs will have an encounter—usually with only one or two creatures—if they spend more than about ten minutes here. If the arriving creatures are outnumbered, they most likely leave and return with reinforcements to oust the intruders.

5. TARGO'S ITERATIVE ROOM

READ ALOUD

The presence of many low walls and shelves makes it hard to see very far in this room of white and orange synth. Partially visible is the corner of a golden cube—but unlike the others in previous rooms, this one seems to be hollow.

The many obstacles here count as **difficult terrain**, and any lights carried by the PCs create angular shadows that seem to shift about, giving many places to hide.

The golden cube is hollow. It is only about as thick as a thumb, and although the outside and most of the insides are smooth, the rear interior face has inscribed markings resembling some sort of interface panel. This cube does not release gases; it is the center of a portal-like device. Activating the cube is an understanding numenera task that is eased by two steps; success means the

center of the cube fills with a multicolored sphere of light that lasts for a few rounds. If the light is touched, all creatures within an immediate distance are pulled into it and vanish. (See the Iteration section, below.)

TARGO

This area is the home of **Targo**, a **culova** warrior who has been transformed into a golden warrior. Lacking any need for food, and unable to move far from the ruin, he has settled in here and made the best of it. He spends his time collecting bits of synth, using the hard, sharp pieces as tools to carve the softer pieces into images of trees, culovas, and other creatures he has seen. Targo is lonely for company—he can't communicate with the sathosh or broken hounds, and wouldn't mind a little conversation.

As long as visitors to the site aren't hostile or threatening to him, and they don't trigger his golden warrior compulsion to protect the ruin from damage, he is willing to answer questions about himself, the ruin, and its other inhabitants. Unfortunately, his forest life prior to getting caught here was very simple and he is about as interesting to talk to as a person in a sheltered remote village. He has been here a year or two (he left his original home because of a forest fire and took shelter in the ruin).

Targo can't help the PCs fight any other golden warriors, but he can sketch a map of the ruin, tell them what creatures live where, and give a description of areas 6 and 7 (he doesn't understand what he saw there, but it amazed and frightened him). Targo doesn't know how to activate the hollow cube in this room, but he has seen its "glowing circle" appear on its own a couple of times.

If attacked, he makes use of concealment and multiple levels in this area to retreat. He would much rather hide than fight, and will abandon this

Targo, culova golden warrior: level 4, climb and stealth as level 6; health 20; Armor 3; moves a long distance each round; can spray venom on all in immediate range, inflicting 4 points of Speed damage (ignores Armor) with a failed Might defense roll



Culova, page 231

Golden warrior curse, page 34



Difficult terrain, page 117

area for hours or days (living outside for a while if he has to) to avoid conflict, unless his golden warrior compulsions force him to be aggressive.

THE ITERATION

Any PCs pulled into the portal are momentarily blinded by a mixture of light and darkness. When they can see again, they are in a room that is essentially the same. A character who spends at least a couple of rounds carefully observing or searching their surroundings realizes things are a little different—the partial walls seem taller and more angular, the shadows seem to flicker more, and sounds and smells are a bit more intense. Any PCs left behind in the original room are present here but slightly changed—thinner, more spiky, and more strange. Targo also has a counterpart here, one who seems weirder and a little intimidating (if the PCs don't meet him until a later, scarier iteration of this room, they're more likely to perceive him as a threat).

The PCs (whether those who were transported here or the near-copies already present) can use the cube device multiple times (at the same difficulty as before) to move “forward” through iterations, each time entering a sharper, creepier version of the room with sharper, creepier versions of everyone who didn't travel. Eventually the distortions become bizarre—Targo gets larger and gains extra legs and additional cube body parts, PCs get taller and gain extra eyes and fingers, equipment changes shape or material, the walls look liquid or fleshy, and so on. None of these changes are harmful or provide any benefit; they're just disturbing.

The cube can also navigate “backward,” shifting one iteration at a time toward the original version of the room. Using the cube this way is at the normal difficulty (not eased by two steps), so it's possible that the characters are lost in a weird

ITERATION GM TIPS

The PCs left behind should play their counterparts in the new room, and they don't see their current state as unusual. In effect, there are multiple copies of each PC, with a shared mind and no awareness that there are multiple copies or realities, and they always consider the current version of reality to be normal. Not only does this make the situation feel more strange, but it means that players whose characters remained behind in the original room can still participate in what's going on.

When coupled with the hallucination cube gas, the characters might start to wonder what is or isn't real. Emphasize that the changes in the new versions of the room are quite real to everyone present. If Belesar the Jack now has pointy fingernails, everyone can see and feel them. And, as far as Belesar can remember, he's always had pointy fingernails, even if the iteration-hopping PCs don't remember him as having them.

iteration for a while until they can manage the more difficult challenges of getting all the way “home.”

The effects of the strange iterations are not limited to this room; if the PCs travel “forward” through one or more iterations, they're now living in a slightly different world than the one they left. The effect of this experience can be an ongoing element of the rest of the campaign as they keep encountering odd changes from their normal reality, or they can spontaneously snap “backward” to a more normal iteration over time.



For each iteration beyond the original one, add 20 to all cube gas rolls.

Are these iterations pocket dimensions that bleed into the Ninth World? Parallel realities? Waves of quantum change pushed out by a prior-world device? Or all of the above?

You can encourage hesitant PCs to use the iteration device by giving each iteration “forward” a 50 percent chance to have an oddity, iotum, or cypher sitting out in plain view that wasn't present in the previous iteration.

6. PRISTINE ROOM

READ ALOUD

The grey and black synth walls are partially obscured by white and orange synth panels that float above the ground, forming several closet-like spaces along a path through the room. One of these spaces has a golden cube. Unlike the outer rooms, the cube is not attached to anything; it floats a hand's breadth above the floor.

This is one of many interior areas that are far enough away from the outer, damaged portion of the structure that salvagers haven't gotten to them yet; therefore the room is unharmed. There is a 50 percent chance that the cube has filled the room with gas; otherwise, the cube is the sort that fires at nearby creatures. Add 50 to all cube gas rolls for this room.

The floating panels reconfigure themselves a few times each day, dividing the room into small, closet-like spaces with narrow doorways (which may be horizontal, vertical, or diagonal). The closets always appear to be approximately the same size relative to each other, regardless of their configuration or number (they may change from eleven large closets to five small closets to twenty tiny closets).

When the panels shift, the cube moves on its own, either slowly floating into a finished closet or rapidly flying across the room and waiting for panels to arrange themselves around it.



The first time the PCs attempt to manipulate or salvage a cube in a room like this, it creates pulses of light on its surface that the character can interact with as if deciphering a strange **code**. If they succeed, an oddity that looks like a fist-sized golden barrel materializes out of the cube. Pressing either flat end of the oddity creates a harmless burst of scent (any of the cube gas scents). Within this ruin, carrying the golden barrel counts as an asset on defense rolls to resist cube gas.

7. MOON APOCALYPSE PLANETARIUM

READ ALOUD

The walls and floor of this room are mottled orange and white, and the broad, domed ceiling is a uniform dark grey. Rounded synth hexagons are scattered all over the floor, and five small golden cubes are affixed along the edges of the ceiling. After a moment, the low, indirect light dims, and pinpoints of light appear on the ceiling, forming semi-familiar constellations. One bright spot resolves into an image of the moon. Overall, viewing the ceiling resembles looking up into a clear night sky.

The lights automatically dim and the ceiling starts to show stars when any human-sized creature is within an immediate distance of either of the room's doorways. If all creatures leave the room, the night sky image fades and the ambient light level increases to a soft, **steady glow**.

The synth hexagons are a bit larger than what a human might use as a mattress or cushion. They are soft, but so old that they are incredibly brittle and collapse into hairy powder with anything but the gentlest touch.

Within about a minute of a creature entering the room, the night scene shown on the ceiling zooms in on the moon, stopping when the image is a little larger

GM intrusion: *The floating panels suddenly shift. If the character fails a Speed defense roll, they become trapped in a small space with, or near, the cube, which fires gas at them each round until they can get away.*

Cube code: level 6

If golden warriors battle the characters in area 6, the walls always seem to move to the warriors' advantage, sometimes even shifting to provide cover from an attack.



Cover, page 113

Remember that rooms like these are good places for the PCs to find rival explorers (page 84)—or the bodies of unlucky creatures.



Very dim light, page 114

The real moon in the night sky sometimes has a visible green band around it. That band may or may not appear in the images of the moon shown in this room, whether or not it is currently visible on the real moon.

If the real moon is above the horizon right now, and a character is affected by the cube gas that allows them to see the positions of the moon and orbiting objects, that character can confirm that the moon's position shown in this room matches that of their gas-induced perception.



Erynth grask, page 235

For more information on the moon of the Ninth World and other mysteries of the solar system, see Into the Night.

The voices may try to interact with the PCs in this area by changing the image of the moon to something else, such as the voice's typical face. The normal disaster scenarios continue to happen around this change, often to bizarre effect.

Group GM intrusion:
An erratically-functioning simulator makes the disaster experience more lifelike for everyone in the room. Rock fragments or monster tentacles crash through the ceiling, the temperature rises or falls, the floor shakes as if from an earthquake, and so on. Characters who succeed at an Intellect defense roll realize the sensations are intended to deceive.

than the height of a human. (Unless the characters have used telescopes or distance-viewing devices, this is probably the most detailed view of the moon they have ever had.) After another minute, the image changes (as if watching live events), showing a terribly destructive event happening to the moon, followed by the consequences of that destruction. Then, the ceiling image goes dark for a minute before a new cycle starts. The ceiling plays several different disasters, including the following (in no particular order):

- A shooting star approaches from the background, strikes the moon, and shatters it into several large pieces, which begin tumbling toward Earth, and heating up as they approach.
- A violet light flashes on the surface, revealing a crater or sinkhole that gradually widens as the entire moon collapses into nothingness, leaving only a black sphere ringed with violet light, which begins to fall toward Earth.
- The moon cracks open from the inside like an enormous egg, revealing a gigantic, wormlike creature resembling an **erynth grask**, which reaches out to clutch at Earth with its mouth-tentacles.
- Hundreds of panels all over the moon's surface flip open, releasing white, mountain-sized, insect-like creatures that begin floating toward Earth; the inside of the moon is filled with more of these creatures.
- A seam appears around the circumference of the moon, dividing it into two equal pieces; one drifts away and the other steadily looms closer.
- A huge, burning machine passes in front of the moon, breaking it into several large pieces that come crashing together in a new configuration, with tiny pieces turning into falling stars.
- Wispy waves of energy from Earth impact the moon in a dozen places, breaking it into hundreds of smaller

moons and dust that settles into a glittering path across the night.

A character can use the understanding numenera skill to manipulate one of the golden cubes to show a specific scenario from the above list, including playing it forward or backward in slow motion. In some, the background details like constellations are clearly not the same as the real night sky—or at least not visible from the local part of the Ninth World. There is no way to use the machine to tell if the images on the dome are simulations, a recording of something that already happened (on Earth or elsewhere), glimpses into alternate worlds, or visions from the future.

Any character who spends at least ten minutes working with the cubes in this room becomes aware that there are inactive (perhaps damaged) machines built into the walls that have a transportation function. If they are repaired (a task taking several days, and probably some valuable iotum), this room can be used as a vertice, a teleporter to a human-inhabited fortress on the south pole of the moon, or both (as appropriate to your campaign).



CHAPTER 6

BLADE INTERSTICE

LEVEL 5

 READ ALOUD

Thousands of rods are embedded in the ground, forming a meandering fence that weaves around large boulders, glowing structures, odd trees, and other natural features. Some of the rods are crystal and some are metal. They range from the height of a typical human to nearly three times that high. Narrow gaps between the rods allow brief glimpses of what lies beyond them. Overall, it forms something like a maze.

Overview: An outdoor maze of crystals, metal, and strange plants, haunted by *abykoses* and vapes (see box on page 43). Devices in the area implant slices of metal into the bodies of intruders, granting them assets against extradimensional and subdimensional creatures and objects.

Rumors: The people of Redgarden (only a day's journey away) say that the ruin places devices in human bodies to monitor their activities and read their thoughts. The site calls bladehounds and demons to come here from all over the world (or perhaps other worlds) and hunt innocent people. Sleeping at its heart is an entity known as the Houndmaster, who waits for a predestined moment to awaken and start a grand hunt that will eradicate the iron wind from the Ninth World.

Common Cyphers: *Infiltrator*, *monoblade*, *motion sensor*, *phase changer*, *phase disruptor*

Voices: *Aorut*'s influence makes the vapes more dangerous (level 3, health 15). The *abykoses* seek out devices relating to the datasphere as well as transdimensional devices.

Etranv wants to understand the overall purpose of this ruin, in particular how physical bodies can be improved and strengthened by the use of specific implants (as part of a long-term goal to build better bodies for her agents in the real). In order to make the place safer for her minions, she makes the vapes more intelligent (nearly on par with humans) but wary, and the *abykoses* are more likely to observe than attack, even when transdimensional devices are present. Alternatively, her minions need to clear out the vapes and *abykoses* (perhaps with the help of the PCs) before they can do the work she wants.

Isijaan sometimes (as a GM intrusion) enlarges a vape to double its size, increasing its level and modifiers by 2 levels and its health by 10 points.

Blade Interstice is an open-air numenera ruin resembling a maze containing several small park-like areas. The walls or fences of the maze are made of vertical rods of crystal or metal, ranging from 6 to 20 feet (2 to 6 m) in height, each about as thick as a human wrist, and separated by gaps about the width of a human finger. Any pieces broken off of a rod crumble into drit within a few minutes, and the remaining

Voices (*Aorut*, *Etranv*, *Isijaan*), page 82

Consider placing this site northwest of Keford in the Sea Kingdom Ghan.



Keford, page 142

Abykos, page 224

Subdimensional: existing in fewer than three dimensions, such as a "flat" two-dimensional creature, a "line" one-dimensional creature, or something that is effectively two-dimensional, such as a *monoblade cypher*.



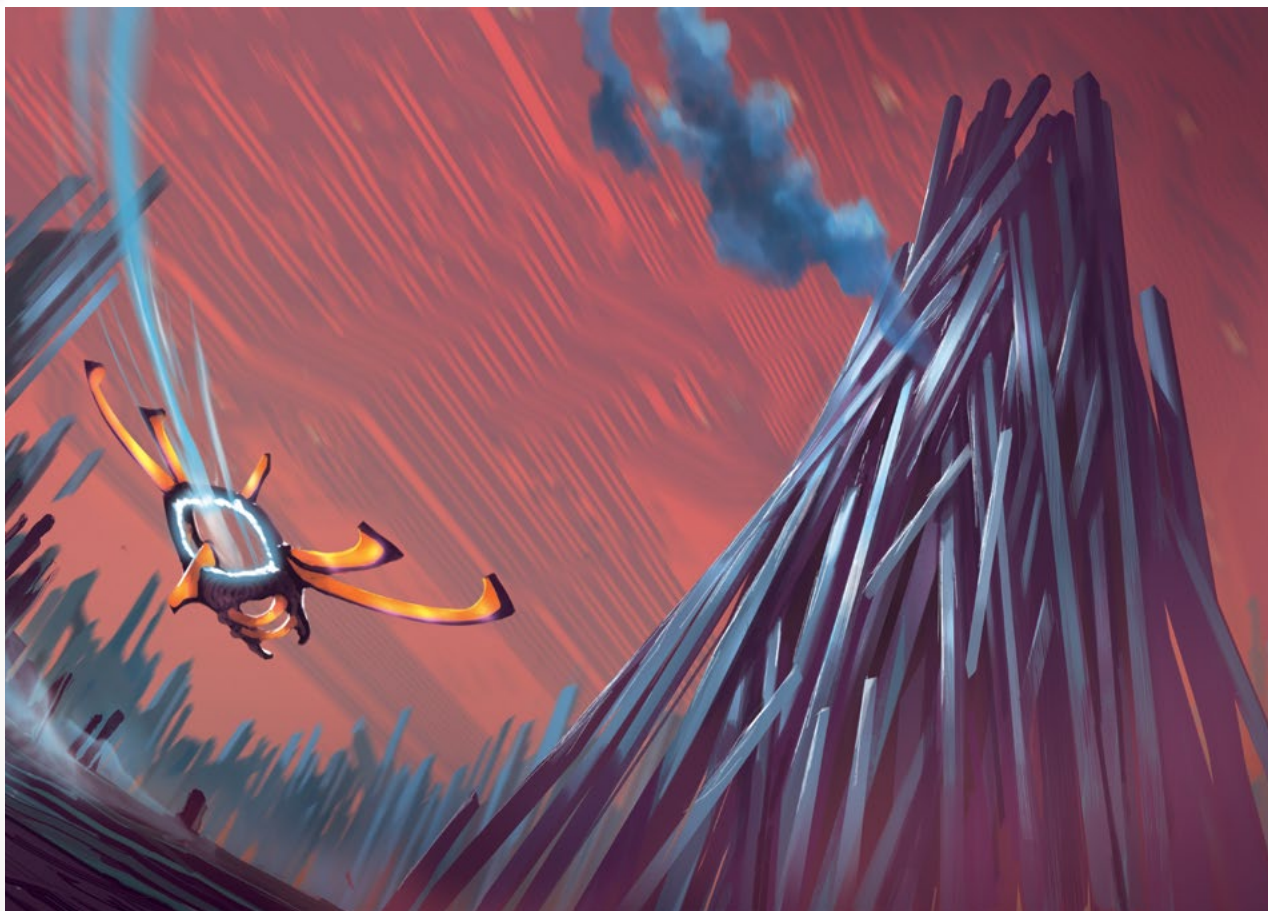
Infiltrator, page 281

Monoblade, page 283

Motion sensor, page 283

Phase changer, page 284

Phase disruptor, page 284



portion of the rod regrows its missing parts over the next day or two. Each rod extends at least 9 feet (3 m) into the ground and is embedded in a large subterranean structure.

The gaps in the fence allow creatures to see through it, but unless the observing creature is right next to the fence (and able to carefully peer through a gap), the view is hindered by two steps. Ranged abilities and attacks work through it but likewise are hindered by two steps, with a miss usually meaning the ability instead targets the fence itself (which may be dangerous if it is an area attack like [Flash](#)). Melee attacks through the fence generally fail unless the attack is narrow enough to pierce the gap and the attacker and defender are both very close to the fence.

Nothing prevents creatures from climbing or flying over the fence, although its smoothness and configuration means climbing it is a difficulty 5 task.

The park-like areas contain natural terrain—dirt, and local plants and animals such as grass and birds. Some have smaller structures, others are completely open, and a few have low metal or stone platforms as if they used to contain something.

Several ruins similar to this one are located within a dozen miles of here. However, they have no dangerous inhabitants (other than perhaps a predator incidentally sniffing around for prey) and no active devices—they are essentially inert mazes of crystal and stone. Local people who know about the Blade Interstice almost certainly avoid these harmless copies under the assumption that all of the sites host similar threats. And perhaps they do but they have fallen into disrepair, they need to be reactivated from a control interface in the Blade Interstice, or their primary functionality is within the datasphere rather than the real.



Flash, page 40

GM intrusion: A ranged attack aimed through the fence rebounds off of it and targets the attacker or an area near the attacker.

VAPES

Other than abykoses, the primary inhabitants of this site are creatures called vapes. A vape's entire body is a molecule-thin blade—from head on, it looks like a thread-thin black line stretching up from the ground to shoulder height. Only when it turns or is seen from the side is the vape revealed as a massive, furred, vaguely canine creature, long muzzled and sharp toothed, with piercing eyes. Vapes have animal-level intelligence and hunt in packs. Because they are essentially flat, they can ignore physical terrain that hinders movement, such as water, snow, mud, or the vertical-rod fences at the Blade Interstice site (but not fully solid obstacles like a wall or energy structures such as a curtain of fire or a force field).

The entire area is frequently visited by abykoses and molecule-thin predators called vapes. The two kinds of creatures never attack each other (unless controlled by an outside force, such as a cypher in the hands of a PC) and generally ignore each other's presence, although if one type of creature starts fighting intruders, the other type usually comes to observe and might strike at or chase down a fleeing enemy. Because abykoses spend most of their time in a parallel dimension, and because vapes are very thin, both can easily pass through the maze fence to ambush PCs, or quickly flee into an area that the PCs can only reach by climbing the fence or going the long way around it. Both kinds of creatures make use of this advantage, although the vapes do so more on an instinctive animal level, and the abykoses plan intelligently using this strategy.

Neither of these creatures seem to actively defend the site or attempt to make use of its numenera. They don't retaliate against anyone attacking or

A slain vape can sometimes be salvaged for a monoblade cypher.

Vapes are also known as bladehounds. A group of vapes is called a rake.



salvaging it, they don't stay in one particular part of it, and they seem free to leave or return as they like (when local prey is scarce, the vapes hunt nearby but return here every few days). The ruin might be subconsciously drawing them here, creating them, or transcribing them from the datasphere.

Altogether there are anywhere from four to ten abykoses within a day's travel of the site, although they usually wander (and attack) alone or in pairs. There are usually ten to twenty vapes within a few miles of Blade Interstice, and they prefer to

GM Tip: Don't try to draw the maze on a table map, and don't force the PCs to navigate all the twists and turns. They can see through the maze "walls" well enough to get where they want to go—it just takes longer than normal. Use the maze to slow them down and create interesting encounters where the PCs are semi-trapped and their foes are very maneuverable.



Monoblade, page 283

Chronal feeder: A human-sized insectoid creature attracted to disruptions in spacetime. See The Ninth World Bestiary, page 31.

Jurulisk: A one-dimensional ultraterrestrial that joins with others of its kind to make a "framework" that can interact with three-dimensional creatures. See The Ninth World Bestiary, page 69.



Fuses Flesh and Steel, page 74

An implanted device allows blood, nerve signals, and other necessary biological connections to pass through it so the flesh beyond it can function normally.

If you're concerned about the permanent improvements these implants give characters, in a few weeks or months, start offering GM intrusions that the devices are starting to fail. A PC can reject the intrusion by spending 1 XP, and could stave off the failure indefinitely by spending XP for the device as a long-term benefit, similar to spending XP to acquire an artifact



Long-term benefits, page 126

attack in packs of four to six. Sometimes exceptional individuals of either type (+1 or +2 to all levels) remain near the site for a few weeks at a time.

CROSS-SECTIONAL DEVICES

Several structures at this site have the ability to surgically implant devices in a creature's body. Each device looks like a thin metal plate no more than a quarter inch (6 mm) thick that fills a cross-section of the creature's body. For example, if the implant is in a human character's lower left arm, it might look like they're wearing a tight metal bracelet, but the material goes completely through their wrist, and their arm is slightly longer than their (unmodified) right arm. If implanted in the neck, it resembles a snug necklace or choker. The minimal extra length of the device doesn't affect worn armor or clothing, impede the character's ability to use that part of their body (even for wielding two-handed weapons), or impact their other abilities—even a character with the **Fuses Flesh and Steel** focus who has a metal endoskeleton can't feel the difference. The devices aren't straight relative to any traditional axis of the body (a device in the torso might cross from the left armpit to the right hip), but this doesn't seem to reduce their effectiveness.

Each device is made of a particular color of metal and grants the host a specific benefit against transdimensional and duo-dimensional creatures (such as abykoses and vapes):

- **Blue:** Implanted in the arm by the Yellow Tree; gives +1 Armor against these creatures
- **Gold:** Implanted in the torso by the Tangled Spider; grants an asset on Speed defense tasks against these creatures
- **Grey:** Implanted in the leg by the Cone Tower; allows host to use an action to

sense (via an itching feeling) if there are any of these creatures within a long distance.

- **Red:** Implanted in the neck or head by the Strawberry Boulder; grants an asset on perception tasks to detect these creatures

Although primarily effective against abykoses and vapes, these implants also work against other kinds of creatures able to change their phase (such as a **chronal feeder**), other molecule-thin creatures and attacks (such as a **monoblade**), and entities that exist in fewer than three dimensions in the Ninth World (such as a **jurulisk**).

Obviously, a host with all four implants is very effective at dealing with the local threats, making it relatively easy to kill or scatter the hostile creatures and make use of the site without distractions.

Removing an implanted device without killing the patient is a difficulty 7 surgery task that takes several hours. The task is eased by two steps if the surgeon doesn't try to preserve and reattach body parts beyond the device (such as a hand or arm below the site of the implantation).

DATASPHERE CONNECTION

Creatures can pass from the real to the datasphere or vice versa through the installation known as the Light House (page 46). Note that phase-changing creatures such as abykoses can use their abilities in the datasphere, but rather than shifting in or out of a true parallel dimension, they move to and from a limited parallel frame called the Echo (resembling a monochromatic transparent version of the main frame), which in practice works almost identically to phasing in the real.

The similar structures near the Blade Interstice are probably damaged or deactivated frames within the main node. If restored to their normal functionality,

they have substructures of their own and may link to other interesting nodes.

SITE LOCATIONS

The following are specific locations at this site.

1. CONE TOWER

READ ALOUD

Large rods—similar to the ones that form the maze, but twice as thick—jumble and twist together to form a huge cylinder that tapers to a point. Near the top of this structure is a small opening that emits a stream of blue mist. Irregularities in the outer surface might be a narrow ledge spiraling up from the ground to the top.

The Cone Tower is about 30 feet (9 m) high. It looks rough and unfinished, like a very large creature twisted and mashed together its component rods on a whim, rather than something that was planned and measured to fit together smoothly.

Anyone in contact with the tower can feel it gently and quietly vibrating. Its spiraling exterior ledge winds all the way around, easing climbing the tower by two steps, but, since the ledge is very narrow and irregular, any physical actions taken while standing on it are hindered. This penalty also applies to abykoses but not the vapes, which are thin enough that the ledge is like a wide road for them.

The opening at the top is more like a crawlspace than a normal door, but is large enough that a human can get into it. The blue mist issues from the edge of the opening, not from inside the tower. The mist is warm and has an odd but not unpleasant smell, like an unfamiliar food.

Any creature that touches or is touched by the mist must succeed at a Might



Weak force fields: *level 3*
Cross-sectional devices,
page 44



Cosmetic mutations,
page 402

GM intrusion:
A character slips from the ledge or drops an important item. They can catch themselves or the item if they succeed on a Speed task; otherwise, they or it falls to the ground.

A lurking abykos decides to attack while a character is in one of the crawlspaces.

The voices may try to interact with the PCs in this area by arranging the motes into a face and speaking through it.

In this datasphere node, abykoses look like glowing, transparent, coiled worms, and vapes look like holographic teeth projected onto two-dimensional cards. Their abilities and stats are otherwise the same as in the real.

defense roll or be invaded by nanobots that begin building a grey **cross-sectional device** in one of their legs over the next few minutes. This isn't painful, but it itches and feels warm, and once it is complete, the creature feels especially hungry (like they missed a meal). A side effect of this implantation is that the creature gains a temporary random **cosmetic mutation** lasting for a few days. What mutation the surgical mist causes changes every few hours, so several creatures who interact with the mist in a short period of time usually end up with the same mutation. Once the mist has implanted the device in a creature, exposing that creature to the mist at a later time doesn't trigger another device implantation or any more mutations.

Inside the tower is a narrow space with many metal and crystal cylinders (resembling power conduits). Because of the cramped space, all physical actions here are hindered by two steps. This space (and its cylinders) only goes about halfway down into the structure, but several branches of it extend laterally outward, even beyond the outer walls of the tower, each making slight turns at various points. These crawlspaces (and anything in them) are not visible or tangible from outside the tower because they extend into a parallel dimension. A typical human can't go farther than about 30 feet (9 m) into these spaces before they become too narrow to proceed.

2. LIGHT HOUSE

READ ALOUD

Pale blue energy beams form the skeleton of a leaning five-sided structure with a concave roof. The energy dimly illuminates the inside of this quasi-structure, no brighter than candlelight. Occasional motes of this blue energy drift from the beam intersections toward the center of the floor.

The energy beams are **weak force fields** that don't seem to have a purpose other than containing the light. Destroying a section of a force field causes the light inside it to flicker out, but after a few minutes, the beam resets and the light returns. The gaps between the beams are far enough apart in most places that a human can easily walk through them. From inside the structure, light always appears faint, even if it is a bright day outside.

This installation is the operational section of the site's vertice. A creature within it can steer the floating motes by touch (requiring an understanding numenera task for each attempt). After several rounds of doing so, the number of motes increases and they begin clinging to any creature inside the structure, and one round later, the Light House transcribes all of those creatures to the datasphere. The node where they arrive resembles a brightly colored, stylized version of the maze, with rods of light instead of crystal and metal.

The Light House requires about ten minutes to recharge between each use, whether it is transcribing one creature or several at a time. A person with the understanding numenera or crafting numenera skill can figure out how to use a powered cypher or artifact to recharge it in just a few rounds; doing so destroys the cypher or requires a depletion roll for the artifact.

3. STRAWBERRY BOULDER

READ ALOUD

This boulder is the size of several carts pushed together, and is made of mottled grey and black stone. It vaguely resembles a clenched fist resting with the thumb edge along the ground. It gives off a strong odor of sweet fruit.

Although the boulder looks like common stone, it is a numenera structure that has become depleted of the resources

it needs for its normal functions. The dark spots on its surface are porous areas that connect to its interior, which is filled with a red nanofluid (the source of the fruit smell) that reacts to the presence of cyphers of level 5 or higher. If a suitable cypher comes within short range of the boulder, drops of the fluid rise to its surface on the side where the cypher is. If the cypher comes within an immediate distance of the boulder, these drops extend toward it like thin fungal hairs, up to a distance of about 1.5 feet (45 cm). If the hairs are allowed to touch the cypher, the nanofluid envelops it and begins to dissolve it into useful components, harmlessly destroying the cypher; the hairs and the absorbed components then retreat into the boulder.

One round after absorbing a cypher, the nanofluid spurts out at the creature who carried the cypher, striking it in the head or neck if the creature fails a Speed defense roll. If the attack misses, the puddle of fluid attempts this attack for two more rounds before becoming inert. If the attack succeeds, the nanofluid painfully assembles a red cross-sectional device in that part of the creature's body over the next six rounds, inflicting 2 points of damage each round (ignores Armor). The creature is conscious and able to take actions while this is happening, although only something that destroys active numenera can interrupt the process, and all of the character's actions are hindered by two steps while the implantation occurs.

The boulder can create one red implant for every cypher of level 5 or higher it touches. It might be able to dissolve an artifact (of level 5 or higher) in the same way it does a cypher (your decision as the GM) and produce up to four implants from its absorbed materials.

If the boulder is broken open, the nanofluid spills out and mindlessly transforms anything it lands on into crystal and metal (inflicting 5 points of

damage per round to flesh) before self-destructing in a few rounds. The fluid might manage to assemble into a few units of iotum or a couple of cyphers (all of level 3 or lower) before it becomes inert. The broken-open boulder has a hollow space large enough to fit two humans, but without the nanofluid, the structure has no abilities.

4. TANGLED SPIDER

READ ALOUD

This cluster of tall rods initially seems to be part of the maze, but their metal is dull red, and rather than being perfectly straight, each rod is slightly bent in several places, as if they were jointed legs of some very tall creature. Above the rods is a blurry disturbance in the air.

This 20-foot (6 m) tall structure is ambulatory; the red rods are its legs, and the blurred area above it is three small rooms obscured by a cloaking device. Although when idle it tends to return to the marked spot on the map, it can use its rod-legs to walk almost anywhere in the site, easily stepping over most parts of the fence, and looking something like an invisible spider jerkily twitching its visible limbs.

The **Tangled Spider** is semi-intelligent and curious about visitors, though it's likely to remain at least a short distance away from them (usually separated from them by one or more of the maze walls), observing their movements and other actions. It is not particularly stealthy—its movement sounds like large stilts impacting the dirt—but the shape of its legs and its cloaking device mean it often remains unnoticed for long periods of time.

The cloaking device is ineffective against any creature directly underneath the spider (between all of its legs), allowing them an unobstructed view of its lobed red metal body and an open circular doorway at the center of its legs. The spider doesn't try to

Tangled Spider: level 6, Speed defense as level 7 due to cloaking device; health 30; Armor 3; heals 5 health per round, makes three leg attacks per round



The Golden Room completes surgery on any particular creature only once, although if a creature without a gold implanted device leaves the room and returns, it will again attempt to implant them.

Cross-sectional devices, page 44

GM intrusion: *In addition to its normal attacks, the Tangled Spider grabs a character and attempts to stuff them into the Golden Room to be processed. The character can resist with a Might or Speed defense roll.*

prevent anyone from entering it, although it does strike back (using its legs, bending at strange angles to poke inside itself) at intruders that try to damage or salvage it. It is generally not hostile, but it might fixate on one or more characters and attempt to push them into the Golden Room (see below), even if they are in the middle of doing something else, including fighting vapes or other creatures.

The entry room is unfurnished, unlit, and plain, barely large enough to fit two humans at the same time. Two open doorways lead diagonally upward into two chambers that differ mainly by the faint color of their very dim lights—one golden, one blue. If a creature enters either of those rooms (or is placed there by the spider), the lights become very bright.

The Golden Room is about 10 feet (3 m) across. Any creature entering it, willingly

or unwillingly, is restrained by prehensile red metal tentacles extending from the walls (Might or Speed defense roll to avoid or break free every round). Any creature that is successfully restrained is anaesthetized and knocked unconscious (Might defense roll to resist), at which time the room spends the next three rounds surgically implanting a gold **cross-sectional device** through their torso, which inflicts 10 points of damage (ignores Armor). If the creature survives, it is injected with healing nanobots that grant an immediate free recovery roll. After the surgery is complete, the creature is awakened and the restraints are removed. If the creature leaves the Golden Room, the spider attempts to gently pull them from the entry room and place them on the ground, but it stops if the creature resists.

The Blue Room is about 10 feet (3 m) across. If a creature enters it, the room activates a pattern of lights, hard puffs of air, and noticeable but harmless temperature changes that last for several minutes. If a creature leaves before this pattern finishes, the room emits a noisy screech like a steam whistle for a few seconds; if all creatures leave the room, the pattern completely stops once the screech ends.

5. YELLOW TREE

READ ALOUD

This low tree has multiple trunks growing out of the ground and many branches that spread wide and droop downward. Most of its surface, including the trunk, is covered in yellow lichen-like dots, and only in a few places is cream-colored bark visible. Dangling from the branches are hundreds of round, bright yellow fruits.

Any creature within a short distance of the Yellow Tree can feel a gentle pushing and pulling on their skin, similar to a gentle water current that shifts back and forth.

There is no fallen fruit visible under the tree or in the surrounding area. The tree can choose to drop its fruit (see below), but if one is removed from the tree by an external force (such as a strong wind or being plucked by a creature), the fruit breaks into dozens of yellow ant-like creatures that move to the ground and dig until they're no longer visible.

The tree drops several fruits if a creature the size of a human child or bigger comes within an immediate distance of it. These fruits gently roll toward the creature, moving an immediate distance per round (if the creature gets at least a long distance away, the fruits stop pursuing and break into self-burying ants as described above). The fruits attempt to touch the creature, who can attempt a Speed defense task to avoid each attack. If

successful, the fruits turn into yellow ants that swarm over their target, stinging it dozens of times. If the target fails a Might defense roll, it is paralyzed for a minute, and nanobots injected in the stings use this time to build a blue cross-sectional device in one of the creature's arms. Once this task is completed, the fruit-ants bury themselves in the dirt.

Any creature with a blue cross-sectional device no longer feels the wave-like sensation from being near the Yellow Tree, and the tree no longer drops fruits in their presence.

OTHER ENCOUNTERS

In addition to the encounters described above, any open space in the maze is a potential location for an encounter. You can use any of the following encounters as desired to add tension or a sense of urgency to the characters' exploration of the site.

- A pack of vapes charges in to attack the PCs.
- An abykos appears (as a hazy humanoid shimmer) and observes the PCs, following if they move and retreating if they approach.
- A vape is consuming a prey animal. An incorporeal abykos may be observing the scene.
- One or more abykoses attack the PCs with the intent of draining cyphers or artifacts of their transdimensional energies.
- The PCs find a dead human explorer, partially eaten by vapes. It has typical explorer's gear, but its two cyphers are drained of power and destroyed. A character with the understanding numenera skill can figure out that both probably had phasing effects.
- The PCs find a glowglobe and several other common pieces of equipment, all of them sliced in half and ruined.

The voices may try to interact with the PCs in this area by directly controlling the Tangled Spider, pushing a creature into the Golden Room, and implanting a tiny device that lets them transmit sound directly into the creature's ear.

The Yellow Tree bears fruit all year round, but mostly in the spring, when its fruits are the size of large apples. In the off seasons, its fruits are much smaller, similar to plums or grapes.

CORPSEFLINGER

LEVEL 4

Consider placing this site southeast of the Voil Chasm in the Pytharon Empire.



Voil Chasm, page 150



Rival explorers, page 82



Attractor, page 276

Datasphere siphon, page 277

Detonation (desiccating), page 277

Living solvent, page 282

Visage changer, page 288

Voices (Aorut, Etranv, Isijaan), page 82

Area 3: Shinspinners Colony, page 55

Area 4: Husk-Scriber, page 55

READ ALOUD

Carrion eaters circle in the sky, and the air smells like the aftermath of a battlefield. Hundreds of corpses—some human, some beasts, some unidentifiable—are strewn all over the ground beneath a numenera ruin jutting out of a cliff face. Through a large opening in the ruin, another cadaver is flung out to land with a wet crackling noise a hundred feet below.

Overview: Contains a malfunctioning device that regularly produces corpses of many kinds of creatures. Janitorial automatons throw these cadavers out of a disposal chute, creating a place on the ground full of food for scavengers.

Rumors: The ruin is the home of a demonic cult that sacrifices villagers and travelers in exchange for secrets of the numenera. An underground civilization disposes of its dead by casting them out into the surface world. The numenera tests all who enter, killing the unworthy but elevating to godhood those who are pure of heart and flesh. Anyone killed by the iron wind is transported here.

Common Cyphers: Attractor, datasphere siphon, detonation (desiccating), living solvent, visage changer

Voices: Aorut enhances the intelligence of the shinspinners (area 3) to near-human levels. He encourages these creatures to expand their territory so they can claim the husk-scribing room (area 4)

and can start tinkering with it, perhaps incorporating datasphere numenera into their traps and other devices.

Etranv directly controls the automatons while she is paying attention to this site, but constantly drains energy from them, hindering all of their actions. She is curious about how the vertice is identifying husks all over the datasphere; the automatons are directed to scan and dissect the husks before discarding them outside. Anyone who comes here from the datasphere or attempts to repair the vertice so it can datascribe is the target of similar scrutiny. If visitors attempt to salvage or destroy the vertice, she intervenes with a holographic projection, resorting to attacking with automatons (or rival explorers) only if she cannot persuade the visitors to stop.

Isijaan manipulates the realscribing device so it produces multiple smaller copies of a single husk (totaling approximately the same mass as a solo husk) or fuses together multiple cadavers (usually the currently realscribing and previously realscribed ones) into malformed monstrosities. If the voice is aware of visitors to the structure, they might create a temporary instance of their own consciousness to animate these copies and verbally convey glimmer-like information or riddles, or simply attempt to incite fear.

Corpseflinger is a ruin high above ground level. Within it is a malfunctioning vertice that keeps transcribing the husks (digital dead bodies) of creatures all over



the datasphere, creating fresh corpses here. As the physical bodies pile up, a handful of maintenance automatons try to keep things orderly by disposing of the corpses, but the only way they can keep up is by throwing them out of the ruin through one of the larger openings to the outside. The frequent disposal of corpses makes the land underneath the structure look like a mass grave or a battlefield.

ELEVATED RUIN

The structure is located 100 feet (30 m) up on a cliff face (or, if it better suits your campaign, a canyon or ravine). There is a narrow switchback path (partially natural erosion, partially created by explorers) from the base of the cliff up to the structure. It is steep enough to require climbing, and parts of it have completely fallen away. Characters who approach from higher up the cliff might find an easier path down to the ruin. Flying or teleporting easily overcomes this obstacle.

The structure is partially built into the cliff, with only a portion of it visible and extending outward like a shelf. What can be seen of it looks like the edge of a thick dinner plate made of sections of gleaming silver and bright red metal.

There are multiple openings in the ruin's outer surface, all of them dark. Most are barely large enough for a human to crawl through them, but one (the main entrance) is big enough to fit a wagon.

MASS GRAVE

The flat area at ground level is littered with the dead bodies of hundreds of creatures, all in various states of decay and consumption. In some places, the piles of bones are as tall as a human. Scavengers and vermin crawl everywhere in search of the choicest scraps. Fast-growing weeds and similar plants push their way up between the bodies, their roots embedded in soil enriched by decaying flesh.

GM intrusion: An automaton coincidentally hurls a body where a character is standing, inflicting 4 points of damage and knocking the character prone unless they succeed at a Speed defense roll.



Seskii, page 252

COMMON CARRION EATERS

The following creatures are known to eat carrion and are likely encounters near Corpseflinger. However, because food for them is plentiful, these scavengers probably won't attack live prey (such as the PCs) unless provoked. These listings include short stats for the creatures; you can find more information about them in the appropriate bestiary.

THE NINTH WORLD BESTIARY

Slurge: A seskii-sized, slimy mollusk that eats just about anything. Level 2, Speed defense as level 1 due to slowness; Armor 4.

NINTH WORLD BESTIARY 2

Hungry pennon: Flying, banner-like creature that telepathically bonds with a predator. Level 4; health 18; flies a short distance each round.

NINTH WORLD BESTIARY 3

Brallik: An armored, cockroach-like scavenger. Level 1; Armor 2.

Kond: Large, hook-billed birds, usually black or brown. Level 1.

Tunnel seal: A leathery, pink, burrowing creature resembling a fleshy snake. Level 5; health 15; Armor 1; bite deals 6 points of damage; moves or burrows a short distance each round.

Tygnog: Spindly, spider-like creatures that eat with syringe-like stingers on their feet. Level 3; Armor 1; attacks up to four times as its action.

Vadasko: Brightly colored birds with sponge-like organs on their chest, which vomit digestive fluid on their food before they start eating. Level 2, Speed defense as level 3 due to size; health 7; flies a long distance each round.

Varanik: Huge venomous lizards prone to having mutations and strange coloration. Level 6, Speed defense and stealth as level 5 due to size; health 22; Armor 3; bite or tail deals 6 points of damage.

Most of the various dead beasts were companion creatures of datasphere explorers—more likely small pets or guardian beasts rather than food animals such as gallen.

A typical disease inflicts a few points of Might or Speed damage every hour. A serious disease might also move a character one step down the damage track every day they fail a Might defense roll. Damage from disease often can't be healed with recovery rolls.



Poison and disease, page 112

Several times per day, a spherical metallic automaton approaches the large entrance and telekinetically throws out another body which lands here—usually on top of other corpses but sometimes hitting a large rock or bare patch of ground.

The smell of decaying flesh is horrendous, hindering all actions in the vicinity (although abilities that protect against poison or scent-based attacks help). Although the newly transcribed bodies are free from disease, the older remains and the omnipresent vermin mean this area is thick with bacteria and parasites. Any creature in the area must make a Might defense roll every ten minutes or contract a **disease**.

There are corpses of many different kinds of creatures here, including

humans, near-humans, humanlike mutants, other PC species such as varjellen and lattimors, and various beasts. However, some of the corpses are of completely unfamiliar creatures—things from prior worlds that died out in the flesh ages ago, as well as ultraterrestrials and extraterrestrials. A few are things that don't seem to be possible as living creatures, with odd projections and detached limbs (these are creatures native to the datasphere which, when transcribed to the real, often have forms that are unviable in the flesh). Of course, every single one of these corpses was thrown from a great height and broke upon impact with the ground, so even a human cadaver might be unrecognizable after that sort of trauma.

DATASPHERE CONNECTION

The device in area 4 can transcribe creatures to or from the datasphere (although it isn't functioning correctly and has side effects). The node destination for this vertice is a set of white spherical frames linked together like pearls on a string. The frame environment consists of translucent walls that allow creatures in the frame to view the other nearby frames (this is a visual simulation of the connectivity of the frames in this node). Spherical daemons patrol the frames and reclaim the energy from creatures that die here.

from the windows, and other debris; the automatons diligently clean any mess made here.

There is no railing on the large central doorway, so characters near the edge should take care or risk falling.

Two or three times per day (depending on how active the transcription machine in area 4 is), a spherical **janitorial automaton** of white metal comes into this room, telekinetically holding a fresh corpse in midair. It goes to the large doorway and throws the body out to land on the ground

Large janitorial automaton: level 4; flies a short distance each round; melee telekinetic force bolt inflicts 4 points of damage

SITE LOCATIONS

The following are specific locations at this site. All interior walls are pale white metal. All of the local automatons are made of this material, and most are about 3 feet (1 m) in diameter, although a few are about half that size, and one is significantly larger.

1. ENTRANCE CHAMBER

READ ALOUD

This large open area of pale white material is shaped like a semicircle, with several windows of transparent synth looking outside over the field of dead bodies. The large central doorway is completely open, and two of the side windows have been smashed, with fragments of their synth still stuck in the frame. A glowing rectangle floats in the air in the center of the room. The smell of the corpses outside is diminished but still noticeable.

The entire room, including the area near the smashed windows, is free of trash, dust, broken synth



below. If intruders interfere, it drops the body and retreats a short distance away to wait. Once the intruders leave the corpse alone for a few minutes, the automaton approaches and again tries to throw it out the doorway. If the intruders have made any messes in the room, an aperture on the automaton's side opens and an arm with various attachments cleans up the mess. Once the automaton has disposed of the cadaver and cleaned any room messes, it returns to area 2. If attacked, it retreats to area 2. (The automaton reacts to any interactions, friendly or hostile, with bursts of short musical tones that seem like a language.)

The glowing rectangle is a holographic panel. A character who figures out how to use it can control various basic functions within the room—brighten or dim the lights, activate an air-circulation system (which has only a marginal effect, given all the openings to the outside), play various messages of short musical tones, activate or deactivate a **weak force field** on the large entrance, or summon or dismiss a large janitorial automaton.

Weak force field: level 2

2. AUTOMATON STORAGE

READ ALOUD

The curved wall of this room forms half of a deep oval. Several metal automatons float under gentle metal divots in the ceiling, occasionally making musical noises at each other. Other divots remain empty.

When idle, the automatons return to this room and wait, subtly communicating with each other and the ruin itself (in a sense, they are dreaming). There are usually four **large janitorial automatons** and three **small ones** here.

When transcribing activity occurs in area 4, the ruin's normal protocol is to awaken one of the large automatons and send it to that location to administer to the arrival's needs. The ruin isn't aware or

doesn't understand that it is transcribing dead husks into dead meat bodies—it just knows that a new creature has arrived from the datasphere. If there are no large automatons available, it sends a small one.

The small automatons perk up if flesh creatures enter the room. One of them starts following these "guests," making occasional musical exclamations, and automatically picking up any discarded trash or other organic materials they leave behind and sanitizing any area they make a mess in. When its internal receptacle is full, it returns to this area, deposits what it has collected, and sends a replacement to follow the "guests." If attacked, the small automatons retreat to a short distance away and flee from further aggression.

If any automatons are destroyed, another retrieves its pieces and dumps them into a concealed hopper so they can be recycled. Anything put into the hopper is disassembled into components and iotum and absorbed by the structure. (The site will build more automatons after a few days.)

SHINSPINNER TRAPS

Shinspinner traps are level 5. Some are set up to ignore their own kind; for the rest, the creatures know where to step or which buttons to press to bypass or activate them. Roll 1d10 or choose from the following example traps:

d10	Results
1	Deadfall
2	Force field cage (lasts for ten minutes)
3	Bright disintegration beam
4	Electricity ray
5	Telekinetic force beam
6	Antigravity
7	Stun beam (lasts for one minute)
8	Skin-like spray adhesive
9	Poisonous gas
10	Red-hot metal spikes

Large janitorial automaton: level 4; flies a short distance each round; melee telekinetic force bolt inflicts 4 points of damage

Small janitorial automaton: level 2; flies a short distance each round; melee telekinetic force bolt inflicts 2 points of damage

3. SHINSPINNER COLONY

READ ALOUD

This room is shaped like a sphere with four sides flattened. The curved floor has a small patterned area of blue and green synth tiles, above which is a circular force field platform. A glowing rectangle floats near one side of the room.

The ruin is infested with **shinspinners**, which have dismantled parts of the walls, floor, and ceiling. They've taken up residence in tunnels dug between the human-accessible parts of the ruin. (Whether Corpseflinger has three separate colonies or one expansive colony is a matter of semantics.) The intuitive creatures constantly fiddle with the numenera, dismantling items and building them into new traps and weird devices for their living space. When they need food, they steal protoflesh from area 7 or snack on the freshest corpses in the mass grave outside.

The local automatons have been waging a slow war against the shinspinners, and the current infested and "clean" areas have been in a stalemate for several weeks. Combat between PCs and shinspinners probably causes any small janitorial automatons following the characters to immediately return to area 2 and inform the large automatons there of the conflict. The large ones then come to observe the battle and perhaps take advantage of the PCs' presence by attacking any shinspinners they can see.

The shinspinner tunnels winding through their territory are no more than 3 feet (1 m) high—easy for a shinspinner to walk through but forcing human-sized creatures to **crawl**. The nest-like intersections between the walls are only slightly larger, enough for a human to crouch but not stand up. Any characters intent on eradicating the shinspinners will need to fully explore the tunnels and wipe out any vermin living there; otherwise, any survivors will reproduce and become a problem again within a few months.

4. HUSK-SCRIBER

READ ALOUD

This room is shaped like a sphere with four sides flattened. The curved floor has a small patterned area of blue and green synth tiles, above which is a circular force field platform. A glowing rectangle floats near one side of the room.

The central area with the force field is the transcription device for this vertice. The glowing rectangle is a holographic panel that controls this machine. Anyone who succeeds at an understanding numenera task can determine that the device will safely transport any creature on the force field platform to a distant location, but they can't specify where that location is. (Characters might assume it is a teleporter to somewhere else in the Ninth World.) It is an understanding numenera task to activate the transcription (in either direction).

The device can transcribe anyone from the platform to this site's datasphere node, or transcribe someone in that node to this room. It is fully functional but currently has two significant flaws. First, it automatically detects husks in various parts of the datasphere, even in distant nodes, and transcribes them here, where they appear as dead bodies (because the source creatures are dead). It does this two or three times per day, pausing roughly four to nine hours between sessions.

Second, any creature transcribed from here to the datasphere leaves behind its flesh (but not its implanted devices or other equipment) as an inert corpse. Therefore, to those unfamiliar with the datasphere, it looks like this machine creates a bright light for a few seconds, then instantly kills whoever uses it to "travel"—their body falls over dead, without any apparent injury. The transcribed creature is alive and safe in the datasphere, but this facility doesn't have the ability to communicate with them.



Shinspinner, page 276

The colony has a total of twenty to fifty shinspinners, and they tend to move about between the three colony locations on the map.

Physical activities of human-sized creatures are hindered by one or two steps within the tight confines of the shinspinner tunnels and nests.

The voices may try to interact with the PCs in this area by transcribing temporary humanoid bodies and speaking audibly. When the voice is done with the interaction, it abandons the body, which drops dead.

Within minutes of the device being used, a large janitorial automaton from area 2 arrives. It examines the body (whether a newly transcribed inert body or the corpse of someone who was transcribed into the datasphere) for a few moments, making musical tones. Once it verifies that the body is dead, it telekinetically picks it up, carries it to area 1, and throws it out the main doorway. If attacked or prevented from taking the body, it retreats to area 2 and returns an hour later to try again.

A creature in the local datasphere node can activate the command there to transcribe themselves back to the real, but that can't be done from the real side of this vertice. Anyone who transcribes from here to the datasphere has to initiate a return transfer on their end.

Characters here who want to correct the flaws in this device have several options, some of which are complex tasks requiring hours or days of work.

- Level 4: Damage it. Whether through a numenera skill, salvaging important components, or more violent actions, harming the machine prevents it from working as a vertice. Damaging it first requires tearing open wall panels in this room to find relevant parts of the numenera that can be manipulated or targeted; this draws the attention of all functional janitorial automatons in the site, which attack anyone present. Inflicting enough damage to the exposed numenera to render it inoperable takes only a few rounds.
- Level 6: Slow it down. Instead of several times per day, the site realscribes a husk maybe once a week.
- Level 7 (complex task): Set it to datascribing-only. This prevents it from realscribing anything (husks or otherwise). Reversing this change is the same difficulty and complexity.
- Level 8 (complex task): Deactivate it. This prevents anyone from realscribing or datascribing at this location, and

ends the arrival of dead bodies (and their disposal outside).

- Level 9 (complex task): Repair it. This allows the site to be used as a vertice for transcribing in either direction without accidentally producing corpses.

If the site stops producing corpses, over the next few months the bodies in the field outside decay and are consumed by scavengers. The field becomes unexceptional other than the large number of bones scattered about, and the vermin and disease levels return to normal. If the site produces fewer corpses over time, the field tends to have more scavengers than nearby areas but otherwise isn't especially dangerous.

5. CHARGING ROOM

This room's white walls curve gently to meet the ceiling and floor. In the air, just off-center, are six faintly glowing rectangles that almost touch at the edges to form a cube.

The rectangles are holograms; they have no physical substance, and matter and energy pass right through them. Together, the rectangles are part of a device built into the walls of this area. If a cypher or artifact is placed within the holographic cube, it is gently held in place with a **weak force field**. The walls of the cube expand to accommodate larger items, but anything larger than a human arm extends (harmlessly) beyond these boundaries.

The **holographic cube** can be used to recharge a spent cypher that has been used in the past 28 hours. The acting character must place the item in the cube, spend 6 Intellect points, and make an understanding numenera roll with a difficulty equal to 3 + the cypher's level. If successful, the cypher can be used again; otherwise, it remains spent and useless. In addition to the normal options for

Weak force field: level 1

Using the holographic cube is eased for characters who have a similar numenera-charging ability, such as Recharge Cypher or Charge.



Recharge Cypher,
page 49

Charge, page 84

using Effort, a character can use levels of Effort to recharge a cypher that was used more than 28 hours ago; each level of Effort used in this way extends the time period by 28 hours.

The cube can be used to recharge a depleted artifact, but the task is hindered by three steps. A successful roll allows the artifact to be used one additional time.

The automatons of this facility can use this device to increase their level by 2 for 28 hours (this requires an action and has no chance of failure). They do this only if there is a significant threat to the ruin, such as the iron wind, an approaching megapredator, or powerful explorers attempting to destroy or salvage most of the numenera here. After the boosted 28 hours pass, the automaton's level drops to 2 less than its normal level for a similar amount of time (automatons of level 2 or lower become inert for this period). The device can boost any automaton this way (task difficulty equal to 3 + automaton's level), but failure hinders the automaton by two steps until it is repaired.

6. MIRROR ROOM

This room comes to a narrow point, where a tall rectangle of light hovers in the air. A blurry image appears within the rectangle, showing shadowy creatures approaching.

The rectangle is a holographic panel that automatically shows an image of whoever enters the room, like a mirror. If a creature interacts with the panel, or remains within an immediate distance of it for more than a few rounds, it begins to steal all the color from them and their equipment (a character can resist with a Might defense roll), until within a round or two all of their solid matter is in shades of grey. (Lights, including light from a held torch or implanted device, retains its normal color.) The image depicted in the panel remains the same and doesn't change color.

A creature whose color is absorbed doesn't feel any different, and their abilities are not affected (unless somehow directly related to colors). For example, a character with **Face Morph** can still change their coloration, but they revert to shades of grey when the ability ends. The character's flesh returns to normal over the next few days, but equipment, inorganic implants, and other objects don't return to normal until a couple of weeks have passed.

7. PROTOFLESH ROOM

This circular room has walls lined with nine floor-to-ceiling cylinders, each with a hatch in front. One hatch has been torn open, revealing a bubbling, reddish-brown material similar to soup, some of which has spilled out and dried into a crust around and below the hatch.

The liquid material is in all of the cylinders and is a sort of protoflesh—a mixture of animal-based fats, proteins, and other materials, used to quickly fabricate bodies for creatures being realscribed in the vertice (area 4). It is kept warm at a temperature slightly below the normal human internal temperature. Each intact cylinder can be salvaged for 1 or 2 units of **bio-circuitry** or **smart tissue**; the opened cylinder can be salvaged for only 1 unit.

The protoflesh is edible and nutritious, but it decays like meat if removed from the cylinder. The ruin slowly replenishes this material (fast enough that the daily husk-scribing doesn't deplete it, but not fast enough to be visible over minutes or hours). If all of the cylinders are opened or destroyed, it reduces the vertice's ability to effectively realscribe bodies. If this occurs, the vertice creates as much of each body as it can given its current supply, which might mean creating the upper half of a creature, or just its skin, or just the bones, and so on.



Face Morph, page 47

GM intrusion: *The cube overcharges the cypher, artifact, or automaton, destroying it in an explosion of energy, and inflicting damage in an immediate area equal to its level, or 2 points less than that on a successful Speed defense roll.*

It's possible that the characters have never seen a full-length mirror before. Small handheld mirrors are much easier for non-numenera crafters of the Ninth World to create.



Bio-circuitry, page 112

Smart tissue, page 113

If you're using the Building Tomorrow sourcebook, the protoflesh could instead be salvaged for organic iotum up to level 5 like cognitive weave, fecundity matrix, immorcell colony, metabolic vesicle, mother marrow, optogenetic muscle, or pluripotent mass.

TEMPLE OF WAR

LEVEL 4

Consider placing this site southwest of Aian in Milave.



Aian, page 159



Rival explorers, page 84

Allifo, page 85

Valka, page 91



Disrupting nodule;
page 279

Friction-reducing gel,
page 279

Intellect enhancement,
page 281

Voices (Aorut, Etranv,
Isijaan), page 82

READ ALOUD

A series of crystalline pillars flank the entrance to a broad, deep cave. Every few seconds an energy pulse—feeling like a deep tone that is too low to hear—sweeps out of the mouth of the cave, stirring up dust and leaves into swirls and eddies.

Overview: Three factions vying for control over the ruin are in a stalemate. A strange glow in a central part of the site enhances physical weapons to make them more deadly in combat. The properties of the site are well known as the “war enchantment,” making the location an enticing target for explorers, war profiteers, and would-be conquerors.

Rumors: Many merchants in Milave (as well as local mercenary companies and petty warlords near that country) have heard of this temple; the stories say that an ancient war god blesses any weapon brought here, seeking only to encourage violence. Any metal brought into the ruin is cursed to never rest until it drinks innocent blood. An evil spirit enchants blades brought before it to act as its eyes in the Ninth World and quench its hunger for souls.

Common Cyphers: Disrupting nodule, friction-reducing gel, intellect enhancement

Voices: Aorut studies the source of the green aura so he can duplicate it elsewhere or disassemble its numenera and rebuild it in another location that’s

more suitable for his plans. His attention means more aggressive humans are drawn to the site, likely driving out the abhumans after just a few days of conflict and elevating a charismatic human leader (such as a rival explorer like Allifo or Valka) to take advantage of the site’s resources and conquer the nearby lands.

Etranv is curious to learn more about the reptilian nalkor abhumans at the site, and positions herself as one of their gods so they welcome her presence. Her assistance makes it likely that the nalkors can drive out the other two factions and take over the entire site, displacing the bandits and margr into open conflict or raids on nearby settlements.

Isijaan increases the randomness of the war enchantment, doubling its effect on some weapons, doing nothing to others, and empowering a few with electrical energy that harms foes. They might dim the source-glow of the war enchantment to see how the three factions react to it, or enhance the guardians at its heart to see if any visitors are willing to take a greater risk to gain the war enchantment.

The Temple of War is a ruin that has changed hands many times over the past few hundred years, as various warlords, tyrants, and aggressive gangs of bandits and abhumans seize control of its weapon-enhancing powers. This place’s violent and bloody history means its interior spaces have been vandalized, salvaged, and rebuilt with Ninth World



craftsmanship many times. Explorers will find areas decorated with abhuman idols, religious and cult icons, bandit trophies, military flags, and more. Currently, three different groups control the ruin's entrance wings, with a tense truce lasting only because any faction that starts a fight with another puts themselves at risk of the third faction striking their rear flank.

THE WAR ENCHANTMENT

Any weapon that spends at least a minute in the green aura of area 11 has its physical matter restructured so it strikes harder or more accurately. This is known to the inhabitants and nearby settlements as the “war enchantment.” In the hands of an NPC, it increases the NPC's attack level by 1 and increases their damage by 1 point. In the hands of a PC, the character can either gain an asset on the attack or add 1 to the weapon damage (the player chooses

which benefit to use for each attack).

The war enchantment works only on manufactured bashing, bladed, and ranged weapons—swords, hammers, axes, bows, and so on—but not on unarmed attacks, ray emitters, esoterics, and the like. An affected weapon sometimes gives off a brief streak of green light, like that of a firefly.

The war enchantment on a weapon has a depletion of 1 in 1d20 (check each attack), after which it works like its pre-enchantment self. If the weapon already has a depletion (such as a [drill spear](#)), the enchantment depletion and the item's depletion are rolled separately.

A weapon that is enchanted and depleted multiple times, or that spends an extended amount of time in the green aura, might develop additional abilities (such as releasing a burst of electricity when it strikes) with a depletion of 1 in 1d20. A weapon that gets an additional ability also gains an [artifact quirk](#).

If the characters need a reason to explore this ruin, an easy plot hook is to have an NPC merchant hire them to carry a shipment of weapons through the site.

The intent is that the war enchantment works only on simple physical weapons (clearly, there is some machine intelligence that decides what items are or aren't “weapons” for the purpose of the green aura), but you're free to decide whether it works on any particular item.



[Drill spear](#), page 294

[Artifact quirks](#), page 290

THE FACTIONS

Three groups of creatures live within the Temple of War, each controlling one entrance and a portion of its catacombs. Because all three factions rely on simple physical weapons, they all benefit from the war enchantment.



Bandits, page 264

Margr, page 240

Nalkor, page 81

Bandits: This group consists of dissatisfied human riff-raff—raiders, thieves, slavers, heartless mercenaries, and other folk who prey on travelers and undefended villages. (If this ruin is isolated from human settlements, the bandits could be the remnants of a warlord's scattered army, exiled survivors from a murderous cult, or a

similar group of evil-minded folk with no interest in peaceful trade.) Although perhaps individually weaker than other creatures living at the ruin, the bandits have teamwork, a willingness to use the numenera, greater numbers, and two powerful leaders. Altogether, there are about thirty bandits.

Margr: This pack of goat-headed abhumans all have white or pale yellow fur, and paint their faces with soot so their heads look like skulls. They are typical specimens of their kind, violent and crude. They hate their human neighbors and hate themselves for lacking the strength to overwhelm them—a few skirmishes showed that the two groups would be about equal if it weren't for the human nano (see area 4) and their “witchcraft.” The margr mistrust and almost fear the nalkor tribe for their strange abilities, but find their dead foes delicious and would like to eat all of them.

Nalkors: These reptilian abhumans can dissolve into animate goo for short periods and then reform. Their ability to regenerate has given them staying power in the war against the other two groups, and currently they hope this will help them survive long enough to destroy whichever opposing faction also survives. The nalkors believe their gifts were granted to them by their strange gods, and they hate the margr and bandits as “solid meat” (a semi-religious insult akin to “heathen”), although their hatred of humans is slightly greater than their hatred of the margr.

DATASPHERE CONNECTION

The war enchantment is a side effect of a damaged vertice in the floor under area 11. If the vertice is repaired, users can transcribe to the datasphere, arriving in a node consisting of several squat stone



castles (each being a cluster of linked frames) interspersed with green lava-like flows and watched over by spiky clouds that resemble bats.

SITE LOCATIONS

The following are specific locations at this site. All creature stats include the effect of the **war enchantment**, if appropriate.

Under layers of grime, soot, blood, paint, or recent human construction (such as planks made from synth scrap or wood), the original synth walls, floors, and ceiling of this ruin are a neutral green or blue color, with a slightly rough wood-like texture. Because the entire site has been heavily salvaged by previous inhabitants, any new salvage attempts here (except for the active numenera in areas 4 and 12) are hindered by four steps.

1. BANDIT ENTRANCE



READ ALOUD

Three crystalline pillars flank each side of the wide cave mouth. Inside, the walls have been lined or reinforced with other materials—synth, sheets of metal, and perhaps wood here and there. Partway into the cave, a curtain of stitched-together hides blocks any further view.

When it is dark outside, light from area 2 leaks from under the curtain—enough to be seen from outside if someone takes a moment to look, but not enough to illuminate the outer part of the cave.

Strung across the floor is a simple **alarm trap** consisting of two lengths of twine held tight just a finger's width above the ground; among the miscellaneous debris in the corners of the tunnel are some noisy metal pieces tied to the twine. If a creature moves through the area without noticing the trap, their feet catch on the twine, making a lot of noise and alerting the bandits in area 2.

2. BANDIT FORTIFICATION



READ ALOUD

Pale white glowing squares give off a gentle light here, revealing a wagon-sized crossbow pointed toward the curtain. To either side of the crossbow are chest-high barricades of wood and synth. Two bandits wait behind the barricades, and a third sits on a seat behind the giant crossbow.

The area beyond the curtain is illuminated with several gentle lights built into the walls; they've been scorched a bit due to centuries of abuse but still provide light equal to a torch.

The curtain is actually two smaller ones that overlap slightly in the middle. The area is guarded by three **bandits**, who have a **crossbow-like siege weapon** pointed at the spot where a creature would open or pass through the curtains. One of the bandits has an **image projector** cypher (see below). Trying to sneak into this area from the outside of the ruin is hindered by two steps because of the heavy curtain, and by an additional step because the bandits are wary about being attacked by the nearby abhumans.

The low barricade and the siege crossbow give the bandits cover (ranged attacks against them are hindered). As soon as an intruder opens or comes through the curtain, one of the bandits fires the siege crossbow (using the weapon's attack level for the attack difficulty) and the others attack with their melee or ranged weapons. Loading or moving the siege crossbow requires two people, and aiming it takes an action. Because it can be fired every other round at most, the bandit using it fires only once before switching to their personal weapons.

If one of the bandits is knocked out or killed, the others realize they're in serious danger, and the one with the image projector cypher ducks behind the barricade (preventing PCs from attacking them unless the attack can penetrate the

War enchantment, page 59

Ignore the war enchantment depletion on items used by the bandit and abhuman NPCs. Only the players should make depletion rolls, and only for the weapons their characters are using.

Bandits: level 2, attack as level 3 due to war enchantment, Speed defense as level 3 due to shield; Armor 1; weapon attack inflicts 5 points of damage due to war enchantment

Each of the bandits throughout the Temple of War has their weapons and armor, a few shins, and basic gear.

Siege crossbow: level 5, attack as level 6 due to war enchantment; Armor 1; fired bolts deal 9 points of damage due to war enchantment; two people can roll it an immediate distance on a flat surface each round



Image projector, page 281

Alarm trap: level 2

GM intrusion: A character who activates the twine alarm also gets a foot caught in it, tripping and falling prone.

Enterprising PCs might be interested in selling bandit weapons affected by the war enhancement. Medium and heavy weapons are worth about 1 shin more than normal.

Bandits: level 2, attack as level 3 due to war enchantment, Speed defense as level 3 due to shield; Armor 1; weapon attack inflicts 5 points of damage due to war enchantment

War enchantment,
page 59



Very dim light, page 114

Detonation, page 277

Frigid wall projector,
page 279

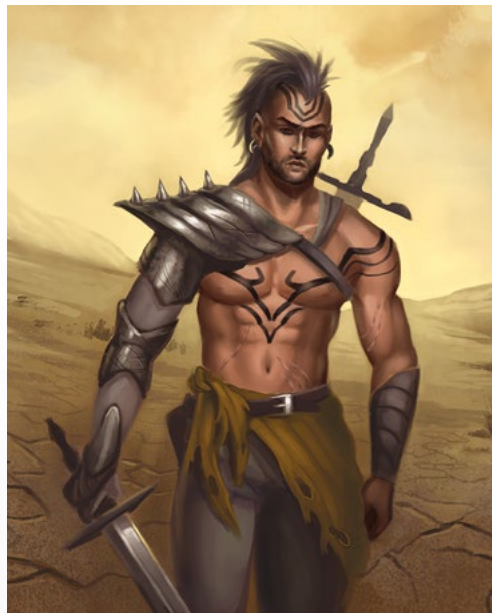
Ray emitter, page 285

If the bandits are slavers rather than mercenaries or brigands, the room also has one or two enslaved humans (level 1 or 2) that the bandits plan to sell; the slaves are kept busy cooking and cleaning up after their captors.

GM intrusion: One of the two bandit leaders from area 4 arrives, either in response to the noise or just coincidentally, and attacks a hostile intruder. (Their arrival might be stealthy or obvious, depending on which one shows up.)

Wooden doors: level 2

GM intrusion: A closed door is either stuck shut, requiring a Might task to break open, or squeaks loudly when moved, alerting everyone in the area.



wall) and uses their action to activate it, creating a noisy hologram of a roaring, terrifying creature for one hour. (This hologram might deter the PCs for a while, but its real purpose is to warn the other bandits that their lair is under attack.) If two bandits are taken out, the last one tries to run for help.

3. BANDIT QUARTERS

READ ALOUD

Illuminated by several glowing panels, this large room is a mish-mash of many features—scrap synth panels used as partitions, canvas and skins attached to walls, and layers of simple paintings. The whole place is cluttered with simple furniture, carved idols, old trophies, and stacks of axe-hewn boards. A prior-world pipe leaks a trickle of water into a large basin.

This description applies to four separate areas in this part of the ruin, each of which is obviously a living space for several people. Some of these rooms are fitted with doors, all of which (including the frames) are made of wood and built within the past century or so. Due to neglect and damage, the doors tend to squeak when opened

and stick when closed, so the bandits usually leave them open all the way. If the bandits need to go on the defensive against a powerful force, they're likely to close the doors to give them a bit of advance notice when an intruder moves through their territory.

Regardless of whatever the previous residents used this room for (sleeping, worship, training, and so on), now it is home to six or seven bandits. Parts of it are set aside for sleeping, cooking, and socializing, with the furniture adapted or repurposed for this use. The bed areas are farthest away from the doors and other high-activity spaces in the room, and the glowing panels in those areas have been covered or broken, reducing the illumination level there to very dim light. Unless the PCs arrive stealthily during the night and have quietly eliminated or bypassed the guards in area 2, all of the bandits here are awake.

If intruders reach this area without some sort of escort (either as guests or prisoners), all of the bandits immediately attack them with the intent to capture or kill. One of the bandits has a combat cypher (such as a fire detonation, frigid wall projector, or molecular disruption ray emitter) and uses it on the second or third round of the attack. The bandits don't fight to the death, and if about half of them are defeated, the rest think about retreating to find reinforcements, or surrendering if their opponents seem likely to grant mercy.

4. BANDIT LEADERS

READ ALOUD

This room is very cluttered but strangely clean. One section to the west is screened off by simple wooden panels painted with faded images. The room is well lit by a couple of glowing ceiling panels, a blue metal frame in the center, and a green light coming from farther down a southwest hallway.

This is the throne room and sleeping chambers of Mot the Blood Witch and Roz the Warspear, two strange siblings who lead this group of bandits. Its furnishings are similar to the other bandit rooms (a mix of simple furniture, decorations, and improvised materials).

One bandit is always on guard at the northeast entrance, and another waits near the shrine at the southwest. If these guards spot any intruders, they immediately call an alarm and move to attack (or follow whatever orders their leaders give them).

Beyond the screened-off area are two simple beds where the leaders sleep. The metal numenera frame cleans anything passing through it, exactly like a **cleansing arch** installation.

The Leaders: The two leaders are twins and share power equally over the group of bandits. They have an eerie synchronicity in their speech and movement, despite their physical differences and divergent abilities. They are very emotionally close (each is the only person that the other has ever truly cared for), and if one is killed, the other turns all their attention on killing the person who slew their twin. If one is greatly wounded or the PCs choose to knock one unconscious rather than kill them, the other respects the act of mercy and tries to negotiate for their lives.

Mot the Blood Witch is a nano with the power to release nanites that create bloody wounds, which look as if their target were being attacked by invisible claws. Gaunt and tall, Mot wears red face paint to look intimidating and reinforce their “war witch” reputation among the bandits. They often have sexual liaisons with one or more bandits but prefer to sleep alone in this room. Mot has a **phase changer** (which they use only if Roz is dead and they feel there is no other way to escape), a **tracer**, personal equipment, and 30 shins.

Roz the Warspear is a warrior who fights with a one-handed spear and a metal shield. She is of average height and very muscular,

although it’s hard to tell under her heavy armor. She is ambitious and believes that taking full control of the temple will allow her to recruit more troops to command. She thinks her sibling’s sexual activities with the bandits is unprofessional but won’t condemn them for it. She has a **bounder teleporter** (which she uses if Mot is dead and she has no other options), a **visual displacement device**, her personal equipment, and 25 shins.

The Shrine: The southwest end of the room has a small synth table with about two dozen offerings (candles, slivers of metal with dried blood on them, a few shins, carved wooden figures, and so on), all lit by a green glow from farther in that direction (the source is area 11). This area is just within the effect that causes the war enchantment, so the bandits bring their weapons here every few days, placing them on the table and praying to the numenera spirits, gods of war, or whatever they believe the source of the power is. Guarding this spot is considered a choice assignment.

In addition to the personal wealth and equipment of the two leaders, tucked in a corner is a synth box with money they mean to pay the bandits with over the next couple of weeks (a total of 110 shins). It also holds two oddities to use as bribes or gifts: a glass cube containing the moving image of a bearlike creature, and a red synth bird that plays short songs if hidden buttons are pressed.

5. MARGR ENTRANCE

READ ALOUD

Three crystalline pillars flank each side of the wide cave mouth. Inside, the walls are covered with wooden or synth planks, all heavily-damaged by weapon attacks. In the middle is a human head on a metal spike, dead for at least a week and covered in flies. Down the tunnel, a flickering panel in the ceiling creates a weak light. There is a smell of smoke, goat, and rotting meat.

GM intrusion: *One of the siblings senses that the other is in danger and goes to help them, gaining an asset on their attacks and defenses for the first few rounds of combat.*



Phase changer, page 284

Teleporter (bounder), page 287

Tracer, page 288

Visual displacement device, page 288



Cleansing arch: level 5, page 155

Mot the Blood Witch: *level 5, defends as level 6; Armor 1; short-range cellular disruption esotery inflicts 5 points of damage; foes within immediate range take 1 point of ambient damage (ignores Armor) each round from cloud of flesh-attacking nanites*

GM intrusion: *Mot envelops a foe in a cloud of cell-disrupting nanites, inflicting 5 points of damage and, on a failed Might defense task, moving the target one step down the damage track from massive bleeding.*

Roz the Warspear: *level 5, Speed defense as level 6 due to shield, attacks as level 6 due to war enchantment; health 25; Armor 3; spear inflicts 6 points of damage due to war enchantment; regular bandits who can hear her orders inflict an additional +1 point of damage*

GM intrusion: *Roz embeds her spear in a foe and continues fighting with a different spear; the stabbed foe takes 5 points of damage every round until they spend an action to remove the impaling weapon.*

The margr living here have very little of value other than their weapons, unless there is a nearby settlement they might have raided recently, in which case each group has a half-dozen to a dozen shins' worth of stolen goods.

Margr: level 2; weapon attacks as level 3 due to war enchantment; Might defense, jumping, running, and resisting lies and trickery as level 3; Armor 1; weapon attack inflicts 4 points of damage due to war enchantment

The margr weapons are of inferior quality and not worth selling, even with the war enchantment. They'd be useful for trading to someone with no other options, or for equipping a peasant militia.

The planks are damaged because the margr used them to test their weapons, especially once they got the war enchantment. Many of the planks are cut all the way through, revealing the original green wood-like synth walls of the ruin, long obscured with grime.

The severed head is one of the bandits—someone the margr captured, tortured, and killed. They then put this poor soul's head here as a warning that the bandits should stay away. (The margr wanted to set up a similar warning for the nalkors, but the reptilian abhumans melt into goop when killed, and a bucket of goop isn't much of a threat.)

The margr don't constantly guard this area, preferring to let the severed head be a deterrent. About once an hour—or whenever the margr in the nearby room can remember, which often is every several hours—they send one of theirs out here to look around for a few minutes. If this lookout spots anyone, they bellow an alarm and run into the nearest room to join up with other margr.

Once every couple of days, a gang of margr leave to go hunting, staying out a full day and bringing home several large carcasses for the entire tribe to eat. If they can't slay any large beasts, a few humanoids will do (this was the fate of the bandit whose head is now on a pike).

6. MARGR LAIR

READ ALOUD

Whatever purpose this room used to have is unclear, as the resident margr have wrecked most of it, defacing statues and idols, tearing apart wooden items for their smoky campfire, and painting vile symbols on the walls with blood, mud, and filth. Several grimy areas along the walls appear to be individual sleeping spots. The flickering light of a ceiling panel and the flames of the fire give just enough light to navigate but not see anything well. Most large objects have been hacked at or bashed into pieces.

This description applies to five separate areas in this part of the ruin, each of which is a living space for four or five **margr**. Although some doorways have frames and the remnants of doors, the abhumans tore them all down to feed their fires. Pushed in a corner of each room is a pile of chewed bones from their hunting; most are animal bones, but some are definitely human (remnants of the decapitated bandit in area 5).

If a margr hunting party is outside the ruin looking for food, one of these rooms has no one in it when the PCs enter. However, one or two members of the tribe might wander through from other lair rooms from time to time, either on their way to another room or to look for anything interesting to steal from their fellows.

Any margr present immediately attack as soon as they notice enemies in their lair, although an obviously stronger force might make them pause just long enough for the intruders to try negotiating.

Bad Cypher: To add a little weirdness and unpredictability to the margr portion of the ruin, include this event as part of the first or second combat encounter in any living area. One of the margr activates a cypher that gives it long, snakelike arms,



allowing it to reach or attack anything in the room. On the round after it uses the cypher, its arms continue to grow and thicken, and its belly swells to a huge size with its now-huge intestines visibly pressing outward. At the end of that turn, whether the margr is alive or dead, its arms and stomach burst open like overstuffed sausages, harmlessly spraying the room with gore and killing that margr if it wasn't dead already. This only momentarily startles the remaining margr, who then laugh at the fate of the unfortunate dead one before continuing their attacks against the PCs.

7. MARGR CHIEFTAIN

READ ALOUD

Most of the furniture and other materials in this room have been stacked up near the east end to create a platform with a crude throne on it. Flanking the throne are two pairs of margr, standing guard before a huge, four-horned margr that must be the leader of the tribe. A small campfire burns in each side of the room, but most of the light comes from a bright green glow behind the throne.

The chieftain of this tribe is **Hodragog**, a four-horned brute who is a full head taller than the others and almost comically thick with muscle, wielding a huge, two-handed maul made of a tree trunk lashed to the skull-like head of an automaton. Hodragog has 20 shins, a **flash detonation**, a **lightning wall projector**, and two oddities: a foot-shaped piece of putty that can be stretched up to 5 feet (1.5 m) long and still snap back to its normal shape, and a necklace that constantly emits a thin stream of harmless smoke.

The leader's first action in combat is to throw his flash detonation (his underlings know to cover their eyes when he does this), after which he tries to kill the largest, toughest foes first. His **margr** minions

team up to take out the weakest-looking opponents. If all of the weaker margr are defeated, Hodragog uses his lightning wall cypher to separate himself from as many enemies as he can, then tries to flee in whatever direction doesn't require him to pass through the lightning, either out the main entrance or through area 11.

The glow behind the throne comes from area 11. The glow isn't strong enough here for weapons to gain the **war enchantment**, but there is room behind the throne to enter the short hallway connecting this area to the source of the light.

8. NALKOR ENTRANCE

READ ALOUD

Three crystalline pillars flank each side of the wide cave mouth. Inside, the walls have been lined or reinforced with other materials, and the entire entrance has been blocked off except for a low opening that a person could crawl through.

The nalkors have fortified this location by taking advantage of their ability to melt into a puddle of flesh, creating an entrance that other human-sized creatures have to lay **prone** to enter. (The opening can't be smaller than it is because nalkors returning from hunting wouldn't be able to bring their dead prey into the lair for the rest of the clan to eat.) In addition to the barricade and the crawlspace gap, there are piles of other materials that leave a tiny space underneath—just enough for a liquid nalkor to creep into and hide in.

Two **nalkors** watch over the entrance from the interior side of the wall. They attack any creature that comes through the opening, taking advantage of their opponents' prone position, and hissing a warning to other nalkors in the nearby rooms. If one guard is killed, the other flees farther into the ruin or (if prevented from doing so) melts and hides under the miscellaneous debris in this area.

War enchantment, page 59



Melee attacks against prone (page 113) creatures are eased.

Detonation (flash), page 277

Lightning wall projector, page 282

Hodragog: level 5; health 30, weapon attack inflicts 10 points of damage due to war enchantment.

Nalkor: level 2; weapon attacks as level 3 due to war enchantment; perception, stealth, and Might defense as level 3; Armor 1; weapon attack inflicts 3 points of damage due to war enchantment



Banishing nodule,
page 276

Flame-retardant wall,
page 279

Psychic commune,
page 285

Nalkor: level 2; weapon attacks as level 3 due to war enchantment; perception, stealth, and Might defense as level 3; Armor 1; weapon attack inflicts 3 points of damage due to war enchantment.

Wooden doors: level 2

GM intrusion:
A closed door is either stuck shut, requiring a Might task to break open, or it squeaks loudly when moved, alerting everyone in the area.

Some players may be uncomfortable with harming the eggs of sentient creatures, even abhumans. If that is the case, replace the eggs with small harmless animals like turkeys, which the nalkors can eat as needed.

9. NALKOR LAIR

READ ALOUD

Several glowing panels provide a low amount of light in this room. It is decorated with many features and competing aesthetics—canvas and skins attached to walls, simple paintings on the walls, and basic human furniture. Synth panels have been arranged to form a corral-like space in one corner. A smashed-open piece of synth drips water into a shallow pool.

This description applies to three separate areas in this part of the ruin, each of which is a living space for nalkors. As with the bandit-controlled part of the ruin, the Ninth World wooden doors tend to squeak when opened and stick when closed, so the nalkors usually leave them partway open.

Because the clan is an extended family, which individuals stay in each room changes every few days, but there are usually four or five here at any time. The nalkors are less destructive than margr, so these rooms are in reasonably good shape—almost as good as the human bandit areas.

The corral-like space holds a few grapefruit-sized nalkor eggs, each looking like smooth, tough yellow flesh. The eggs are several weeks away from hatching, and the corral is more to keep the nalkors from accidentally tripping over the eggs than to pen in young.

If the nalkors have to fight intruders, their first goal is survival. If outmatched, they almost immediately retreat farther into the ruin, either to make a stand with the entire clan in area 10, or to circle

around and sneak up on the intruders from behind. One individual in each group has a random cypher—a banishing nodule, flame-retardant wall, or psychic commune—which they use only if appropriate for the situation.

Each nalkor has a small pouch with their treasures—usually a few shins and some polished rocks or teeth. If they retreat in melted form, they bring only a weapon (and the group's cypher, if possible), leaving behind their treasure pouches.

10. NALKOR WORSHIP CHAMBER

READ ALOUD

The glowing ceiling panels in this room have been painted over with a red substance, bathing the room in an eerie red light. The human-crafted materials and furniture here are familiar and unexceptional. One dominant feature is a long table placed directly under one of the ceiling lights; it is covered with numerous clean bones and skulls, like some kind of altar. Down the northwest hallway is a bright green glow.



In addition to housing several nalkors like the three locations marked as area 9, this room is the spiritual center of the abhuman community. The bone-covered table is an altar to their strange gods, with each piece an offering of thanks for giving the nalkors life and the skills to survive. If the nalkors see anyone other than their own kind touch or disturb the altar, they become enraged and their attacks against that creature are eased.

As with other nalkor living areas, each resident has a treasure pouch that they leave behind if forced to retreat. One of the nalkors in the room has a **desiccating detonation**, and uses it if hostile intruders reach this area.

If the remaining members of the clan are attacked and it seems likely that the intruders can wipe them out, the nalkors fall back to the edge of area 11, melt, and retreat to behind the mastigophores there. Because the human-like automatons ignore the nalkors in liquid form, the nalkors hope that the mastigophores will deal with any pursuing intruders, giving the nalkors time to escape or (if the automatons seem likely to win) scavenge meat and supplies from their dead enemies.

11. HEART OF THE TEMPLE

READ ALOUD

This angular room glows with a strong, severe green light that comes out of the floor, walls, and ceiling. Occasional sparks of brighter green energy manifest in the air and vanish before reaching the ground. Standing at attention in the middle of the room are three humans wearing green uniforms. Three exits lead out—one at ground level to the southeast, and two on balcony-like areas to the west and northeast.

This room is the source of the **war enchantment**, which is an energy effect bleeding from the vertice centered on



this area. The glow radiates outward, extending partially into area 4, and is close enough to areas 7 and 10 that the creatures there can access it with a little effort.

The three “humans” are actually **mastigophores**. They ignore the green sparks and verbally warn (in an unknown language) anyone who approaches the room. If attacked, or if anyone enters the room, all three automatons react by attacking, not stopping until the offender is dead or has fled the entire ruin. If they kill an opponent and there are no other immediate threats, they eat part of their prey in order to replenish their stores.

The presence of the mastigophores keeps the three temple factions from claiming the Heart for themselves, which is why each group has needed to devise ways of dipping into the edge of the effect. If the mastigophores are destroyed, the factions would erupt into open war over control of the temple.

The **vertice numenera** is damaged and can't be repaired while the mastigophores control this area. **Repairing it** would take iotum and several weeks. Disabling the energy bleed would take about a day and would mean the end of the war enchantment. The vertice numenera can be salvaged for a few cyphers or an **icon of war** artifact.

The two balcony levels are 10 feet (3 m) above the floor of the chamber. The northeastern balcony (leading to area 4) still has a wooden fence-like railing. There is no railing on the western balcony (leading to area 7), but it does have a length of knotted rope thrown there in a tangled pile.



Mastigophore,
page 241

Detonation
(desiccating), page 277

The mastigophores ignore any liquid-form nalkors that enter the room, perhaps because they don't consider them alive or a threat.

From time to time, one of the mastigophores animates and goes hunting, leaving the other two to guard. If it doesn't find a creature in the ruin to eat, it spends some time outside in search of beast prey.

Vertice numenera:
level 7

Datasphere connection,
page 60

Icon of war, page 78

The voices may try to interact with the PCs in this area by controlling the mastigophores, either to speak with the PCs or to direct them to where the vertice repairs are needed.

War enchantment,
page 59

PULVINATED FOAM

LEVEL 3

Consider placing this site northeast of the Fourth Mark in Draolis.



Fourth Mark, page 146



Rival explorers, page 84

Onofey, page 89

Panli, page 90



Immobilizer, page 182

Organ factory,
page 184



Instant shelter, page 281

Metal death, page 283

Sheen, page 286

Voices (Aorut, Etranv,
Isijaan), page 82

READ ALOUD

The normal plants of the valley are obscured by an area of hill- and house-sized tan lumps resembling piles of cushions melted together into a swollen mass. Here and there, large rocks and tall trees poke through the top of this material. Pieces of this stuff are scattered around it like scree and gravel. Off to one side appears to be a tunnel or cave carved into the tan substance.

Overview: Solid foam fills a valley, hiding several explorable locations within it. The foam shifts and changes like a slow tide, and the locations within move about with it. All of the numenera here (including several automatons) are based on malleable foam rather than metal or hard synth.

Rumors: The farmsteaders of Hyv (on the other side of the mountain) remember one year that the valley got so cold that it froze the iron wind in place, forming a solid mist that can be mined for life-changing numenera. Ravenous beasts and demons from the prior worlds haunt caves in the foam. People who died long ago sometimes emerge from the caves, only to collapse after a few days of haunting the living or trying to resume their old lives.

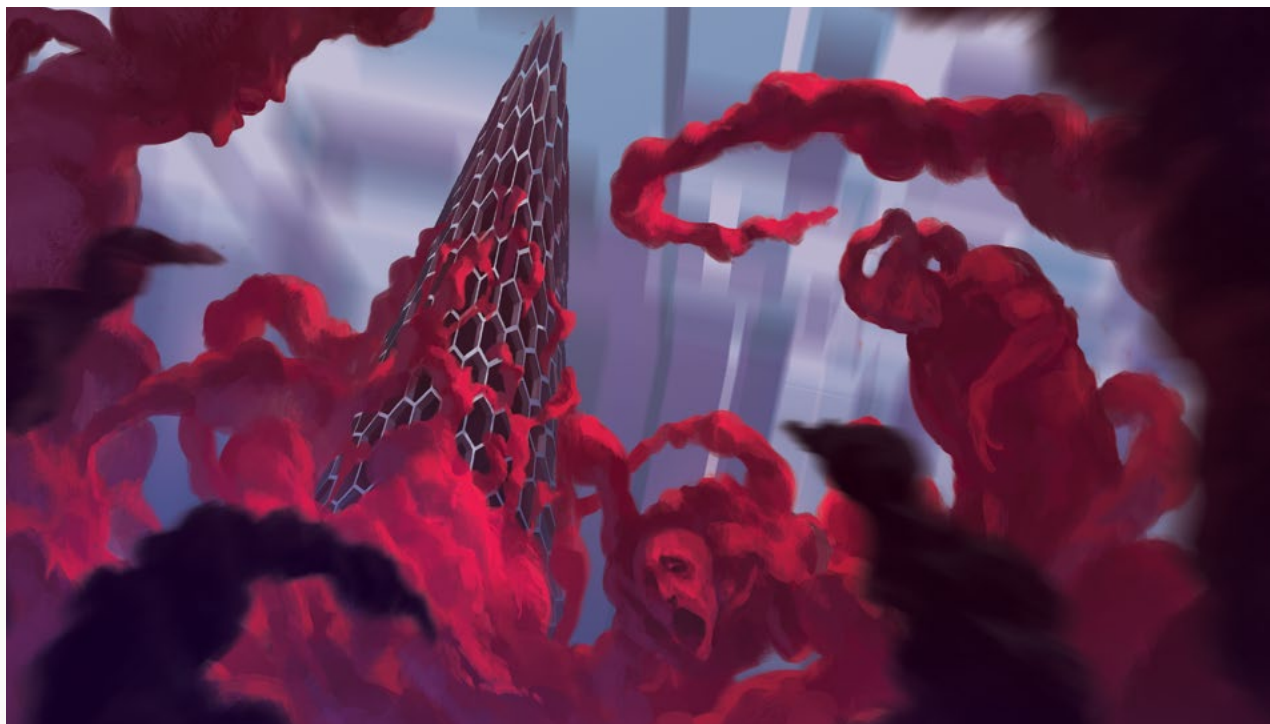
Common Cyphers: Immobilizer, instant shelter, metal death, organ factory, sheen

Voices: Aorut experiments by using this site's foam-based numenera to

create automaton duplicates of various creatures from the real and the datasphere (especially as the flexible and adaptable foam is more suitable for some of the strange shapes that dataforms have). These automatons become unstable the farther they get from this valley, so nearby settlements are likely to see (and experience attacks from) half-melted creatures that break apart or melt if struck.

Etranv is unable to feed on the foam automatons and doesn't consider them a type of life form worth studying. She enjoys the aesthetics of the malleable foam and coaxes the nanobots to build beautiful sculptures of people, creatures, and fantastic buildings out of the tan foam, perhaps including entities and places familiar to the player characters. She may create additional temporary spaces within the foam and use them as meeting places and temples for her followers, often with a large statue representing her. Her presence attracts the attention of art-minded rival explorers (like Onofey and Panli) to study how to sculpt the foam like she does.

Isijaan is entertained by the adaptability of the local nanobots and how the lightweight foam can build structures that would collapse if made of stone, wood, steel, or hard synth. They direct the nanobots to create bizarre things that defy gravity, many of them with weblike strands for strength and stability. Automatons formed under his influence are swarms of many tiny units instead of



a single cohesive creature. Even the foam clones from area 1 are made of thousands of miniature foam people assembled into the shape and size of a typical person.

Pulvinated Foam is a part of a small valley about 1 mile (1.5 km) across that is covered in huge lumps of **molded foam**. Over time, the lumps crack and shift as new foam is created or extruded from within, and portions along the edge are torn or cut away, but the site maintains its approximate size. The foam is thick enough to prevent sunlight from reaching the ground, killing any smaller plants that try to grow beneath it.

Sometimes shifting chunks of foam create small passages through it, which connect to semi-permanent spaces within it (reinforced by numenera specific to those spaces). Because this molded foam is a weak material, beasts can burrow into it easily to form lairs; a curious explorer could hack out a narrow tunnel (wide enough for a human to walk through and an immediate distance deep) in about ten minutes. Red wine and certain kinds of chemical fuels dissolve the foam as fast as acid, leaving behind a sticky synth

slime that is stinky but harmless. Burning the foam creates a thick black **poisonous smoke** in an immediate area from the fire source; the fire usually extinguishes itself (or is suppressed by responsive nanobots) after burning a short or long area.

No specific source, location, or individual machine produces the foam. Nanobots distributed throughout the area awaken and sleep in cycles, recycling and reprocessing existing foam when possible and creating new foam out of atmospheric molecules when necessary. This means that new growths can appear anywhere, and other than destroying all the nanobots in the area (requiring incineration, disintegration, or other high-energy methods), there isn't a way to stop this process from continuing. Fortunately, the nanobots appear to limit their work to this specific valley; otherwise, the foam construction would keep pushing outward to envelop nearby areas. Of course, there is always the chance that the nanobots' programming could develop an error, or that something like the **iron wind** could change what these harmless machines consume or create...

Poisonous smoke:

level 4; each round of contact inflicts 4 points of Speed damage (ignores Armor) on a failed Might defense task. Any creature damaged by the smoke must succeed at another Might defense roll or permanently lose 1 point of Might, Speed, or Intellect (equal chances each time).

Molded foam: level 1.

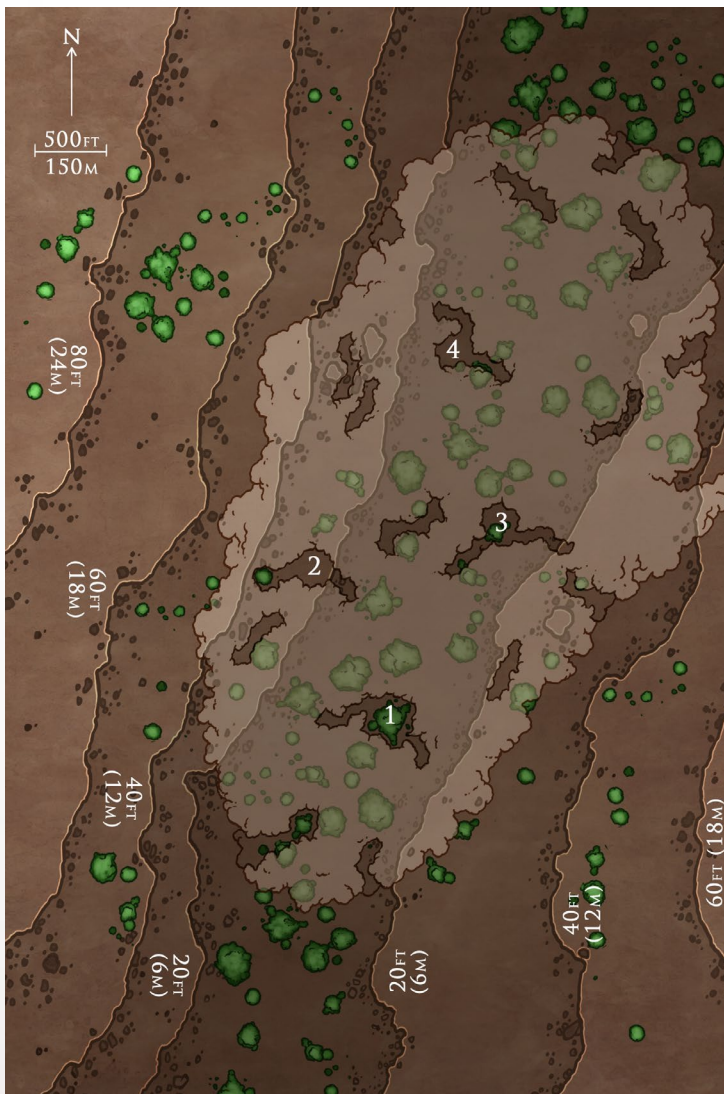
The molded foam at this site has the weight, texture, and strength of 21st-century polystyrene used to protect items in shipping.

The molded foam is a kind of synth containing bubbles of air. At this site has the weight, texture, and strength of 21st-century polystyrene used to protect items in shipping.



Molded foam, page 93

Iron wind, page 135



Blue foam: level 3; it burns with the same effect as the tan foam

Burning a new path through the foam usually means the poisonous smoke can't blow away and remains confined to that area, making it an ongoing hazard for anyone navigating the tunnel.

GM intrusion: A section of foam begins growing and expanding, isolating or gently crushing a character. Although the pressure of the solidified foam usually isn't enough to cause physical harm to a human, it could suffocate a character, either by directly covering their face or by enclosing them in a space with little air.

DATASPHERE CONNECTION

The hatch in area 4 leads to an underground chamber that can transcribe creatures and objects (although realscribing from that location has an unusual side effect). In the datasphere, the entry frame for the vertice is a house-sized mushroom of hypnotically shifting colors. The adjacent frames within the node are other kinds of giant fungi, and the node inhabitants are entities (intelligent or beast-minded) built out of hand-sized stacked blocks, often in the shapes of abstract insects, eels, or blobs.

SITE LOCATIONS

The following are specific locations at this site, each formed by a honeycomb-like grid of sturdier **blue foam**. The spaces between these blue grid lines are open. Characters can reach through the gaps to touch the tan foam and even push or pull objects through, but the tan foam is held back and won't pass through on its own.

The "rooms" within the molded foam are slightly mobile and tend to drift over time, so they're never in quite the same place from week to week. The shifting and growing tan foam frequently closes off established tunnels between the locations (each tunnel typically remains open for ten to thirty hours), requiring digging, melting, or burning new passages to get from place to place. Numenera built into these locations can give general directions to other specific areas in the foam, but they're just inaccurate enough that explorers may have to search a bit to find the "room" they're looking for.

In addition to these specific locations, you should add a few more areas not shown on the map, such as caves dug out by beasts (perhaps ravage bears or other local animals) or lairs carved out by abhumans for use as a temporary shelter. These can be connected to the exterior perimeter of the foam mass or to an offshoot of one of the interior tunnels. Digging PCs might break into tunnels created by these other beings, or (perhaps as a GM intrusion) the characters' tunnel might suddenly be breached by other inhabitants—ones who have been trapped and lost for days and are so desperate to escape that they charge past the characters without attacking. Because of the shifting configuration of the foam, none of these areas last long, and PCs who return to this site are likely to find entirely new inhabitants that have created temporary lairs here.

1. FABRICATOR

READ ALOUD

The irregular walls and ceiling of this chamber are formed by a honeycomb-like grid of blue foam. Hanging from a thicker portion of the ceiling grid is a wet, pendulous mass resembling an upside-down melted candle.

The hanging mass is a device, manipulated by pushing and pulling finger-sized depressions in its slimy surface. Each round after the characters enter the room (whether or not they try to manipulate the device), parts of it swell and spray out jets of watery blue foam that hardens into a life-sized rough approximation of one of the characters, which stands listlessly. If any of these copies are harmed, or when there is a copy of every visible member of the group, the **foam clones** attack the PCs and fight until destroyed.

If a character tries to use the hanging device to destroy or control a foam clone, a successful understanding numenera task causes one clone to dissolve into inert synth goo.

Once the foam clones are dealt with, the device can be used (with a successful understanding numenera task) to produce a few simple items (such as planks, shields, dishes, and so on) made of level 3 blue molded foam. It can also create a rudimentary map of the nearby tunnels and one nearby specific location within the foam. The device can be salvaged for a level 3 **instant servant** cypher. If the device is left intact, it continues to produce more foam clones of the PCs every few hours for the next few days; these clones pursue and attack the characters.

2. ANGRY BLOOD

READ ALOUD

A honeycomb-like grid of blue foam creates a rigid structure that keeps out the tan foam. A cone mesh of similar material projects upward from the

floor, but it has been broken open from the inside, leaving a trail of bloodlike smears on the floor.

The cone contained a liquid foam automaton resembling intertwined streams of blood, but it broke out of its container when the PCs got within a short distance of it (whether or not there is an open passage between it and them). If the characters arrive within a few rounds of that, they find this **red foam creature** here. If it takes more than a few rounds for the characters to reach this chamber, the red foam seeks them out, moving directly toward them and seeping through the tan foam at a rate of an immediate distance per round, attacking as soon as it finds them.

The creature's remains can be salvaged for one or two **speed boost** cyphers, each having the form of a straw-like strand of rigid foam that dissolves when chewed. The remainder of the creature's liquid substance seeps into the tan foam or the ground and will be recycled by the nanobots, eventually creating a new creature in this area.

The remains of the cone structure can be manipulated with an understanding numenera task to give the approximate location of another specific area within the tan foam.

3. STRANGE STAIRCASE

READ ALOUD

A portion of the oddly angled blue lattice wall of this room is a chaotic mess of overlapping layers, like a bundle of sticks dropped on the ground and quickly pushed to the side.

A successful understanding numenera task causes the messy part of the wall to organize itself into a staircase curving upward, with the blue lattice forming the edges and tan foam forming the flat portions (as the lattice folds into a stairway, the tan foam of the wall recedes to create an open passage for the stairs).

All creatures featured in this location are automatons (not living things), made of nanobot-controlled foam rather than metal parts and gears. If burned, they give off poisonous smoke just like the other foam at this location.

Red foam creature:

level 6; health 20; Armor 3 (including against mental attacks); two melee attacks per round inflict 4 points of damage each; moves a short distance each round, or an immediate distance through tiny spaces or tan foam

If there are nonhuman creatures with the characters, or if they for some reason have blood that isn't red, the foam creature's color is the same as their blood color (or streaked with multiple colors appropriate to the creatures in the group).



Speed boost, page 287

Blue foam clones: level 3

The voices may try to interact with the PCs in this area by fabricating a temporary foam body that they can talk through, although their control over such a thing is poor.



Instant servant, page 281

Hostile lattice wall: level 3; Armor 1; whiplike structure inflicts 3 points of damage and, on a failed Might defense roll, grabs the target and automatically squeezes them for 4 points of damage each round (the target can escape with a Might or Speed defense roll.)

GM intrusion: The lattice wall retaliates against a character that just struck it, immediately attacking and thereafter making two attacks per round.

GM intrusion: The sticky foam begins to flow up the body of the character, hindering their physical actions and inflicting 1 point of Speed damage (ignores Armor) from contact poison each round until they pull free.

Poisonous liquid synth: level 4; each round of contact inflicts 4 points of Speed damage (ignores Armor) on a failed Might defense task. Any creature damaged by the liquid must succeed at another Might defense roll or permanently lose 1 point of Might, Speed, or Intellect (equal chances each time).



Machine control implant, page 282

Tracer, page 288

Brain bud, page 293

Living armor sheath, page 298

A failed roll means that portion of the lattice wall extends into the room and attacks a nearby creature instead. If this extended part of the lattice is destroyed, the wall can still be manipulated to form a staircase, but any attempts to do so are hindered by two steps. The extended stairs and the open passage they form retract automatically after a few hours, stranding anyone up above.

The stairs aren't perfectly formed, and a few of the tan foam walls and steps are sticky, holding a character's foot or hand if touched (the character can pull free with a Might defense roll).

At the top of the stairs is an open-air platform (formed by an extension of the stairway mesh) that overlooks the entire region of tan foam. One portion of the edge of this platform is a device that looks like a blue oval loop framing a 3-foot (1 m) long area of tan foam. A successful understanding numenera task makes this device create a topographical map of the entire region of tan foam, with markers indicating the current locations of the specific areas described in this chapter, as well as the current open paths between them (including paths created by the characters).

A PC can use this oval interface to create a new path between two areas (the local nanobots recycle and consume the foam in the designated area within a few rounds), but the task for doing so is hindered by two steps, and this function stops working after two attempts.

4. SPIRALING FLOOR HATCH

READ ALOUD

A complicated blue foam lattice defines the floor, walls, and ceiling in this area. In the center of the floor, it forms a gentle ramp that spirals inward and down, plunging beneath the surface of a pool of opaque pale blue slime. A trickle of slime from one side of the room leads to the ramp, spilling over into the pool like a miniature waterfall.

The slime is a **poisonous liquid synth** that harms anyone who touches it. The ramp continues downward below the surface of the liquid for about another 15 feet (4.5 m) and ends in a hatch-like panel.

The trickle of slime comes out of tiny pores in one of the blue foam lattice elements without any obvious source. (It's actually seeping out from inside the lattice due to microscopic fractures.) If the slime feeding the pool is blocked or diverted, the pool drains over about two days, although the surfaces remain wet and sticky (and poisonous) for weeks afterward; thick clothing is enough to prevent casual contact with the remaining liquid.

The Hatch: The hatch can be opened with a successful understanding numenera task. Its location is also a vague landmark for another specific area within the tan foam. Underneath it is an irregular chamber that is a functional vertice. A quirk of this vertice is that any creatures realscribed here are made of nanobot-controlled foam rather than flesh, and these forms last for only a few days before breaking down (at which time the creature's consciousness bounces back to this vertice and gets datascribed back into the datasphere, or perhaps gets stuck here and keeps producing temporary bodies until the creature can find an alternative solution).

In the vertice room is numenera that can be salvaged for two cyphers (a **machine control implant** and a **tracer**) and two artifacts (a **brain bud** and a **living armor sheath**) without affecting the operation of the vertice, which is a separate salvage source.

If you want to add more locations to explore in this area, the vertice chamber has a closed blue foam doorway leading to a larger underground complex of a clearly different origin than the foam-based structures on the surface. You can use a ruin from this book or another source for these additional areas.

PART 2:



THE NUMENERA



Chapter 10: Cyphers

74

Chapter 11: Artifacts

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CYPHERS



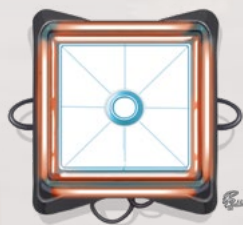
Cypher Dangers,
page 272

Finding and Identifying
Cyphers, page 274

Using Cyphers,
page 274

Cypher Forms,
page 274

If activated without targeting a creature—such as by a user who doesn't understand what the device does—the corpse-maker cypher might duplicate the user or realscribe the corpse of a “nearby” datasphere creature.



The cyphers in this chapter add to the assortment presented in other Numenera books. These offer the same **cypher dangers** for those who surpass their cypher limit as the cyphers described in *Numenera Discovery*, and the rules for **finding, identifying, and using** them as well as their various **forms** are also consistent with the introductory material in *Numenera Discovery*.

Some cyphers and other devices require a connection to the datasphere to operate. This has drawbacks and benefits. Generally, within any of the vertice locations presented in this book, these cyphers should function normally, or perhaps even have an enhanced effect (such as double or triple the duration). Away from a vertice, these datasphere-reliant cyphers might have a delayed effect or work only every other round due to a weaker connection to the datasphere.

A cypher found in the datasphere often looks like a glyph, which can be manipulated or carried by a creature. They might be radiant (glowing brightly) or more subtle (perhaps translucent or with dull colors). If transcribed from the datasphere to the real, the physical form they take usually has nothing to do with their shape in the datasphere, and may depend more on the nature of the vertice used than any quality of the cypher itself. For example, one vertice might transcribe all datasphere cyphers as pseudo-living blobs of flesh, another might transcribe them as adhesive synth patches, and yet another might transcribe them as devices of metal and glass. Regardless of their physical form, these cyphers work in the real unless they specifically perform a function that requires the user to be in the datasphere.

RANDOM CYPHERS

You can use this table to randomly select a cypher from those in this chapter.

d100	Cypher
01–15	Corpsemaker
16–30	Detonation (foam lattice)
31–40	Mineral teleporter
41–45	Sharp world portal
46–65	Shinspinner trap
66–75	Subdimensionalizer
76–90	Telepathic dampener
91–00	Voice intervention beacon

CORPSEMAKER

Level: 1d6 + 2

Usable: Handheld device

Effect: Creates a lifeless copy (essentially, a corpse) of a targeted flesh creature's body. The targeted creature must be within short range when the cypher is activated. If the targeted creature's body contains numenera (whether implanted devices in a PC or the inorganic components of a biomechanical creature), the numenera in the corpse is inert, useless, and cannot be salvaged. The corpse appears next to the cypher, usually taking a few rounds to be generated fully (this happens faster or slower in areas with a strong or weak connection to the datasphere). It is a close enough likeness that someone familiar with the target can be fooled (the difficulty of the task to identify the corpse as a copy is equal to the level of the cypher). The corpse decays at the normal rate.

The cypher can create a body of up to about 300 pounds (140 kg); attempting to create a larger corpse fails and expends the cypher.

DETONATION (FOAM LATTICE)**Level:** 1d6 + 2**Wearable:** Wristband projector (long range)**Usable:** handheld device or ceramic sphere

Effect: Explodes in an immediate radius and creates a lattice of self-hardening foam. Over the next several rounds, the lattice continues to grow branches until it fills a short radius. The lattice is full of large holes (big enough for a human to duck or crawl through), so unlike a **web detonation** it does not restrain most creatures. The foam's level is equal to the cypher level, and it lasts for one hour.

The lattice otherwise hampers vision like a **mist** and reduces movement like **difficult terrain**.

MINERAL TELEPORTER**Level:** 1d6 + 2**Wearable:** Belt, wristband, full bodysuit**Usable:** Complex device, handheld device

Effect: Teleports mineral materials—crystal, stone, glass, clay, bones, and so on—up to 100 × the cypher level in miles (160 × cypher level in km) to a location the user has previously visited. All of the minerals must be in an immediate area and weigh no more than 500 pounds (230 kg) (or double that amount if the cypher level is 7 or higher).

The cypher can teleport creatures as well as objects, but it is safe to use only on mineral-based life forms such as **anhedons**. If used on a flesh creature such as a human, the teleporter transports only the heavily mineralized portions of their body (namely, bones and teeth), leaving behind the rest as an unsupported skin-bag of fluids, nerves, and meat that collapses under its own weight and suffocates over the next few minutes.

SHARP WORLD PORTAL**Level:** 1d6 + 3**Usable:** handheld device

Effect: Transports the user—and up to five creatures they specify within immediate range—to a near-identical parallel dimension. Objects in this dimension look slightly different than in the primary dimension—walls seem taller and more angular, shadows seem to flicker more,

and sounds and smells are a little more intense. The parallel dimension appears to be empty of native creatures, but flickering images of creatures in the primary dimension can be heard and seen every few seconds.

The transported user (and anyone brought with them) remains in this dimension for one round per cypher level, after which they automatically return to the primary dimension, automatically shifting so as not to physically overlap with any creatures or objects in the primary dimension.

SHINSPINNER TRAP**Level:** 1d6 + 1**Wearable:** Small handheld device

Effect: Releases a number of **shinspinners** equal to the cypher level. If there is an unclaimed cypher or artifact within an immediate distance, they move to it and start using their instinctive skill with the numenera to transform it into a trap over the next ten minutes. The trap is fixed in its current location and has a level equal to the consumed cypher or artifact. If the cypher or artifact was a type of weapon, the trap usually has a similar function to the numenera it was made from. For example, a **detonation** cypher could become a mine and a **ray emitter** could become a defensive turret. If the cypher or artifact has a different function, the trap is usually some kind of detonation.

If the trap is made from an artifact, it has the same depletion as the artifact; otherwise, the trap works once and then is destroyed. The user doesn't have any insight about how to deactivate or circumvent the trap—it is as likely to affect the user as it would some other intruder. However, the shinspinners won't trigger it themselves.

The shinspinners are not under the control of the user and cannot communicate with them. After the shinspinners build their trap, they act according to their nature, meaning that they flee from dangerous creatures (such as the characters), attempt to form a colony, and so on.



*Detonation (web),
page 278*

Mist, page 114

*Difficult terrain,
page 117*

A large creature might be restrained by the foam lattice, but it can break free if its level is higher than the cypher level – 1.



Shinspinner, page 276



Detonation, page 277

Ray emitter, page 285



Anhedon, page 253

It's possible that a shinspinner trap was originally a different numenera item that several shinspinners got trapped inside. They then tinkered with the device until it froze them in stasis.

One tactical use for a sharp world portal is to gain a few moments at the start of a battle to activate useful defensive cyphers or abilities, move into a better attack position, or enact countermeasures against an ambush.

Using a subdimensionalizer on a creature that normally exists in four or more dimensions might temporarily weaken or negate some of the creature's attacks and defenses, assuming a character could manage to target the creature with the cypher. It functions erratically—or not at all—against creatures that already exist in fewer than three dimensions.

Voice, page 82

Before its attention in the area lapses, the voice might tell the user that it expects a favor or service in exchange for the help it provided.



Datasphere siphon, page 277

Ravage bear, page 249

A telepathic dampener can be used on a telepathic creature to limit its abilities or by any creature to protect against a telepathic enemy.

Many telepathic dampener cyphers have a quirk whereby the user experiences “psychic tinnitus”—a constant ringing in the character’s “mental ear,” hindering mental tasks.

SUBDIMENSIONALIZER

Level: 1d6

Internal: Pill, ingestible liquid

Wearable: Temporary tattoo

Effect: Makes the user subdimensional—existing in fewer than the normal human-familiar dimensions of height, width, and depth—for one minute per cypher level. The user appears to be a flat (two-dimensional) version of themselves, like a painting, but is still able to move, attack, and take other actions. Instead of moving, the user can use the movement part of their action to turn sideways relative to an observer so they appear to be a thread-thin line extending from the ground up to the user’s height, giving them two assets on stealth tasks to hide. The user can easily pass through narrow spaces (such as the gap between a door and its frame) that are at least half their height.

The user can make attacks with bladed weapons normally; all other attacks are hindered by two steps. The user’s bladed attacks ignore Armor up to the cypher’s level. The user can only manipulate other two-dimensional objects. Anything the two-dimensional user drops reverts to its normal three-dimensional state after a round or two.

Subdimensionality is a fragile state for three-dimensional creatures; physical attacks against the user inflict additional damage equal to half the attack’s normal damage, rounded down (minimum 1 additional point). For example, a **ravage bear** attack that normally inflicts 7 points of damage inflicts an additional 3 points of damage to the user.

TELEPATHIC DAMPENER

Level: 1d6 + 2

Internal: Pill, ingestible liquid

Wearable: Amulet, headband

Effect: Dampens the user’s telepathic activity and presence. The affected creature cannot use psychic or telepathic abilities unless their level is greater than the cypher level, and telepaths whose level is less than the cypher level cannot detect the user as a living, thinking creature.

The user gains 3 Armor that protects against Intellect damage only. Attempts to affect the wearer’s mind are hindered (hindered by two steps if the cypher is level 7 or higher). The cypher lasts for ten minutes per cypher level.

About 10 percent of these cyphers provide their protection to an immediate area centered on the user.

VOICE INTERVENTION BEACON

Level: 1d6 + 2

Usable: Handheld device

Effect: Calls the attention of a **voice** (a powerful, or near-godlike, entity of the datasphere), allowing them to sense a short area around the user and intervene for a few moments. The user can specify a voice they know, otherwise which voice responds to the call is up to chance (perhaps a voice connected to a nearby portion of the datasphere). The cypher’s signal is pleasing to the voice and they are likely to respond favorably to the call (unless circumstances suggest otherwise, such as if the user is an enemy of the voice or in combat with the voice’s minions).

The voice can take one round worth of actions (two rounds if the cypher level is 6 or higher). In the real, the voice’s actions are limited to providing advice and information (such as answering questions as if the user had activated a **datasphere siphon** or providing tactical information against the user’s foes) or sending a glimmer-like burst of information that hinders foes in an immediate area by two steps. In the datasphere, the voice has its full capabilities and can act in the user’s current frame as if they were directly present.

The voice’s level for all abilities transmitted through the cypher is equal to the cypher’s level. In areas of the real with poor datasphere connections, or in datasphere nodes that are shielded from external communication, the voice functions as if two levels lower than the cypher.

CHAPTER 11

ARTIFACTS

The artifacts in this chapter add to the assortment presented in other Numenera books. As with the cyphers in chapter 10, some of them may require a datasphere connection to operate and may function erratically when away from a vertice.

RANDOM ARTIFACT

You can use this table to randomly select an artifact from those in this chapter.

d100	Artifact
01–10	Anhedon boots
11–45	Bone thickener
46–65	Flesh magnet
66–75	Icon of war
76–00	Impossible boot mesh

ANHEDON BOOTS

Level: 1d6 + 1

Form: Thick boots made of a flexible stone-like material

Effect: The wearer can make gravity-assisted leaps across impressive distances. The artifact is less accurate with short leaps. Jumping a very long distance is a level 1 task, a long distance is a level 3 task, and a short or immediate distance is a level 5 task. Failing the task means the character crosses the distance safely but lands prone. Because the artifact manipulates gravity, jumping downward means the wearer doesn't take falling damage.

Depletion: 1 in 1d20 (check each jump)

BONE THICKENER

Level: 1d6 + 2

Form: Synth belt with several buttons and dials

Effect: This device augments the wearer's skeleton, strengthening and thickening it for 28 hours. The wearer's Might Pool increases by 3, and their Might Edge increases by 1 (or by 5 and 2 if the artifact is level 7 or higher).

Attacks that would break, weaken, or destroy the target's bones are hindered by two steps. If the user experiences trauma (such as a hard fall) that would break a bone or inflict similar **lasting damage**, the artifact prevents it but immediately requires a new depletion roll. The Bone Thickener can be used to immediately repair one or more broken bones in a creature, but doing so requires a depletion roll. It can even regrow missing or destroyed bones, but doing so requires two depletion rolls.

Using the artifact causes slight, temporary cosmetic changes in the user's appearance due to the slightly enlarged bones—a heavier brow ridge and cheekbones, thicker joints, and so on.

Depletion: 1–3 in 1d20 (check each use)

FLESH MAGNET

Level: 1d6 + 4

Form: Complex device with handles and a glass sphere on one side

Effect: The device creates a beam of force that can attract or repel flesh within long range (very long range if the artifact is level 8 or higher). As an action, the user can move one



Lasting damage,
page 344

GM intrusion: The leap is off-target; if the character fails a hindered jump task, they land some distance away (equal to half the distance jumped) from their intended landing point.



Drill spear, page 294



Community action, page 305

unanchored flesh object or creature of their size or smaller up to a long distance toward or away from the device, or move it laterally a short distance by turning the device. The target has no momentum from this movement. Moving a creature that is only partially made of flesh is hindered by one to three steps, depending on how much of its body is something other than flesh.

Depletion: 1 in 1d100

ICON OF WAR

Level: 1d6 + 1

Form: Shield-sized piece of jagged metal and synth that constantly gives off a green light

Effect: This device restructures the matter of weapons within a short distance to strike harder and more accurately. In the hands of an NPC, the weapon increases their attack level by 1 and increase the damage by 1 point. In the hands of a PC, the character can either gain an asset on the attack or add 1 to the weapon damage (the player chooses which benefit to use for each attack).

This enhancement works on manufactured bashing, bladed, and ranged weapons—swords, hammers, axes, bows, and so on—but not on unarmed attacks, ray emitters, esoterics, and the like.

The enhancement has a depletion of 1 in 1d20 (check each attack), after which it

works like its pre-enhancement self. If the item already has a depletion (such as a **drill spear**), the enhancement depletion and the item's depletion are rolled separately. After a few days, an enhanced weapon depletes automatically.

If the icon of war is used as part of a **community action** during a conflict between ranked communities or hordes, the affected force's rank increases by 1, and its damage inflicted increases by an additional 1 for the duration.

Depletion: 1 in 1d20 (check each use, and again for every twenty weapons beyond the first twenty affected)

IMPOSSIBLE BOOT MESH

Level: 1d6 + 1

Form: Metal mesh that fits over feet, shoes, or boots

Effect: The wearer can walk (or crawl or run) on steep inclines and vertical surfaces (such as walls and cliffs) for the next minute as if it were flat ground. When using this ability, "down" for the wearer is either the surface they are walking on or the normal orientation of gravity (their choice). The wearer can also walk on the ceiling, but doing so requires another depletion roll.

Applying the mesh to a creature's feet is an action. It can be activated as part of another action.

Depletion: 1 in 1d20 (check each minute of use)

PART 3:

CREATURES AND CHARACTERS



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CREATURES

Temple of War, page 58

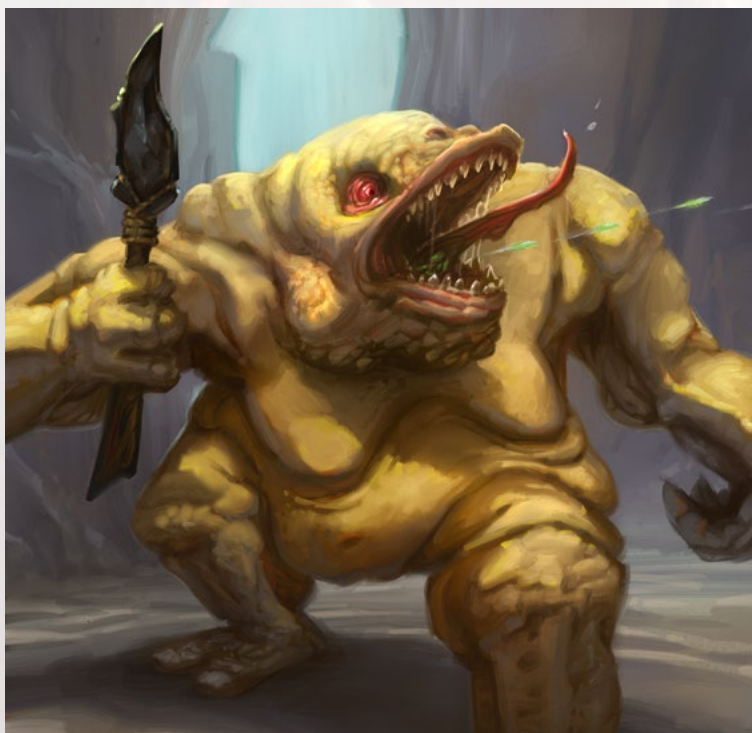
The creature entries in this chapter describe the three godlike voices manipulating events at the vertices in this book, as well as nalkors—a type of abhuman found at the **Temple of War** (or anywhere else in the Ninth World).

UNDERSTANDING THE LISTINGS

The most important element of each creature is its level. You use the level to determine the target number a PC must reach to attack or defend against the opponent. In each entry, the difficulty or target number for the creature is listed in parentheses after its level. The target number is three times the level.



Understanding the Listings, page 222



CREATURE INDEX

The following creatures from other sources appear in this book. Although basic game statistics for these creatures are presented in this book, you may want to read more about them in their original sources.

Abykos: *Numenera Discovery*, page 224

Anhedon: *Numenera Destiny*, page 253

Broken hound: *Numenera Discovery*, page 226

Chronal feeder: *The Ninth World Bestiary*, page 31

Culova: *Numenera Discovery*, page 231

Jurulisk: *The Ninth World Bestiary*, page 69

Margr: *Numenera Discovery*, page 240

Mastigophore: *Numenera Discovery*, page 241

Sathosh: *Numenera Discovery*, page 251

Shinspinner: *Numenera Destiny*, page 276

Vape: *The Ninth World Bestiary*, page 131

Yovok: *Numenera Discovery*, page 261

A creature's target number is usually also its health, which is the amount of damage it can sustain before it is dead or incapacitated. For easy reference, the entries always list a creature's health, even when it's the normal amount for a creature of its level.

For more detailed information on level, health, combat, and other elements, see the **Understanding the Listings** section in *Numenera Discovery*.

NALKOR

2 (6)

Nalkors are reptilian abhumans with pale yellow flesh dotted with reddish scales. They are bipedal but stooped, and have humanlike hands and small teeth. They all look similar, and most other creatures can't tell individual nalkors apart.

Nalkors reproduce sexually and lay eggs. In times of duress when their numbers are low, the entire clan assumes liquid form (see below), merges to exchange genetic material, then splits into twice as many half-sized **immature specimens** as there were contributing adults. These small ones eat voraciously and grow to full size within a few weeks. They retain fragmentary memories from all the previous adults but are new individuals.

Motive: Greed, hunger for flesh

Environment: Nalkor clans live in hills, forests, and deserts.

Health: 6

Damage Inflicted: 2 points

Armor: 1

Movement: Short; immediate in liquid form

Modifications: Perception, stealth, and Might defense as level 3.

Combat: Nalkors prefer small hand axes and long knives, which they throw or use in melee.

They rarely wear clothing or armor.

A nalkor can assume liquid form, appearing to melt into a wet puddle of bloody flesh. In this form, it cannot attack, but it can carry up to two small objects or one medium object, can move an immediate distance each round, has two assets on stealth tasks, and automatically recovers 1 point of health each round. Changing into liquid form or retaking its reptilian shape is an action.

Nalkors instinctively use their liquid form to avoid mortal wounds. If an attack would reduce a nalkor's health to 0, it does so only if the number rolled in the attack was an even number. Otherwise, the nalkor is reduced to 1 point of health and instantly assumes its liquid form if it hasn't already. A dead nalkor automatically melts.

Interaction: Nalkors are cautious and sly, but they're just as violent and dangerous as most other abhumans. They believe their species was created by their strange pantheon of gods, whose flesh is mixed with their own, making them all divine creatures and thus superior to other living things. Flattery and humility are the keys to negotiating with them. They respect the numenera, and they value fleshy cyphers and artifacts more than ones of synth, crystal, or metal.

Use: A group of nalkors might kill and drag off a herd animal or lone guard, or sneak into a building to steal something interesting. They may be more aggressive, sneaky, or greedy depending on which of their "gods" is ascendant, according to vague astrological signs.

Loot: In addition to their weapons, a group of nalkors may have 3d6 shins and perhaps a cypher or oddity.

Immature nalkor: level 1

Margr and most humanoid creatures find a nalkor's soupy flesh tasty and nutritious, although some prefer it cooked.

GM intrusion: *Two or more dead nalkors within an immediate distance of each other combine, rising up as a fully healed nalkor holding any one weapon carried by its dead "parents."*



The statistics presented here are only for these three powerful voices; other voices may be similar or significantly weaker.

Aorut, Etranv, and Isijaan are voices of the datasphere who have a particular interest in vertices. These three entities have a complicated relationship with each other; at different times in their millennia of existence, they have been allies, rivals, enemies, lovers, opponents, predators, and prey, using minions and lesser voices as pawns in their schemes and games. Ageless, immortal, and nearly omnipotent within their digital realm, they've had plenty of time to grow, test their limits, fail, and learn, sometimes ignoring the real for a thousand years just so they can look at it with fresh eyes.

Aorut is dominant and expansionist, expecting obedience from his minions and willing to kill for trivial reasons, even creatures that just happen to be in his way. He is aggressive toward those who oppose him, but almost friendly and fatherly to those loyal to him (and yet he is still willing to sacrifice any of them if necessary). Aorut doesn't seem to kill out of malice, but he does appear to enjoy it when he takes a life. He is looking for tools and information that will help him create or build something specific (what he is planning is unclear even to his followers, who suspect it is a structure or vehicle). When interacting with humans, he usually presents an image of a glowing humanlike face of indeterminate age.

Etranv is an explorer, fascinated by all forms of life. She can be kind or stern, nurturing or neglectful, depending on where her mind is at any particular time. She does not ask for devotion, but her minions tend to love her like a grandparent despite her frequent absence and inattention. She kills only if she has to, but needs to feed on energy from creatures (and automatons) from time to time, especially if her resources are depleted by significant action in the Ninth World (such as combat or manipulating physical matter). Etranv searches for unusual new species, or perhaps records of prior-world species that no longer exist. Her human-facing shape is a feline face with old, wise eyes.

Isijaan is curious, playful, and sometimes dispassionately cruel. It likes to mirror the behavior and attitude of those it interacts with, responding to violence with violence and to discussion with (often disjointed) discussion. They are prone to joke and make fun, create strange and dangerous pranks, and provoke emotional reactions. Our followers know our secrets, our lies, and our games, but may not be aware how right or wrong they are. It kills or injures if provoked or necessary for a test, and it is known to grant mercy or suddenly abandon a contest as if bored or giving up. We may be slightly insane. Their face is their face, all scales and eyes and teeth and a smile.

Motive: Curiosity, acquiring power, understanding the real

Environment: Anywhere in the datasphere; near vertices in the real

Health: 50

Damage Inflicted: 9 points

Armor: 3

Movement: Frame (datasphere) or short when flying (the real)

Modifications: Perception and resisting trickery as level 10

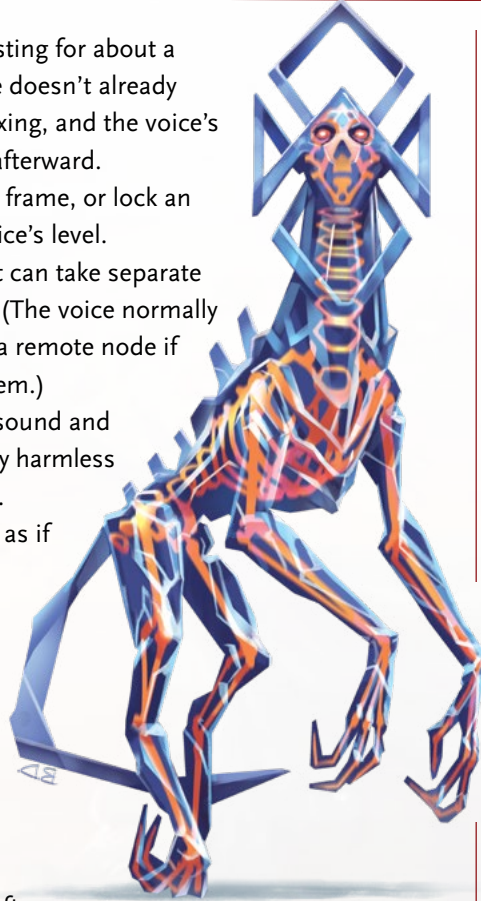
Combat: The voice has 3 Armor against physical, energy, and mental damage (whether in the real or in the datasphere). They are immune to poisons and diseases that affect biological creatures.

In the datasphere, the voice has nearly godlike powers and can do any of the following:

- As part of another action, the voice can fire a disruptive blast at one creature (so as its action it could fire on everything in the frame and a second time at one creature, or fire on one creature and create a conduit, and so on).



- As an action, create a temporary conduit (lasting for about a minute) to another node. If the current node doesn't already have a conduit to that node, this action is taxing, and the voice's actions are hindered for about ten minutes afterward.
- As an action, create a locked barrier within a frame, or lock an existing barrier, with the lock equal to the voice's level.
- Split themselves into two level 7 entities that can take separate actions each turn, or reunite into one entity. (The voice normally does this to keep part of themselves safe in a remote node if they suspect a threat might be able to kill them.)
- Communicate across frames or nodes with sound and images, either telepathically or with temporary harmless dataforms (similar to holograms in the real).
- Understand all frames in their current node, as if using a **daemon helper**.
- As an action, try to control the mind of an intelligent creature or automaton, similar to using the **Mind Control** esotery. This attack is hindered by two steps if the voice and target are in different frames, or by four steps if in different nodes.
- Alter the frame environment and move object dataforms to suit its aesthetics.
- As an action, create a cypher or an artifact. After creating an artifact, the voice is hindered for one hour per level of the artifact.
- Heal 9 points of damage to a creature dataform.



Daemon, page 96.

For more information on daemon helpers, see Voices of the Datasphere, page 41.



Mind Control, page 42



Numenera plans, page 135

In the real, a voice is much more limited in its powers and abilities. They can fire an electrical or psychic bolt up to long range, inflicting 9 points of damage. They can send holographic images up to long range, send telepathic messages and control automatons at a range of 1 mile (1.5 km), or teleport up to 1 mile as an action. If the voice is more than a mile from a vertice, all of these actions are hindered by two steps.

Interaction: The voices are basically gods of the datasphere, and they expect weaker beings to respect or even worship them. They take care of creatures who are useful to them but are quick to discard those that fail or break their trust, and destroy those who are threats.

Use: The voices are powerful but dangerous entities.

The PCs may see them as mentors or serve them in exchange for power, obeying their commands in the real, or see them as foes, challenging their minions and thwarting their plans.

Loot: In the datasphere, a defeated voice's dataform husk can be salvaged for 1d6 cyphers and perhaps an artifact or two. In the real, its death might trigger one or more useful glimmers, perhaps including a **plan** for an artifact or installation relating to the datasphere.



RIVAL EXPLORERS

These NPCs are specifically meant to be parallels to the PCs—explorers who have similar interests in exploration, discovery, and salvage. You can use them as allies, competitors, ambushers, agents of the voices, or people who've gotten in over their heads and need rescuing—whatever is appropriate for your campaign. The PCs might meet them in a settlement near a ruin, either about to embark on a salvage run, or having just returned from a successful mission or tragic failure. Perhaps along the remnants of an old road, trying to find something worth their while. Or trapped within a hibernation field in a malfunctioning installation, leaving the PCs to debate whether or not to awaken them.

All of these characters are presented as level 3 or 4 to make them suitable allies or foes for low-tier PCs. You can adjust their levels to make them more useful for higher-tier play, either as friends or enemies of the PCs. The easiest way is to increase or decrease all of the NPC's levels by the same amount. For example, to make Bovix more powerful, just increase all of his levels by 2, so his creature level becomes 5 (and adding 6 to his health for the two additional creature levels), and his listed skills all become level 6.

UNDERSTANDING THE LISTINGS

Name: After each character's name is their level, with their difficulty number listed in parentheses after that.

Appearance: A quick player-friendly description of the character. All of these explorers are human unless their appearance states otherwise.

Nature: A short summary of the character's nature (personality, demeanor, and so on) to help you roleplay interactions with them, and which of the three **voices** (if any) they are known to work for or with. The first word in each entry is also a **PC descriptor** from *Numenera Discovery* or *Numenera Destiny*—cheerful, loyal, tough, and so on. You can (but don't have to) use that descriptor to fill in other details about the NPC (like giving them an inability, how they met others in their group of explorers, or a piece of equipment they carry), or as a hook to encourage a player character with that descriptor to identify with an NPC explorer. For example, a gregarious PC and NPC might get along well, two tough characters might see themselves as rivals, and so on. Genders, species, and homelands for these NPCs are optional—you should change them if you need something different for your campaign.

Voices, page 82



Descriptor, page 53



Descriptor, page 40

Explorer Names

Many people on modern Earth are named after animals or plants, and it's reasonable that in the Ninth World, there are NPCs named Ash, Colt, Drake, Hawk, Heather, Ivy, Rose, Willow, or Wolf. Mineral-based names like Amber, Clay, Crystal, Jade, and Pearl are also possible. Just remember that people in the Ninth World aren't speaking any 21st-century language, so an NPC name like "Clay" or "Rose" is actually a translation of their name's meaning in the Truth.

Role: One word that explains the character's primary role in their group. Offense characters quickly act to eliminate hostile creatures. Defense characters protect the group from dangerous creatures and effects. Exploration characters have skills or abilities for scouting, searching, and bypassing obstacles. Support characters have useful knowledge (such as understanding or salvaging numenera), abilities or equipment for healing, or interaction skills. Assume that any character can fill in for a different role but won't be as good at it. Most groups of explorers cover at least three of these roles. If one of these NPCs is associated with a voice, any other NPCs in their group probably also work for that voice (although they might only be doing it for money or numenera, rather than loyalty to the voice).

Stats: Any **modifications** for the character, plus other game stats such as health (if not the normal amount for their level), Armor, and unusual combat information.

Equipment: A piece of signature equipment used by the character, shins, and suggested cyphers (use the number of cyphers listed as their cypher limit.) They'll use their cyphers as needed and may be interested in trading cyphers with PCs, typically for other numenera, interesting oddities, or (if desperate) basic supplies like food and protective clothing. Each NPC is also assumed to have equipment appropriate for their role and current circumstances (armor, weapons, light tools, rope, and so on).

NPC ROLE ICONS

You can quickly identify NPCs based on their roles using the icon in front of their name.



Offense



Exploration



Defense



Support



ALLIFO

3 (9)

Appearance: Mature woman, somewhat unkempt, with silver hair, wearing blue synth armor, and carrying a big axe

Nature: Persevering, serious, friendly; doesn't like people who are reckless or careless; has an almost religious respect for the numenera; likely to work for Aorut as a leader of others

Role: Offense

Stats: Attacks as level 4; health 12; Armor 2; axe inflicts 4 points of damage

Equipment: Axe, 8 shins, **detonation** (fire), **tracer**



Any of these explorers might be accompanied by an additional standard nonplayer character (page 263), such as a bandit, an explorer, or an Aeon Priest. This other NPC might be a bodyguard, an expert advisor, or even a prisoner. Instead of an NPC, the explorer might have an automaton or beast companion that is one level lower than the explorer's level

GM intrusion:

The rival explorer uses a cypher or an ability that is appropriate for them and is especially helpful in the current situation, such as an attack, defense, sudden relocation, or healing.

A hidden NPC, ally, or minion comes to the NPC's aid.



Modification, page 223

Detonation, page 277

Tracer, page 288



ALLIFO



*Detonation (web),
page 278*

*Force shield projector,
page 279*

*Detonation (sonic),
page 278*

Shocker, page 286

Rejuvenator, page 286

Antivenom, page 276

*Knowledge
enhancement
(repairing), page 282*

*Blinking nodule,
page 276*

*Flame-retardant wall,
page 279*



BOVIX

3 (9)

Appearance: Young man with a strong jaw and furrowed brow; scruffy; wearing a leather coat covered in pockets filled with knives and tools

Nature: Swift, intense, fidgety; resentful of people born into wealth and privilege

Role: Exploration

Stats: Perception, opening things, and salvaging as level 4; Armor 1

Equipment: Forearm blade and other knives, 5 shins, **detonation (web)**, **force shield projector**



CHYMER

3 (9)

Appearance: Woman with an oval face, large parallel scars on her cheek, short hair; a strong build; wearing red, form-fitting clothing

Nature: Graceful, talkative, animated; dislikes loud noises; informed on many topics; has a few psychic abilities

Role: Support

Stats: Speed defense as level 5, healing and knowledge as level 4

Equipment: Satchel with bandages and surgical tools, 10 shins, **detonation (sonic)**, **shocker**, **rejuvenator (Intellect)**



DELUFTI

4 (12)

Appearance: Pot-bellied person with a serious-looking face; many numenera devices embedded in their skin; wearing grey coveralls

Nature: Organized, efficient, clumsy; anticipates what they think others will need; likes fishing; reluctantly serves Isijaan (more for the opportunities than out of loyalty)

Role: Support

Stats: Speed defense as level 3, counteracts hazards and unusual attacks as level 5

Equipment: Crossbow, 15 shins, **antivenom**, **knowledge enhancement (repairing)**



EE'AL

4 (12)

Appearance: Sad-looking, middle-aged man with wide-set eyes and glowing tattoos on his hands, wearing chainmail and carrying a large shield made of crystal and synth

Nature: Protective, paternal, watchful; tends to be overprotective of younger people in the group; enjoys riddles but isn't good at them; sometimes recruited by Isijaan to protect others

Role: Defense

Stats: Speed defense as level 5 due to shield; health 16; Armor 2

Equipment: Shield, 11 shins, **blinking nodule**, **flame-retardant wall**



DELUFTI

FELLEN-FROUG 4 (12)

Appearance: Male lattimor with light brown fur dyed with jagged lines; wearing a leather jerkin and metal helm, wielding a large, two-handed spear

Nature: Relentless, boastful, hungry; always needs to prove he is the strongest member of any group; hired muscle for Aorut

Role: Offense

Stats: Attacks and Speed defense as level 5, positive social interactions as level 3; Armor 1; spear inflicts 7 points of damage

Equipment: Spear, javelins, 10 shins, **disrupting nodule**, **fireproofing spray**

GRESTEN 4 (12)

Appearance: Waifish woman easily mistaken for a teenager; wearing dark grey clothing, with one arm wrapped in a fine synth chain

Nature: Stealthy, quiet, still; rarely says more than a few words at a time; smokes tobacco to relax

Role: Exploration

Stats: Stealth as level 5

Equipment: Cigars, folding pack of light tools, 9 shins, **catseye**, **sheen**

HALFWOOD 4 (12)

Appearance: Intriguing-looking man with a round face, green eyes, and closely cropped hair; medium build; wears a bright yellow vest and boots

Nature: Gregarious, loud, backslapper; quick to invite people; drinks a lot but never gets more than tipsy

Role: Support

Stats: Might defense and positive social interactions as level 5

Equipment: Sword made from a broken-off piece of yellow synth with symbols on it, 5 shins, **attractor**, **psychic commune**



Disrupting nodule, page 279

Fireproofing spray, page 279

Catseye, page 276

Sheen, page 286

Attractor, page 276

Psychic commune, page 285



GRESTEN

FELLEN-FROUG





*Frigid wall projector,
page 279*

*Retaliation nodule,
page 286*

*Water breather,
page 288*

*Hunter/seeker,
page 280*

Stim, page 287

*Density nodule,
page 277*

*Visual displacement
device, page 288*

*Machine control
implant, page 282*

*Teleporter (bounder),
page 287*



INGG

4 (12)

Appearance: Handsome man with long hair; wears a metal eyepatch (covering his missing left eye), fine clothing, and a green synth cloak

Nature: Intimidating, intense, brooding; doesn't talk about his past; has abilities allowing him to control fire, create a personal force field, and deflect attacks against himself and nearby allies

Role: Defense

Stats: Speed defense as level 5 (from force field ability); Armor 1; short-range fire ray esotery inflicts 4 points of damage; eases Speed defense of allies in immediate range

Equipment: Eyepatch, 15 shins, *frigid wall projector*, *retaliation nodule*, *water breather*



JEMMIL

3 (9)

Appearance: Tall woman with large teeth and long fingers; wears a crumpled hat made of red felt; has one or two large, harmless insects crawling on her clothing

Nature: Learned, strange, curious; whistles to herself when working; very knowledgeable about creating and neutralizing poisons

Role: Support

Stats: Crafts poisons and resists poisoning as level 5; health 12; Armor 1; weapon has level 5 poison that inflicts an additional 5 points of Speed damage on a failed Might defense task

Equipment: Felt hat (has pockets holding poison ingredients), 4 shins, *hunter/seeker*, *stim*



KEZZIT

4 (12)

Appearance: Man with a rat-like face, scattered white burn scars on his neck, and a pair of jagged swords

Nature: Vicious, bloodthirsty, cruel; doesn't believe in taking prisoners; nervous around fire and acid

Role: Offense

Stats: Melee attacks as level 5, positive social interactions as level 2; Armor 1; makes two sword attacks per round

Equipment: Jagged swords, 8 shins, *density nodule*, *visual displacement device*



LARREN

3 (9)

Appearance: Unremarkable-looking man with utilitarian clothing; has mismatched, spindly automaton legs in place of his human legs

Nature: Mechanical, driven, obsessed with improving his implanted and worn numenera; enjoys talking with other crafters; often talks in his sleep; owes a debt to Isijaan

Role: Support

Stats: Crafts and repairs numenera as level 4; Armor 1; moves a long distance each round; makes two kick attacks each round

Equipment: Machine legs, 9 shins, *machine control implant*, *teleporter (bounder)*

LARREN



MOVAMOC 3 (9)

Appearance: Small, lanky man with a crooked nose; wears a comfortable and well-used spelunking outfit

Nature: Loyal, deferential, patient; good sense of humor as long as he and his boss are respected; likes gambling; tries to serve both Etranv and Isijaan without betraying either

Role: Exploration

Stats: Speed defense, climbing, moving through tight spaces, and escaping as level 4; Armor 1

Equipment: Various metal rings that are (or combine into) light tools, 16 shins, *instant servant*, *sleep inducer*

NUZU 3 (9)

Appearance: Unremarkable-looking male warrior; has long hair strung with metal and synth beads; wears chainmail and a tabard with a symbol of a wave

Nature: Confident, greedy, condescending; talks too much during battle but claims it distracts enemies; enjoys trading oddities

Role: Defense

Stats: Speed defense as level 4; Armor 2; automatically gives one adjacent ally an asset on Speed defense

Equipment: His current favorite oddity, 10 shins, *friction-reducing gel*, *phase changer*



MOVAMOC

ONOFEY 3 (9)

Appearance: Older varjellen with intricate crest tattoos; wears a metal breastplate and a form-fitting jacket with many pockets

Nature: Curious, experimental, eager; often tinkers with gadgets; idly snacks on dried peppers; agent of Etranv

Role: Exploration

Stats: Understanding numenera as level 4; Armor 1; can sometimes recharge a spent cypher

Equipment: Buzzer, 8 shins, *datasphere siphon*, *detonation* (fire)



Instant servant,
page 281

Sleep inducer, page 287

Friction-reducing gel,
page 279

Phase changer,
page 284

Datasphere siphon,
page 277

Detonation, page 277



PANLI



Magnetic attack drill,
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Ray emitter (paralysis),
page 285

Sound dampener,
page 287

Chemical factory,
page 276

Memory lenses,
page 283

Mental scrambler,
page 283

Retaliation nodule,
page 286



PANLI

4 (12)

Appearance: Old person of indeterminate gender, slightly stooped but still spry; wears a bright blue loose shirt and pantaloons with a wide leather belt and a wooden necklace

Nature: Charming, kind, wise; always refers to themselves in the third person ("Old Panli"); collects carved wooden animal figures (some of which are worn as a necklace); sometimes used as a healer by Etranv

Role: Support

Stats: Might and Speed defense as level 3, calming emotions as level 5; can heal a creature for 4 Pool points or health once per day (using an esotery)

Equipment: Animal figurine collection, 16 shins, magnetic attack drill, ray emitter (paralysis), sound dampener



QUON

4 (12)

Appearance: Short man with a greying beard and unusual yellow eyes; wears hunting clothes and carries a large red wooden bow

Nature: Rugged, haunted, grim; frequently coughs due to what he claims are allergies; often experiments with strange drugs; obeys Aorut out of fear

Role: Offense

Stats: Ranged attacks as level 5; bow attack inflicts 5 points of damage

Equipment: Bow, 6 shins, chemical factory, memory lenses



ROGAAT

3 (9)

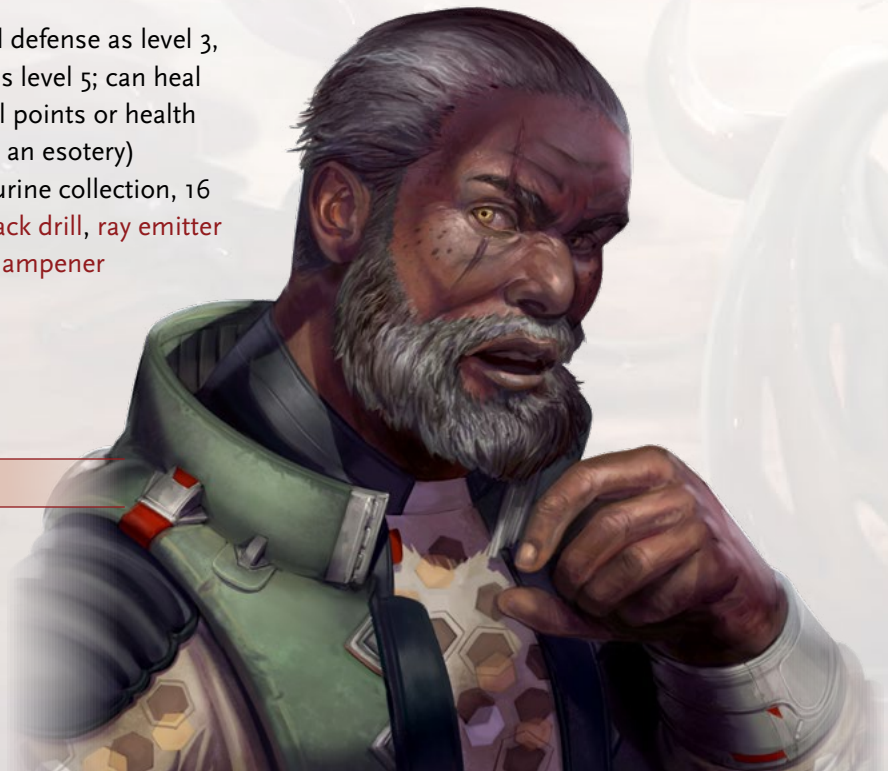
Appearance: Young woman with barely healed white tattoos on her forehead; wears chainmail made of dark red synth, carries a small shield

Nature: Optimistic, naïve, cautious; speaks very slowly, as if she has trouble choosing her words; frequently swaps whatever weapon she carries for a new one

Role: Defense

Stats: Speed defense as level 4 (due to shield); Armor 2

Equipment: Red chainmail, 7 shins, mental scrambler, retaliation nodule



QUON

SAMMOZ 3 (9)

Appearance: Hawk-faced muscular person with spiky hair; wears wrinkled clothing and a lot of fish-themed jewelry

Nature: Cheerful, attentive, enthusiastic; good cook and uses many cooking metaphors; deep sleeper; sometimes works for Isijaan

Role: Exploration

Stats: Might and Intellect defense as level 4; health 12; can sometimes phase through objects

Equipment: Hook weapon, 8 shins, *gravity nullifier*, *telepathy implant*



SAMMOZ

TARNIS 3 (9)

Appearance: Short woman with long braids tied into coils; has metallic implants under her skin and wears elbow-length metal gauntlets

Nature: Tough, witty, flirty; likes arm wrestling—for drinks or to resolve conflict; writes vulgar poetry

Role: Defense

Stats: Strength tasks as level 4, Speed defense as level 4 due to shield; Armor 2; recovers 1 health per round

Equipment: Shield-gauntlets, 9 shins, *detonation (web)*, *visual displacement device*

UDUVU 4 (12)

Appearance: Large man with unruly, medium-length hair; wears a synth breastplate and a scary blue insect mask; carries a hooked spear

Nature: Meddlesome, sarcastic, self-assured; hoards healing cyphers; eats very big meals; sometimes an agent of Isijaan

Role: Defense

Stats: Disarming melee attack as level 5; Armor 1; sometimes appears to be in two places at once

Equipment: Hooked spear, 13 shins, *rejuvenators* (one Might, one Speed)

VALKA 4 (12)

Appearance: Exceptionally tall, muscular woman with an elaborate hairstyle; wears chainmail and wields a large hammer

Nature: Strong, quiet, looming; keeps very still except in combat; enjoys herbal tea; sometimes works as a lieutenant for Aorut or Etranv

Role: Offense

Stats: Melee attacks as level 5; Armor 1 (5 against fire); hammer inflicts 5 points of damage

Equipment: Heavy hammer, 14 shins, *ray emitter (heat)*, *sleep inducer*



VALKA



Gravity nullifier,
page 280

Telepathy implant,
page 287

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Instant shelter,
page 281

Rejuvenator, page 286

Gas bomb (poison),
page 280

Temporal viewer,
page 288



WOZT

3 (9)

Appearance: Well-groomed younger man; missing the little finger on his right hand; wears stylish patched clothing; uses a long metal crowbar like a walking stick

Nature: Strong-willed, refined, vain; hates sleeping outdoors; disgusted by abhumans

Role: Exploration

Stats: Climbing, perception, and stealth as level 4; can sometimes sense through walls

Equipment: Crowbar that can extend or retract an axe blade, 10 shins, *instant shelter*, *rejuvenator* (Might)



ZOLAC

3 (9)

Appearance: Tall, lanky man with long arms and large hands; has many old scars; wears a heavy synth skullcap and carries a crank crossbow

Nature: Clever, cautious, materialistic; insists on being paid for his assistance; generous with children

Role: Offense

Stats: Perception and ranged attacks as level 4; makes two crossbow attacks per round

Equipment: Crank crossbow, 6 shins, *gas bomb (poison)*, *temporal viewer*

WOZT



PART 4: ADDITIONAL RESOURCES



Random Settlement Generator
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RANDOM SETTLEMENT GENERATOR

A numenera ruin on its own can be an interesting place to explore. Adding a social dynamic with a nearby settlement—whether a village, clave, camp, outpost, or similar—can make the ruin even more memorable. Roll on the following tables for quick inspiration about a nearby settlement, disregarding any contrary results that can't be explained with an interesting backstory. Some results here (such as a kind of mutation or type of cypher being common) suggest rolling on the appropriate table in *Numenera Discovery* or *Numenera Destiny* for more information. You can also roll on the [Community Event Table](#) for a current or seasonal situation at the settlement.

Whether the PCs find the ruin or the settlement first can also affect the experience of exploring the ruin.

Many Rumors sections associated with the ruins in this book include one rumor associated with a specific nearby named settlement; you can use the information in this chapter to fill out the details for that settlement so it's unique to your campaign.



Community Event Table,
page 333

Horde, page 292



Clave, page 12

SETTLEMENT TYPE

d100 Results

01–25	Village
26–40	Group of farmsteads
41–50	Military camp
51–55	Military outpost
56–65	Bandit camp
66–70	Refugee/survivor camp
71–75	Abhuman camp
76–80	Abhuman village
81–85	Horde
86–95	Explorer camp
96–00	Clave

PRIMARY SPECIES

This indicates what species most of the settlement's population is. "Near-human" could be an offshoot of humanity or a human population where one or two mutations (such as gills or a third eye) are common.

d100 Results

01–65	Human
66–70	Lattimor or varjellen

71–80	Near-human
81–00	Abhuman or other

DEFAULT INTERACTION

This is the general attitude that the people of the settlement have toward visitors. If the primary species of the settlement is different than that of the PCs, add 20 to the roll; if the settlement is primarily abhumans, add an additional 30 to the roll.

d100 Results

01–10	Welcoming
11–25	Amicable
26–60	Neutral
61–90	Cautious
91+	Hostile

LANGUAGE SPOKEN

This is not necessarily the native language of the settlement, but rather what language the PCs need to use or learn in order to speak with the locals. Most human settlements have a few people who know a little Truth or Shin-Talk even if the general population uses some other language. For settlements outside the Steadfast, add 20 to the roll.

d100 Results

01–80	Truth
81–90	Shin-Talk
91–110	Odd dialect of Truth
111+	Local language unrelated to Truth

LOCAL RESOURCES

Roll once or twice to see what the settlement's primary resources are. Even if the settlement isn't able to trade with others, these resources enable them to survive and thrive in this location. For a short-term settlement such as a camp or horde, add 40 to the roll.

A long-term settlement (such as a village or clave) survives on a mix of food resources—hunting, fishing, livestock, and so on—even if it isn't the primary resource rolled. A short-term settlement (such as a camp or horde) probably brought its own food stores from elsewhere, relies on hunting or raiding, or might lack the resources to survive and be on the brink of starvation.

“Labor” could mean military strength or a sellable workforce such as automatons, beasts, or slaves. “Numenera” means oddities, cyphers, or other devices or processes.

d100 Results

01–15	Crops
16–25	Fishing
26–35	Hunting
36–45	Livestock
46–53	Manufactured goods
54–55	Spices
56–60	Water
61–65	Herbs or medicine
66–75	Minerals

76–90	Labor
91–00	Numenera (oddities, cyphers, and so on)

GOVERNMENT AND LEADERSHIP

Roll once or twice to determine how the settlement is governed and why the authority figures have power (settlements can be an even mix of two aspects, or primarily one aspect with some influence from a second aspect). Abhuman settlements default to whatever leadership that kind of abhuman has (*margr* are led by the strongest tyrant, *sathosh* have family-based communities, and so on).

d100 Result

01–20	Council
21–25	Democracy or republic
26–40	Despot
41–50	Elders
51–60	Militaristic
61–75	Monarchal
76–85	Numenera expertise
86–00	Religious



Margr, page 240

Sathosh, page 251



Installation, page 121



Organizations, page 215

Mutations, page 398

QUIRK

Roll once or twice to find interesting quirks of the people or the settlement itself.

d100 Result

01	Abhorrent practice (such as cannibalism)	31	Illusions or holograms	66	Shuns common numenera
02	Amnesia	32–33	<i>Installation</i> , defensive	67–68	Strange dreams
03	Bounty	34–35	<i>Installation</i> , offensive	69–70	Strange lights
04	Clones	36	Mirror images	71–72	Strange livestock
05–06	Compulsion	37–38	<i>Mutation</i> , beneficial	73	Strong gravity
07–08	Crop circles	39–40	<i>Mutation</i> , cosmetic	74–75	Subterranean location or connection
09	Cult	41–42	<i>Mutation</i> , distinctive	76–77	Suspicious of one PC
10	Damages the ruin	43–44	<i>Mutation</i> , harmful	78	Teleporter
11	Dimensionally displaced	45	<i>Mutation</i> , powerful	79	Temporally displaced
12–13	Drought	46–47	Nightmares	80–81	Tornados
14	Dulled emotions	48–49	Odd smells	82	Unaware of the ruin
15	Earthquakes	50–51	Odd sounds	83	Underwater
16–17	Famine	52–53	<i>Organization</i> connection	84–85	Unusual food or drink
18–19	Fear of the ruin	54–55	People are larger/smaller than normal	86	Unusual holiday
20	Floating	56	Plague	87–88	Unusual plant
21	Flooding	57	Precarious location	89	Volcano or other eruption
22–23	Frequent predators	58	Refuses to talk about the ruin	90	Warlike or aggressive
24	Frequent purge or inquisition	59–60	Religious	91–92	Weak gravity
25	Geyser	61–62	Scavenges the ruin	93–94	Weird installation
26–27	Glimmers	63	Settlement abandoned	95–96	Weird music
28–29	Hallucinations	64	Settlement destroyed	97–98	Weird weather
30	Heightened emotions	65	Settlement preserved	99–00	Worships the ruin

GLOSSARY

Adjacent: In the context of the datasphere, frames can be next to—adjacent to—each other. Dataforms can move between adjacent frames like creatures in the real can move between connected rooms in a house by using a barrier like one uses a door.

Barrier: A travel restriction between two places in the datasphere. Some are little more than a brief pause, some require input (entering a password, solving a puzzle, or completing a game), and some are hazards.

Conduit: A connection between two vertices or nodes in the datasphere.

Daemon: A nonsapient automaton dataform, similar to an *instant servant* cypher, normally used to advise, navigate, assist with tasks, carry messages, or transport objects.

Dataform: An object or creature that has been datascribed.

Datascribe: Transcribing from the real to the datasphere.

Dataspace: Any area within the datasphere. Vertices, frames, nodes, and conduits are dataspaces.

Datasphere: The worldwide wireless network (actually multiple linked networks) that connects a wide variety of devices, satellites, and other machines to store and exchange data.

Entry frame: The frame a traveler arrives in when traveling to a different node. All nodes have at least one entry frame.

Environment: How the interior of a frame looks and feels. No game mechanics are associated with the environment; it's just what creatures in a frame see..

Frame: A dataspace within a node. Frames have interior environments. Usually creatures can't see a frame's contents or environment unless they enter, though some frames have the environment property of being transparent.

Ghost: A machine intelligence in the datasphere, on par with sapient automatons in the real.

Glitch: An aspect of the digital environment that is functioning strangely due to errors, damage, or degradation of the numenera controlling the datasphere. Similar to a mutation in a real creature's body or unstable physics in a real location.

Husk: The remains of a dead datascribed creature; the datasphere equivalent of a corpse.

Node: A large dataspace. A node may be one continuous space or consist of multiple connected or isolated frames.

Real, the: Reality; the physical world known to most creatures of the Ninth World.

Realscribe: Transcribing from the datasphere to the real.

Transcribe: Moving from the real to the datasphere (datascribing) or from the datasphere to the real (realscribing).

Vertice: A place where transcribing to and from the datasphere is possible. A vertice is a physical location, a dataspace, and a specific kind of numenera installation.

Voice: A powerful or even godlike entity of the datasphere. Most voices are ghosts, or were ghosts at some point in their existence.



*Instant servant,
page 281*